

INBRIEF



IIT-M invites applications for School Connect programme

The Indian Institute of Technology-Madras (IIT-M) has opened applications for the October 2026 cohort of its School Connect programme. The programme is intended to expose school students to various academic disciplines and help them make informed choices about their education and career. This year, students of Class IX may also take part, along with the students of Classes X, XI, and XII. Early exposure helps students discover diverse career paths ahead of time, a press release said. The deadline for applications falls on September 30 and the courses commence on October 5. Principals and school administrators may partner with the IIT-M School Connect programme through <https://code.iitm.ac.in/schoolconnect/>.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (September 8, Tuesday), the following articles are available:

■ Are nicotine pouches beyond the law? [newsth.live/lawfornicotinpouches](https://www.thehindu.com/news/national/newsth-live-lawfornicotinpouches)

■ India can cut steel emissions before new coal plants lock them in [newsth.live/greensteel](https://www.thehindu.com/news/national/newsth-live-greensteel)

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Air India Express to suspend flights to four cities from Chennai temporarily

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Air India Express plans to temporarily suspend flights from Chennai to Madurai, Port Blair, Guwahati, and Hyderabad from the end of October.

As a result, IndiGo will be the lone operator of flights to Guwahati, Madurai, and Hyderabad.

After suspending the Chennai-Madurai services, the Air India Express will introduce Bengaluru-Madurai flights.

Airline sources told *The Hindu* that these were 'seasonal cuts' and they might consider resuming the flights later next year, based on the demand. The airline has been focusing on making Bengaluru their hub for various reasons.

Officials of the Airports Author-

Airline sources say these are 'seasonal cuts' and they might resume the flights to Madurai, Guwahati, Port Blair, and Hyderabad next year, based on the demand

ity of India said the demand-supply was driven by opportunities in the State.

Jobs and connectivity

"An airport is a transport hub; we don't generate the demand. If Chennai, like Bengaluru, had as many high-end white-collar jobs that could fuel such demand, our connectivity too would have increased," an official said.

Now, the State government is finally focusing on the creation of

such jobs, and hopefully, the demand will increase, leading to additional connectivity in Chennai, sources said.

"It is good to see we have distributed growth in aviation. But sadly, that is not enough. Unless the capital city stands out with maximum connectivity and growth, it won't help the State. Chennai needs to grow in aviation on a par with Bengaluru and we need a vision for that," an expert in aviation said.

A. Sankar, a frequent flier, said it was disappointing to see the airline temporarily suspend connectivity to some of the cities.

"Passengers need to have quite a few options to fly because that is the way to ensure that the prices remain competitive and affordable," Mr. Shankar said.

☀️🌧️ Timings
CHENNAI

TUESDAY, SEP. 08		
RISE	05:58	SET 18:15
RISE	03:03	SET 16:11
WEDNESDAY, SEP. 09		
RISE	05:58	SET 18:15
RISE	04:04	SET 16:58
THURSDAY, SEP. 10		
RISE	05:58	SET 18:14
RISE	05:01	SET 17:41

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	36	24
Chennai Airport	36	27
Chennai City	35	26

Chennai Airport Today
36°C The weather will be very warm and uneasy. Night will be comfortable. Spell of light rain and thundershower may occur.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
35°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be warm. Night will be comfortable. Spell of moderate rain and thundershower to occur.

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THE HINDU
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T.N. govt. proposes to extend term of Special Officers for rural local bodies

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The State government on Monday introduced a Bill in the Assembly to amend the Tamil Nadu Panchayats Act 1994, so as to extend the term of Special Officers for village panchayats, panchayat union councils, and district panchayats in 28 districts of the State.

According to the Bill, the term of office of the elected representatives expired on January 5, 2025.

The districts excluded are Kancheepuram, Chengalpattu, Villupuram, Kallakurichi, Vellore, Ranipet, Tirupattur, Tirunelveli, and Tenkasi.

The elections to the said rural local bodies

The govt. moves a Bill to amend the Tamil Nadu Panchayats Act 1994 so as to extend the term of Special Officers in 28 districts

could not be conducted before the said process due to the non-completion of the process of delimitation and reservation of wards.

The term of the Special Officers was extended from time to time, with the last extension done on July 5, 2026.

Subsequently, the government issued orders extending the term of Special Officers from July 6 to October 19. The Bill seeks to give effect to the above decision.

CINEMA • ARTS • EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

Arulmigu Sri Kapaleeswarar Temple, Mylapore, Chennai
Today (08-09-2026) Tuesday 6:45 P.M - Aimbhozhil Vallaan PRADHOSHAM Special NAMASANKERTHANAM by Kum. Rasiga Devi Prasadh & Team. All Are Welcome.

Gana Mukundhapriya 9444076899
Today 6.30 p.m. at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Mylapore. Tribute to Dikshitar 250 by Prof. S Venkateswararan, Dr. Usha Raja gopalan, Madipakkam Suresh, Madipakkam Murali, Madipakkam Gopalakrishnan & R Raman. All are welcome.

Naada Inbam, 24992672
Dr. Baby Sreeram, Bombay Madhavan, B Sivaraman. Today 5 p.m at Ragasudha Hall.

Sri Thyaga Brahma Gana Sabha (Regd) Vani Mahal.
Ph: 28152166
In association with NIPPO INDO NATIONAL LIMITED Dedicated to the memory of Sri P. Obul Reddy and Smt. P. Gnanambika. Today 4.30 p.m Namasankertanam by Students of DAV School Adambakkam, Chennai. 6.30 p.m Vocal Concert by Ms. Sruthi S Bhat, Ms. Shree Lakshmi S. Bhat (Violin), Sri. M.S. Venkatasubramanian (Mridangam). All are welcome.

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The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 52-year-old autorickshaw driver died after being hit by a suburban electric train while he was crossing the tracks at Vandalur Railway Station on Sunday.

The Government Railway Police (GRP) officials said the incident took place when Palani, from Lakshmi Nagar in Urapakkam, was returning home after visiting his friend in Vandalur.

Palani had parked his autorickshaw on the GST Road

Special commission to identify Panchami lands soon: Minister

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government will soon constitute a special commission to identify Panchami lands across the State, Social Justice Minister Vanni Arasu told the Assembly on Monday.

Responding to CPI MLA K. Marimuthu's demand for a separate board to recover the lands, during the debate on the Demands for Grants, the Minister said the proposed commission would be more effective than the panels previously constituted to identify and protect Panchami lands.

Mr. Vanni Arasu said the issue dates back to 1891, when the then Chengalpattu Collector identified the lands and wrote to the Queen of England.

Subsequently, two government orders were issued, allocating around 12 lakh acres of wasteland exclusively for tribal communities, he said.

1996 committee

The Minister said a committee was constituted in 1996 – towards the end of the then AIADMK government – to identify Panchami lands, on the directions of then Revenue Minister. However, the initiative subsequently lost momentum. Later, based on a recom-



Vanni Arasu

mendation from the Vidthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi, former Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi constituted another committee, but it too remained pending, the Minister further said.

Following a court judgment in 2015, when Jayalithaa was Chief Minister, yet another committee was constituted to identify Panchami lands, Mr. Vanni Arasu said.

'Just 1.86 lakh acres left'
"According to information obtained under the Right to Information Act, while 12 lakh acres of Panchami land existed earlier, only 1.86 lakh acres remain now," he said.

The government would constitute a special commission to identify the remaining Panchami lands and take steps for their protection, he added.

Autorickshaw driver dies after being hit by train

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PERSONAL
ANNOUNCEMENTS

I, M.R.T Prabu F/o Sarah Agnes Prabu, New No.20, Old No.67, Anna Street, Thiruvanniyur, Ch - 41, would like to inform that I have changed my daughter's Name from Sarah Agnes to Sarah Agnes Prabu (Reg.No. 8681413, year 2024 - 25)

PERSONAL
CHANGE OF NAME

I, RAFIQ Meraj AR, S/o, Abdul Rahman, Date of Birth: 04.05.1983, residing at T181, Kattabomman Street, Pari Nagar, Jafferkhanpet, Chennai- 600083, shall henceforth be known as Rafiq Mehraj AR. S/o. Abdul Rahaman.

CHANGE OF NAME

I, MANICKAM PADMANABAN s/o. Manickam, Hindu, DOB: 28.06.1963 r/o. Flat no F3, First floor, Ruby Block, Venus Garden, 1/2, Bharathi Street, Lalithambal Nagar, Thirumullaivoyal, Chennai - 600062 shall henceforth be known as M. Padmanabhan. The name Manickam Padmanaban and M.Padmanabhan are one and the same person.

CHANGE OF NAME

I, ANTHONY Fernando Louisgerald s/o Louis Fernando born on 29/07/1969 residing at A4, Balaji Enclave, 12, Subramaniyapuram 2nd Street, Kolathur, Chennai 600099 have changed my name to Gerald Antony Fernando vide affidavit dated 28/08/2026 at Chennai.

CHANGE OF NAME

I, MAHALAKSHMI Padmanabhan residing at 27/2, Second Street, SVS Nagar Annexe, Valasaravakkam, Chennai -600087 widow of late Army Personnel No:7131010F Rank: Havildar Name: S.Padmanabhan declare that my name has been wrongly recorded as Mhalakshmi in my husband's Army Service Records and Pension Payment Order (PPO) No: Original PPO/Corrigendum No:3 PPO No: 240196 500242/e- PPO NO: 1801966 00041. I hereby declare that Mhalakshmi and Mahalakshmi Padmanabhan are the names of one and the same person, i.e., myself. Vide affidavit dated 5/9/2026 Chennai, in future, I shall be known only by my correct name: Mahalakshmi Padmanabhan.

I, Dhinakaran Kingsley Samuel S/O, Selwyn N R/o 33, Veera Chowk Street, Ramana Nagar, Perambur, Chennai - 600011 have changed my name to Dhinakaran S.

I, TARUN Girish s/o Girish Thekkethil r/o 4B, Fourth Floor, No 18, Manikeshwari Road Kilpaik, Chennai, Tamil Nadu-600010, declare that my name has been wrongly written as Tarun G in my 12th marksheet and Pan Card, name of my father as Girish in my Aadhar card. My and father's correct name is Tarun Girish and Girish Thekkethil.

GOVERNMENT OF TAMILNADU
WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT
PENNAIYAR BASIN CIRCLE, TIRUVANNAMALAI – 606 603.
e-Tender Notice No. 01 / PBC / TVMALAI / 2026 / Dated : 07.09.2026
Lumpsum Contract (Two Cover System)
For and on behalf of the Governor of Tamil Nadu, the Superintending Engineer, WRD, Pennaiyar Basin Circle, Tiruvannamalai – 3, invites ONLINE tenders under "Two Cover System" through online for the under mentioned work from the eligible tenderers as prescribed in the website.

Sl. No.	Name of Work	Approximate Value put to Tender (including GST) Rs. in Lakh	Last date and time of submission of Tender (as per Server Clock)	Date and time of Tender opening (as per Server Clock)	Period of Completion (including Rainy Season)
1.	Comprehensive Flood Protection works for Flood Bank Formation and Construction of Head Regulators in North Malattar River in Villupuram Taluk and District.	Rs. 2912.00	13.10.2026 upto 15.00 Hrs.	14.10.2026 at 15.30 Hrs.	12 Months

The tender document and other details will be available in the website <https://tntenders.gov.in> to enable the tenderers to view and download the e-tender document thro' online at free of cost and submission of Tenders shall be done only through online.
NOTE :
i) It is the responsibility of the tenderer to check any Corrigendum issued for any correction or modification uploaded subsequently in website, the same shall be taken into account while submitting tender.
ii) The Tender Authority does not take any responsibility for the delay/non-submission of tender/ non-reconciliation of online payment caused due to non-availability of internet connection, network traffic/holidays or any other reasons.
iii) Tender may be cancelled at any stage by competent authority.
iv) Cost of EMD will be paid through online mode only.
Superintending Engineer, WRD.,
Pennaiyar Basin Circle, Tiruvannamalai – 3.
DIPR/ 2764 /Tender/2026

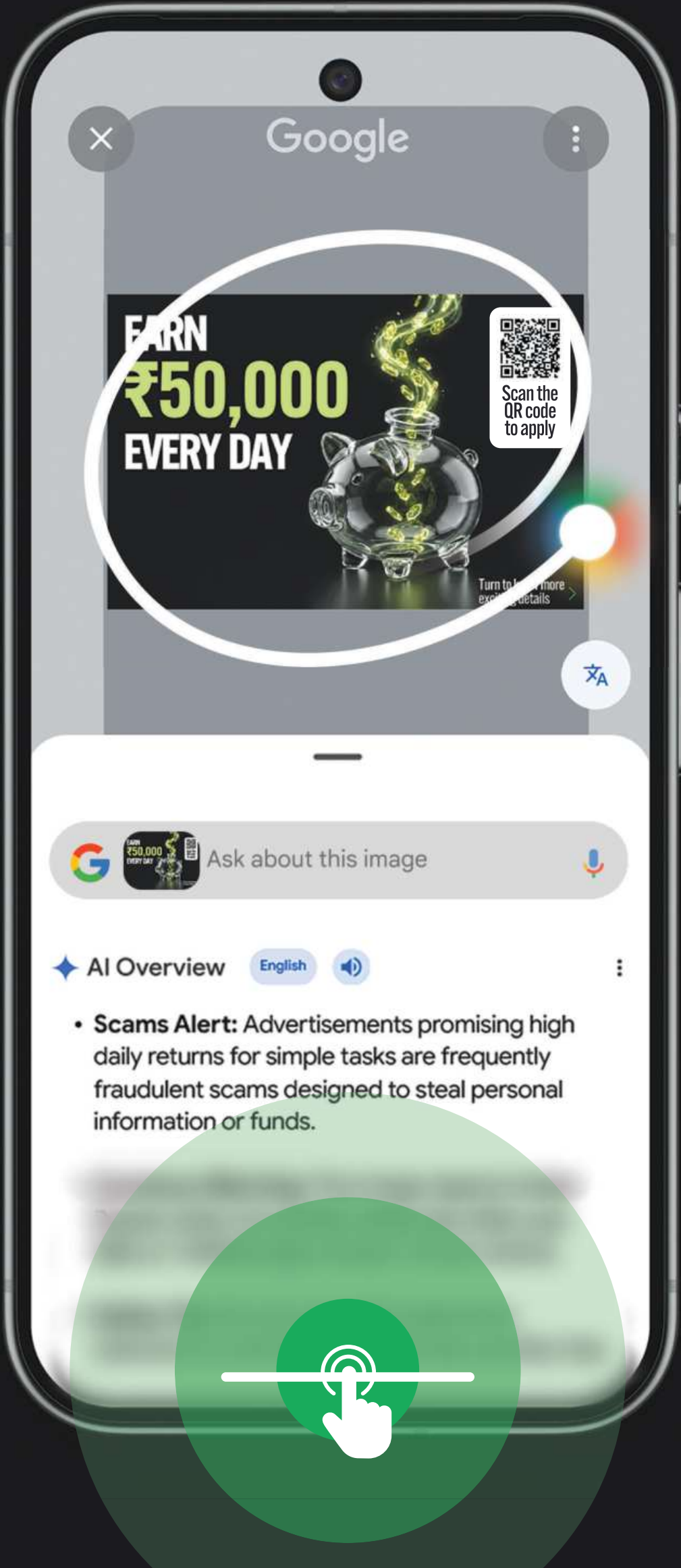
GOVERNMENT OF TAMIL NADU
MUNICIPAL ADMINISTRATION AND WATER SUPPLY DEPARTMENT
Directorate of Municipal Administration, Chennai-28. Tel: 044-29864447
Notice for Inviting Tender (NIT)
(Roc.No.616/2026/UPA, Date:02.09.2026)
1. Tenders are invited from eligible bidders for engaging a Manpower Outsourcing Agency for the hiring of one State Mission Manager and 83 City Mission Managers.
2. The tender value from is **Rs.2313.60 lakhs**.
3. The details of tender can be obtained from web portal: <https://tntenders.gov.in>
4. The tender document can be downloaded from **10.09.2026 to 14.10.2026** through the E-tendering Website <https://tntenders.gov.in>
5. Pre-Bid meeting will be held on **23.09.2026 at 3.00 P.M** at the Directorate of Municipal Administration office.
6. The last date for uploading / submission of filled up tender is up to **3.00 P.M on 14.10.2026**.
7. The tenders will be opened through online at **3.30 P.M on 14.10.2026** at the Directorate of Municipal Administration office.
8. The value of tender of Earnest Money Deposit and the eligibility of bidders can be had from tender document.
CHIEF ENGINEER, CHENNAI - 28
DIPR/2767/TENDER/2026

Does this offer sound unreal? It might just be.

How to spot a scam:

Step 1

Long press the
home button



Step 2

Circle to Search
over the suspicious
offer or SMS

Avoid scams with Circle to Search



Disclaimer: Internet connection required. Works on compatible apps, surfaces, and Circle to Search compatible devices. Results may vary depending on visual matches. Image simulated, actual may vary. Actual UX/UI and color may vary. Color and feature as per availability.

INBRIEF



26-year-old killed in accident involving TVK Minister's car

A 26-year-old man was killed after a car belonging to Social Welfare and Women Empowerment Minister Jagadeshwari K. hit the two-wheeler he was riding at Kattankulathur near Chennai in the early hours of Monday. The deceased has been identified as Iraiyanbu. The accident occurred at the Kattankulathur junction. The Minister was coming to Chennai to attend the Assembly session. She was travelling in a government vehicle, followed by an escort vehicle and her personal car. The Minister's personal car allegedly hit the two-wheeler, killing him on the spot. The Maraimalai Nagar Traffic Investigation Wing seized the car. The police arrested the driver, Chinna Agni, of Madurai.



AAI to install sanitary napkin vending machines at airport

The Airports Authority of India (AAI) will install sanitary napkin vending machines at Chennai airport soon. Officials of AAI said the work had already been awarded to a firm and the installation of the machines will begin shortly. "Sanitary napkins are already available in the terminals and signages are placed in the washrooms and frisking booths. If a passenger asks, it will be provided within two minutes," an official said. This aside, AAI plans to install vending machines soon, he added.

Southern Railway proposes to increase tracks at Tambaram

The Railways is planning to increase the number of tracks from 10 to 15 for operating more long distance trains from Tambaram station. It would help to ease congestion at the Egmore station

TRACK TALES

R. Srikanth
CHENNAI

The Tambaram railway station could well become the second biggest train operational facility in the city as Southern Railway proposes to have 15 tracks. At present, track development and platform extension work is under progress, and is expected to be completed by the end of March next year.

The Chennai division of Southern Railway has proposed to increase the number of railway tracks from 10 to 15 for operating more long distance trains from the railway station.

Transport hub

Once the proposal is cleared, the Tambaram railway station, which has been announced as the third railway terminal in the city, would overtake Egmore railway station, and could well become the transport hub for operating trains towards southern parts of the State and also towards the north corridor.

A senior official of Southern Railway, sharing details of the track development work and the various passenger amenities being set up in the third railway terminal, said the Chennai division has proposed to increase the track



Major project: The Rail Land Development Authority is preparing the detailed project report for executing the redevelopment of the railway terminal in Tambaram station. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

lines from 10 to 15, and once the project is cleared, it would help in easing the operational congestion at Egmore railway station.

"At present, Egmore railway station is undergoing redevelopment. The second footover bridge (FOB) construction on the north side of the Tambaram railway station would also be completed by March next year, with access facilities, along with circulating areas, to be created on both sides of the station. On the east side, a new road, creating access to commuters to the FOB has been initiated and would be linked to Bharathamatha Road," the official said.

Passenger amenities

Along with the track expansion work, Southern Railway is also creating various passenger amenities,

including construction of waiting halls, installation of escalators and elevators, connecting the new FOB with all the platforms. All these infrastructure work is being carried out at a cost of ₹19 crore.

The Tambaram railway station, having been designated as category '1' railway station, sees more than 3.50 crore commuters every year. However, hundreds of commuters, particularly senior citizens, have been facing severe difficulties in accessing the platforms, where long distance trains are operated or halted.

Consumer activist T. Sadagopan said that the new FOB, being constructed on the north side of the railway station, has been progressing slowly. "As most of the long distance trains are being operated or halted at platforms 7 and 8, which

are quite narrow, it causes severe inconvenience to passengers, as they have to carry heavy luggage to use the old FOB. Though a limited number of battery cars are available, senior citizens have to wait for several minutes for their turn.

Booking counter

The senior railway official said an elevated booking counter is proposed for getting tickets in the new FOB, along with a waiting hall. The Southern Railway has proposed to install nine elevators and 10 escalators with lifts connecting all the platforms in the railway station.

The Rail Land Development Authority is preparing the detailed project report for executing the massive redevelopment of the railway terminal in Tambaram station.

'Chennai has been a guardian through every stage of my life'

I first came to Chennai in 1996 to prepare for the postgraduate medical entrance examination, the city soon became the place where my professional and personal life took shape.

After three-and-a-half years of rural service, I returned to Chennai to join Madras Medical College for my MS in General Surgery. My wife was also pursuing her postgraduate training in Anaesthesia at the college.

We were both building our careers and starting a family, and Chennai became our home.

I continued at Madras Medical College for my MCh in Vascular Surgery and later worked there as an Assistant Professor. Later, I headed the Department of Vascular Surgery at Government Stanley Medical College Hospital.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, I was deputed to the Directorate of Medical Education and was in-



K. Elancheralathan, Head of the Department of Vascular Surgery, Government Stanley Medical College Hospital.

volved in health administration. I returned to Stanley in 2022 and resumed clinical work and teaching.

After nearly three decades, Chennai has remained a constant in my life. I came here as a young man preparing for an entrance examination. Today, Chennai is where I have built my career, my family and my life. (As told to Athira Elssa Johnson)



From the archives: A Russian ballet performance at the Music Academy, Madras, sponsored by the Indian Council for Cultural Relations on

November 8, 1979. This photo and more are on display at The Hindu Made of Chennai Archival Photo Exhibit as part of Madras Month celebrations. The exhibition will be on at The Hindu office till September 14 and is open to the public from 10 a.m. to 6.30 p.m. on all days, except Sundays. To visit, register for free at <https://madeofchennai.thehindu.com/>

Jeddah-bound flight makes emergency landing at airport due to technical issue

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A Malaysian Airlines aircraft from Kuala Lumpur to Jeddah made an emergency landing at Chennai airport on Monday due to a technical issue with one of the engines.

Officials of Airports Authority of India (AAI) said the flight departed with 186 passengers from Kuala Lumpur at 3.30

An Air India Express from Tiruchi to Singapore was also diverted to Chennai

p.m., and a little later, when the pilot suspected that the engine number two was malfunctioning, he requested the Air Traffic Control (ATC) at Chennai airport permission for landing.

The authorities made all the necessary safety arrangements, and the flight made an emergency landing at the airport at 4.40 p.m.

The passengers were de-boarded safely and have been given accommodation, an official said. "The aircraft is grounded now and the airline is making arrangements for an alternative flight. But it is not clear yet when the flight

will depart from the airport," he added.

An Air India Express from Tiruchi to Singapore was also diverted to Chennai on Monday due to a technical issue. The flight, with 179 passengers, left from Tiruchi at 4.45 p.m., and after a technical glitch was detected, it landed safely at 5.52 p.m. and vacated the runway on its own power. Officials said an inspection is under way.

Burst in major pipeline disrupts supply of water in north Chennai, repair works on



Work has commenced to dig the stretch of the GNT Road to replace the damaged portion of the pipeline with a new one.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Piped water supply to various north Chennai areas would be temporarily stopped as work is in progress to repair damages in a major pipeline on GNT Road.

Following a burst in a major pipeline carrying drinking water from Puzhal water treatment plant in the early hours of Mon-

day, Chennai Metrowater has commenced repair work on the damaged section on GNT Road.

A press release said various places in north Chennai, including Vadaperumbakkam, Kosapur, and Chettimedu in zone 2, wards 25, 26, 28 to 31 in zone 3, all areas covered by Patel Nagar distribution station in zone 4, and wards 71 and 72 in zone 6, will not receive piped wa-

ter supply till 10 p.m. on September 9.

Work has commenced to dig the stretch of the GNT Road to replace the damaged portion of the pipeline, which is 1,200 mm in diameter, with a new one.

Additional tankers

Additional water tankers would be deployed to provide water supply to affected areas, said the release.

Posts of District Entomologist remain vacant in over 40 Health Unit Districts in the State

Serena Josephine M.
CHENNAI

With dengue cases on the rise, the post of District Entomologists is lying vacant in more than 40 of the 45 Health Unit Districts (HUD) in the State. District Entomologists play a critical role in vector-borne disease control, and the existing vacancies may adversely impact the planning and monitoring of dengue control activities.

According to the Tamil Nadu Public Health Entomologists Association, 48 posts of the total 60 sanctioned posts of Senior Entomologists were vacant in the State. As a result, more than 40 HUDs were functioning without a District Malaria Officer/District Entomologist/Senior Entomologist. Each HUD has one District Entomologist, while there are senior entomologist positions in government medical colleges and at the Directorate of Public Health (DPH) and Preventive Medicine.

A DPH source said the vacant posts of District Entomologists is one of the most serious concerns. "Entomologists play a critical role in as-



The vacancies may adversely impact planning and monitoring of dengue control activities. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

sessing mosquito density, breeding patterns, vector indices, and the effectiveness of control measures. A severe shortage of technical manpower inevitably raises questions about whether vector control operations are being guided by adequate scientific assessment," he said.

He said that dengue control cannot be reduced to fogging and chemical application. "Without strong entomological surveillance, vector control risks becoming activity-driven rather than evidence-driven," he said.

In fact, the association had already urged the State go-

vernment and the Tamil Nadu Public Service Commission (TNPSC) to urgently fill the vacant District Entomologist posts, saying that the shortage could affect vector-borne disease surveillance and control, particularly ahead of the Northeast monsoon.

It had raised the issue in July and submitted representations to the TNPSC, Health Secretary and DPH. The posts have remained vacant since 2024-2025 after no eligible candidates were available for promotion. Subsequently, the DPH proposed direct recruitment through TNPSC to fill 33 Senior Entomologist vacancies.

The TNPSC conducted the written examination under the Combined Technical Services Examination in July 2025 and completed the interviews in March 2026. Though the candidates' marks were published, the final selection list is yet to be released as some candidates had approached the court over grievances relating to the recruitment. As a result, the vacancies, now numbering more than 40 across HUDs, remain unfilled.

The association said District Entomologists play a crucial role in vector-borne disease surveillance, prevention, monitoring and control, and assist District Health Officers for better implementation of the programme.

With climate change contributing to the spread of diseases such as dengue, malaria, chikungunya, and scrub typhus, the shortage of entomologists has affected district-level planning and monitoring, the association said. It warned that the upcoming northeast monsoon could further increase the risk of seasonal and vector-borne diseases.

The association urged the TNPSC to expedite the pending court cases and release the final results at the earliest. It also requested the State government and DPH to immediately fill the vacant posts to strengthen disease surveillance and control measures. It also pointed out that the TNPSC had notified another 13 Senior Entomologist posts for 2025-26.

Officials of the DPH could not be reached for their response.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

OBITUARY


We are deeply saddened to inform the untimely demise of **BV VIDYANDH** from LIC Colony, Adyar, on September 7th, 2026. He is survived by all members of his family and will be remembered as the generous, brilliant and spiritual person he was. Contact: Sanjay (Nephew) 98409 42896

DEATH


Fr. Emmanuel Arockiam, S.J. (11.12.1955 - 07.09.2026)
It is with deep sorrow that the family of Fr. Emmanuel Arockiam, S.J. announces his peaceful passing on 7th September 2026.
Funeral Mass: 10:30 a.m., 8th September 2026 Christ the King Church, Loyola College Nungambakkam, Chennai - 600 054
Please keep Fr. Emmanuel and our family in your prayers. "I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith." - 2 Timothy 4:7 The Family

DEATH

ATTAINED DIVINITY


08.06.1944 - 07.09.2026
K MAHADEVAN
Retd. Advisor, DoT Lovingly remembered by Wife: RAJESWARI Sons: Nagabhushan & Sriram. Final Rites : 09.09.2026, 9:00 a.m., Chennai **Ct.94980 50767**

In memory of 
Rajiv Krishnamurthy 23/9/1956 - 7/9/2026 Beloved friend, family member and idiosyncratic person. He will be deeply missed. Funeral on 8/9/26 at 11:00 am, Besant Nagar. Cortege will leave at 10:00 am from 9/5 Janaki Avenue, Abhiramapuram 4th St, Chennai 600018. Eyes donated.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

FIRST DEATH ANNIVERSARY


Tearfull homage to **Mrs. P. KOMALAVALLI** Msc., PhD. DOB:23.10.1978 DOD:08.09.2025 Beloved Husband: M. Selvakumar, M.Tech. Daughter: S. Dhanishtaa, Son: S. Sanjaivadhan, Father: P. Palanichamy, Mother: P. Krishnammal, Brother: P. Bhagavathi Raja, Sister: Dr. P. Dhanalakshmi.

13th ANNIVERSARY


M. GEETHA B.Sc. B.L., Advocate "You still live in our hearts" D/o. Late Justice Maheshwaran With Fond remembrance D. Thirumorthy B.E., Mother: P. Madan Ganesha B.E., Proprietor GEE Network Systems, T. Hemavardhini a.Tech., Prop & CEO CHAHub

BIRTHDAY REMEMBRANCE

80th BIRTHDAY REMEMBRANCE 08.09.1946 
Thiru. M.A.K. BALAKRISHNAN Chairman & Managing Trustee **KRISHNASWAMY** Educational Trust Nungambakkam, Ch-34. **IN FOND MEMORY** M.A.K. Family Members, Staff & Students of **SHRI KRISHNASWAMY** GROUP OF SCHOOLS & **SHRI KRISHNASWAMY COLLEGE** FOR WOMEN, CHENNAI.

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INBRIEF



Conference on bioinformatics, computational biology held

SRM Medical College Hospital and Research Centre hosted a three-day bioinformatics and computational biology conference covering developments in modern life sciences. Titled IndiBioCom 2026, the conference featured experts and speakers from leading academic and research institutions, including K. Thangaraj, CSIR-Centre for Cellular and Molecular Biology, Hyderabad, and G.P.S. Raghava, Director, IIT Delhi. R. Jayanthi, dean (Medical), SRM Medical College Hospital and Research Centre, highlighted the importance of bringing computational science and clinical medicine together. Sunil K. Narayan, dean, also spoke.

Bill to provide vehicles to legislators introduced in T.N. Assembly

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government has introduced a Bill in the Assembly to amend the Tamil Nadu Payment of Salaries Act so as to provide a vehicle to every MLAs and other allowances.

On August 19, Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay announced on the floor of the Assembly that a vehicle will be provided to every legislator to enable them to effectively render public service and discharge their duties in their respective constituencies.

Allowance hikes
Mr. Vijay had also announced that the vehicle allowance payable to every MLA would be enhanced from ₹25,000 to ₹75,000 per month and a personal assistance allowance of ₹25,000 per month would be sanctioned to them.
For the implementation of the above announcement, the State government has decided to amend the Tamil Nadu Payment of Salaries Act 1951 and introduced the Bill in the Assembly.



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Tender No.785

Date : 07.09.2026

Date Extension Notice-3
Due to unavoidable circumstances, due dates in respect of online Bid Identification No.T-01/EE(Solar)/2026-27 are revised as follows:
Last Date /Time of Receipt of : 15:09-2026 upto 16:00 Hrs.
bid on the portal
Last Date /Time of submission of : 18:09-2026 upto 12:00 Hrs.
bid in Office
Date of opening of the bid on website : 18:09-2026 from 13:00 Hrs.
All other details and terms & conditions shall remain same. Detail of subsequent addendum/corrigendum/cancellation etc. may be obtained from the website.
Further details can be seen from the e-procurement portal <http://uktenders.gov.in>.

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Government of India
Ministry of Finance - Income Tax Department
Office of The Principal Chief Commissioner of Income Tax, Tamil Nadu & Puducherry
Ponni Block, 121, Mahatma Gandhi Road, Nungambakkam, Chennai - 600034
Fax: 6(4)/Estt./Steno Gr.I/PO/2026, Dated 03.09.2026
E-Mail: chennai.cdci.hq.admin@incometax.gov.in Telephone: 044-28338510

Advertisement for appointment of '146' posts of Stenographer Gr.I on deputation basis in Income Tax Department, Tamil Nadu & Puducherry.

Income Tax Department, Tamil Nadu & Puducherry invites application for '146' posts of Stenographer Gr.I on deputation basis from willing and eligible officials fulfilling the following eligibility criteria:-

Name of the post	Mode of recruitment	Vacancy	Salary	Applicability	Max. Age limit
(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Stenographer Gr.I	Deputation	146* (One hundred and forty six) *Vacancy exists in different stations of Tamil Nadu & Puducherry	Level-6 as per 7th Pay Commission in the pay matrix of Rs. 35400-112400	Officers holding the post of Stenographer under the Central Government; (i) Holding analogous post on regular basis in the parent cadre or department; or (ii) With ten years' regular service in Pay Level-4 in the pay matrix (Rs.25500-81100) or equivalent.	56 years

2.The detailed terms and conditions, eligibility criteria for appointment on deputation basis and proforma application may be seen on Income Tax website www.incometax.gov.in. The terms of deputation will be governed by DoPT OM No.6/8/2009-Estt.(Pay.II), dated 17.06.2010 and amended from time to time.
3. Interested eligible officials may send their applications in the prescribed proforma, along with the documents mentioned in the vacancy circular available on the Income Tax website, through proper channel so as to reach the Commissioner of Income Tax (Admn & TPS), O/o PCCIT, Tamil Nadu & Puducherry, Ponni Block, 121, Mahatma Gandhi Road, Nungambakkam, Chennai-600 034 on or before 30.10.2026.

sd/-

(Keerthi Narayan P)

Joint Commissioner of Income Tax (Hqrs.) (Admn. & TPS)

O/o PCCIT, Tamil Nadu & Puducherry, Chennai

Inquiry on into ₹4-crore cheating complaint against C. Vijayabaskar, police tell High Court

AIADMK's Alangudi constituency candidate had accused the ex-Minister of borrowing ₹4.5 cr. from him to prove that he could meet poll expenses and promising that he would return it after the declaration of candidature. However, Vijayabaskar returned only ₹50 lakh despite multiple requests

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Illuppur police in Pudukottai district on Monday informed the Madras High Court that they had summoned the AIADMK candidate for Alangudi, Dhana Vimal, for an inquiry into a complaint lodged by him after reportedly giving ₹4.5 crore to former Minister C. Vijayabaskar (now in the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam) to prove his ability to meet election expenses.
Justice V. Lakshminarayanan recorded the submission made by Addition-

al Public Prosecutor (APP) Arun Anbumani that the Illuppur police had summoned the complainant for a preliminary inquiry on August 28, 2026, but he had sought time till September 10. The judge recorded the submission and directed the police to report the progress to the court by September 15.
The submission was made during the hearing of a writ petition (criminal) filed by the complainant seeking a direction to the police to register a First Information Report (FIR). According to the petitioner, after he had sought nomi-



C. Vijayabaskar

nation from the AIADMK to contest from the Alangudi Assembly constituency, Mr. Vijayabaskar called him up on November 11, 2025, and asked him to ar-

The judge recorded the submission and directed the police to report the progress of the probe to the court by Sept. 15

range for ₹5 crore to prove that he could meet the election expenses.
The complainant also claimed that Mr. Vijayabaskar, who was the then Pudukottai district secretary of the AIADMK, promised that he would return the money immediately after the declaration of candidature. Accordingly, the peti-

tioner arranged for ₹4.5 crore through various sources and supposedly handed it over to a contractor named Sothupalai Murugesan at the latter's office in Pudukottai on March 11, 2026.
Subsequently, after the announcement of Mr. Vimal as the AIADMK candidate for Alangudi, Mr. Vijayabaskar returned only ₹50 lakh. The rest of the money was never returned despite multiple requests, the complainant said, alleging that he was not paid another ₹10 lakh, which was promised in return for mortgaging his father's im-

movable property to another individual associated with the former Minister.
The petitioner said he met Mr. Vijayabaskar on 14 occasions and demanded the return of his money, but it was not forthcoming at all. "The third respondent [Mr. Vijayabaskar] is now adopting a threatening and intimidating attitude whenever I demand my money and documents. The third respondent is a politically influential person and has subsequently joined the ruling party," his affidavit read.

P. Shanmugam condemns Vijay for remarks on Stalin during his speech in Assembly

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

CPI(M) State secretary P. Shanmugam on Monday took strong exception to Chief Minister C. Joseph Vi-

jay's remarks in the Assembly on DMK president M.K. Stalin, accusing him of body-shaming the DMK president over the broken jaw he suffered during his detention under the MISA,

when Emergency was imposed in India.
"The country knows the history of the struggles to protect democracy and the repressive measures and excesses unleashed during

the Emergency. Mr. Stalin was brutally attacked by the police, and his jaw was broken. It is condemnable, however great they may be, to ridicule him. The act of the Chief Minister is ir-

responsible," Mr. Shanmugam said in a post on X.
Mr. Shanmugam, whose party provides outside support to the ruling TVK, said:"Instead of speaking about issues concerning

the people, his reply targeted the principal Opposition party. When all democratic organisations are under the clutches of the Enforcement Directorate, levelling allegations made

by the agency is not appropriate," Mr. Shanmugam said. He added that it was against the ethics of the Assembly to use the House to eulogise individuals and launch personal attacks.



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A1/1 Industrial Area, Ferozabad 282303, www.cdgitindia.net

4 DAYS GOVERNMENT CERTIFICATE COURSE ON

AI DATA SCIENCE

Course Duration (ONLINE) 4 Days

Date: 12 & 13 and 19 & 20 Sept. 2026

Time: 3:00 PM to 5:00 PM

Course Content: Data Science & AI, ML vs AI vs Deep Learning, Data Science lifecycle, types of data Machine learning - supervised, unsupervised, regression, algorithms for finance, medical fields GenAI - LLM, RAG, deep learning, transformers Agentic AI development and examples

Fees : Rs.3,540/- (Study material in soft copy shall be provided)

Coordinator: 8603769900, 9818528498, 8168984069

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA CERTIFICATE WILL BE AWARDED



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A1/1 Industrial Area, Ferozabad 282303, www.cdgitindia.net

2 DAYS GOVERNMENT TRAINING ON

PROJECT MANAGEMENT PROFESSIONAL (PMP)

Course Duration (ONLINE) 2 Days

Date: 12 & 19 September 2026

Time: 4:30 PM to 8:30 PM

Course Content: Project Management Basics, Project Integration Management, The Project Management Framework, Project Scope Management, Project Time Management, Project Cost Management, Human Resource Management, Project Risk Management, Project Quality Management, Project Procurement Management, Project Communications Management, Project Stakeholder Management, Professional Responsibilities, More Topic.

Fees : Rs.3,540/- (Study material in soft copy shall be provided)

Coordinator: 9818676612, 9818528498, 8168984069

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA CERTIFICATE WILL BE AWARDED



STATE INDUSTRIES PROMOTION CORPORATION OF TAMIL NADU LIMITED
19-A, RUKMANI LAKSHMIPATHY ROAD, EGMORE, CHENNAI-600 008.
CIN : U74999TN19715GC005967

(Online Only)

Dated: 07.09.2026

Tender Notice NIT.No.24/CD/T.No.24/2026-27

For and on behalf of State Industries Promotion Corporation of Tamil Nadu Limited, tenders are invited under "Single Cover System" through online only for the following work from Class – IV and above Civil Contractors registered in PWD / Highways / Any Department of Government of Tamil Nadu, Central Government Department, Tamil Nadu State Government Undertaking having experience in similar nature of works. Tenders will be received upto 15.30 Hrs (as per server system clock) on 28.09.2026 and the same will be opened at 15.30 Hrs (as per server system clock) on 29.09.2026.

Name of Work	Approx. Value of work	EMD
Extension of 18m wide road, construction of RCC storm water drain with footpath, street light system, Thermoplastic lane marking with road studs from M/s. Rajaratan Global wire entrance to boundary of M/s. Keynes circles Pvt. Ltd. at Phase-II, SIPCOT Industrial Park Vallam Vadagal, Kancheepuram District.	Rs.132.00 Lakhs (including GST @18%)	Rs. 76,000/-*

* EMD should be paid through online in the portal (<https://tntenders.gov.in>) or through eBG (as per the list of banks attached in Annexure-II)

The tender schedule can be downloaded at free of cost from the website <https://tntenders.gov.in>

DIPR / 2776 / Tender / 2026

SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER

S. E. RAILWAY – TENDER

Dy Chief Mechanical Engineer (Carriage Works), acting for and on behalf of President of India invites E-Tender.

E-Tender Notice No: KGPW-CW-AMDBSAMCFT-26-28; **Name of work:** Comprehensive Annual Maintenance Contract for Axle Mounted Disc Brake System of LHB Coaches (FTRTL Make); **Place of Work:** Kharagpur Workshop, South Eastern Railway, Post-Kharagpur, Dist-Paschim Midnapore, Pin-721301; **Quantity:** As per tender document. **Tender Value:** ₹71,73,24,254.10; **Earnest Money:** ₹1,43,46,500.00; **Contract period:** 24 Months from the date of issue of LOA; **Closing Date and Time of Tender:** At 26/09/2026 11:00 Hrs.; **Cost of Tender Document:** NIL; **Bidding System:** Single Packet System; **Contract Type:** Works — General; **Tender Type:** Single; **Detail Tender Notice and Tender Document** is available in the e-Portal website <https://www.ireps.gov.in> (PR-730)

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PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby informed to the general public at large that we are investigating the title to land parcel admeasuring an extent of **5.645 acres** comprised in the following survey numbers situated in Block No. 0027, Ward – D, Periyakuppam village, Thiruvallur Taluk, Thiruvallur District, and situated within Registration District of Thiruvallur and Sub-Registration District of Thiruvallur (hereinafter referred to as the "Schedule Property") standing in the name of **Spectra Perfect Realtors Private Limited**.

Sl. No.	Old Survey No.	Present TSLR No.	Extent (in acres)
1.	789 Part	18/3A	1.44
2.	790/12	18/2C	0.21
3.	789/PT	18/3B	0.72
4.	790/10	18/5	0.24
5.	790/11		0.20
6.	790/2		0.17
7.	790/3	18/46	0.16
8.	790/4		0.17
9.	790/1		0.34 ½
10.	790/5		0.21
11.	790/9		0.45
12.	790/9	18/2B	0.45
13.	790/6		0.21
14.	790/7		0.22
15.	790/8		0.45
Total			5.64 ½

Any person(s) or entity(ies) (a) having, claiming or asserting to have any rights, title, demands and/or interests in respect of the Schedule Property or any part or portion thereof of any nature whatsoever and/ or any claim by way of, under, or in the nature of sale, share, conveyance, acquisition, partition, transfer, memorandum of understanding, exchange, mortgage, pledge, charge, encumbrance, gift, Will, trust, inheritance, succession, possession, lease, sub-lease, tenancy, maintenance, easement, license, bequeath, bequest, assignment, lien, attachment, decree, award or order of any court of law or authority, development rights, right of way, lis pendens, family arrangement/ settlement, reservation, or under any contract/ agreement/ writing/ document or other disposition, FSI/FAR consumption, or any liability or commitment or otherwise or demand of any nature whatsoever over the Schedule Property or any portion(s) thereof; and/or (b) having any objection(s) of any manner whatsoever are hereby called upon to notify the undersigned in writing of any such claim accompanied with necessary documentary proof of the same within 15 (Fifteen) days from the date of publication of this notice failing which it will be presumed that no one has any right, title, claim or interest, possession of any nature whatsoever in the Schedule Property, and the claim or objection, if any, has been knowingly waived. Any claims or objections received thereafter shall be deemed to be forfeited / waived and shall not be entertained in any manner whatsoever and shall not be binding.

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Dadha Chaharan, 9th Floor, New No 250, Old No 268,
Avvai Shanmugham Salai, Royapettah, Chennai-600014,
E-mail: pirabu.mohan@khaitanco.com

From Page One

Vijay’s broadside at DMK sparks uproar

“You always say that you have faced MISA [Maintenance of Internal Security Act]. But we know the history behind MISA,” he said.

Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar paid no heed to the demands of DMK members to respond to the Chief Minister. Later, he said the aim of the DMK MLAs was to prevent the Chief Minister’s speech from reaching the people.

At one point, DMK deputy leader K.N. Nehru spoke to the Chief Minister and asked him to tell the Speaker to allow their leader, Udhayanidhi Stalin, to respond. Mr. Vijay was seen making gestures indicating that only the Speaker could decide.

Subsequently, Mr. Vijay asked the Speaker to allow DMK members to speak. Even as the DMK MLAs returned to their seats, the Speaker ruled that he could not allow them to speak as they had not allowed the Chief Minister to address the House.

Mr. Vijay singled out the DMK, the main Opposition party in the Assembly, and invoked the nearly 50-year-old Sarkaria Commission inquiry against the DMK government headed by M. Karunanidhi, the Veeranam “scandal”, and the report by the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) on the alleged collection of “party funds”.

“Fifty years have passed since the Sarkaria Commission is known to us. It is a golden jubilee achievement of a party that has celebrated its diamond jubilee,” he said.

Mr. Vijay said the Sarkaria Commission report was raised in the Assembly in 2001 by then Chief Minister, Jayalalithaa and her Cabinet colleague C. Ponnaiyan. He alleged that late Murasoli Maran, the nephew of Karunanidhi, had demanded a 2.5% commission on ₹16 crore from the company, Sathyanarayana Brothers, for taking part in the tender proceedings for the Veeranam water scheme.

Quoting the report, Mr. Vijay said the DMK had received ₹29 lakh in seven instalments between 1970 and 1974. “Besides, they received money to construct a building for *Murasoli* [the mouthpiece of the DMK],” he said, recalling the report’s allegation that Karunanidhi had “abused his official position as the Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu”.

Mr. Vijay said that according to the report, Karunanidhi had pressured the Chief Engineer of the PWD, Hussain, to reduce the tender amount.

He said he had respect and admiration for *Ka-laighnar* (Karunanidhi), and had previously apologised for referring to him by name (in the House). “These are not my allegations. They are part of the report and the allegations of the ED,” he said.

‘CM has no right to advise others against denigrating women’

The quality of the films he had acted in, and the scenes and songs they contained, were at odds with what he was preaching, says Udhayanidhi

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Leader of the Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin on Monday said Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay had no right to advise others to refrain from making “double and triple meaning comments” against women, as the quality of the films he had acted in, and the scenes and the songs they contained, were at odds with what he was preaching.

“If we talk about them, he will not be able to bear it. What is the position of his friends Vishnu Reddy, Sujai Reddy, and Anil Reddy? Why have you handed over the mines and other responsibilities to them? We will release the documents,” he told reporters after staging a walkout from the Assembly in protest against Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar denying him an opportunity to respond in the House.

When asked about the Speaker’s allegation that the DMK had indulged in protests to prevent the Chief Minister’s speech from reaching the people, Mr. Udhayanidhi said the DMK had sought permission to respond only after the Chief Minister had completed his reply.

“He [Speaker] agreed to allow us to speak, but subsequently denied permission. We do not know un-



Countering criticism: Leader of the Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin addressing the media after staging a walkout from the Assembly. ANI

der what compulsion he did that. That is why we are meeting the media,” he said.

On the Chief Minister’s claim that he had evidence to support corruption charges against the DMK, Mr. Udhayanidhi said they were mere allegations.

“There is no evidence. We also possess similar evidence. There are allegations against the Public Works Minister,” he said.

Mr. Udhayanidhi said the Chief Minister and his government were not prepared to say anything against the BJP, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, or Home Minister Amit Shah.

“One Minister spoke about the BJP and another Minister demanded its expunction. They have no courage. He [Mr. Vijay] is a dummy Chief Minister. He memorised the text writ-

ten by someone for three days and delivered it today,” he alleged.

Mr. Udhayanidhi said DMK members had been present in the House to listen to the replies to the 15 questions raised by him.

“I was waiting to take notes. But after 15 minutes, he started levelling allegations. They were false, and contained wrong information. It is our right to object to lies and false allegations. He [Speaker] agreed to allow us to respond after the Chief Minister completed his speech. But he then denied permission,” he said.

Alleging that the Chief Minister had delivered content meant only for [social media] reels and film dialogues, Mr. Udhayanidhi said the DMK members were unable to control their emotions, and raised their voice.



Scathing attack: Why should the DMK continue in politics if it lacks the mindset to accept the people’s verdict, the Chief Minister asked.

Vijay warns of action against people who disparage women

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Monday questioned why the DMK should continue in politics if it lacked the mindset to accept the verdict of the people.

Recalling a senior DMK leader’s remarks (made outside the House) that the people would “not have a good death” because they had not voted for the DMK, Mr. Vijay wondered how he could make such a statement when the same people had voted for the DMK for nearly 50 years.

While replying to the demands for grants for the Police and Fire and Rescue Services Departments, the Chief Minister departed from his prepared text, adopting a different tone and body language as he launched a scathing attack on the DMK.

“In the past, Jayalalithaa, as a woman, was subjected to a lot of humiliation, including in the Assembly, because of the current Opposition party (DMK). We are particular that such incidents should not recur,” he said. Alleging that some senior politicians were jus-

tifying misogynistic and hateful speeches on the ground that they were nothing compared with what was said in the past, Mr. Vijay said there was no need for obscene, hateful, and “rusted” speeches.

He said that of late, the people were watching speeches containing “double and triple” meanings directed at women. He made a strong case for refraining from making such remarks, as “women are our mothers and sisters”. “The law will do its duty if anyone resorts to obscene speeches against women,” he said.

Mr. Vijay also ridiculed the claim by a senior DMK leader that the party had faced the Maintenance of Internal Security Act (MISA). He said everyone knew the history behind it. “The people know what happened and what is going to happen. Are we better commentators than the people,” he asked.

The Chief Minister went on to quote late poet Kannadasan to drive home his criticism of the DMK: “They are used to uttering lies; used to collection and keeping [it] in their pocket.”

Individual crimes can’t be equated with law and order situation: CM

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay argued that there was a difference between individual crimes and the overall law and order situation, and not every crime could be characterised as a law and order issue.

“The outlook towards crime should change. One cannot fix responsibility for a crime on a government, because not all crimes were committed in the last 100 days,” he said.

According to Mr. Vijay, there was a reason behind every crime, which could include family and property disputes, personal enmity and vendetta, drug use, lack of fear of the law during the previous government, performance of the police under the control of certain individuals, caste identity, inter-caste marriages, and local and political struggles for power.

“That was why, while addressing the SPS’ conference, I said the role of the police should not end with arresting the culprit. The police should act to prevent crime,” he said.

Expressing concern over the involvement of students in crime, he said there was a need to work with their families and provide proper guidance.

Circumstances, lack of care and affection from families, bad company, social media, lack of awareness on drugs, and the urge to project oneself as important were the reasons behind the crimes, he said.

With bypolls notified, the focus shifts to whether TVK fields former AIADMK MLAs

K. Muralitharan
CHENNAI

With the Election Commission (EC) notifying the byelection schedule for two out of the seven vacant Assembly constituencies in Tamil Nadu, the question on everyone’s mind is whether the AIADMK MLAs who had resigned from Madurantakam and Dharapuram (both reserved seats) and joined the ruling TVK would get an opportunity to contest the bypolls.

Soon after the formation of the TVK-led government, 25 rebel AIADMK MLAs voted in favour of the motion of confidence moved by Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay. Subsequently, six AIADMK MLAs resigned and joined the TVK. However, the losing candidates filed election petitions challenging the results in five constituencies. As per law, the EC cannot notify bypolls in these seats.

Consequently, the EC announced bypolls only to Madurantakam and Dharapuram.

P. Sathyabama, who resigned as Dharapuram MLA, said she will seek a ticket for the bypoll. “However, the party leadership will take the final call,” she added.

Maragatham Kumaravel, who resigned as Madurantakam MLA, declined to comment.

Former Minister R.B. Udhayakumar of the AIADMK said the party will definitely contest the polls.

Registration offices to be rationalised, says Minister

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Commercial Taxes and Registration Minister D. Logesh Tamilselvan on Monday announced in the Assembly that the Registration Department will rationalise its offices to ensure better and faster services, and distribute the workload of sub-registrars, with a proposal to have only one Sub-Registrar’s office within a revenue division.

The department will also establish 25 model registration hubs to provide various registration-related services under one roof. The first phase will cover Vellore, Central Chennai, South Chennai, Chengalpattu, and Coimbatore (North), he said.

Mr. Tamilselvan said additional buildings, equipment, and other facilities will be provided to 25 Sub-Registrar offices handling a high volume of registra-

tions, at a cost of ₹54 lakh under the Revenue Expenditure head and ₹34 lakh under the Capital Expenditure head.

From September 15, registration of loan-related documents executed at banks and non-banking financial institutions will be brought under a presence-less system, allowing registration without physical appearance at the Sub-Registrar’s office.

From October 15, the presence-less registration system will be extended to certain transactions including settlement, release, partition, revocation of settlement, and family arrangement deeds.

The ‘Engirundhum Pathivu’ (Registration from Anywhere) system will be extended to 100 Sub-Registrar offices across the State to make services more accessible and reduce the need for people to travel to a particular registration office, the Minister said.

Mr. Tamilselvan said a single-window online facility will be created to address traders’ grievances relating to tax procedures and their implementation under the GST Act and earlier tax laws.

A separate tax assessment circle will be created in every Commercial Taxes Division to administer traders covered under the Tamil Nadu Value Added Tax Act, Central Sales Tax Act, and other earlier tax laws.

Petrol and diesel retail outlets that have paid VAT at the first-sale stage in the State, and are registered under the GST Act, will be exempted from obtaining registration under the Tamil Nadu VAT Act.

The monetary jurisdiction of the single-member Bench of the Tamil Nadu Sales Tax Appellate Tribunal will be enhanced from ₹1 lakh to ₹1 crore to facilitate speedy disposal of second appeals under earlier tax laws, the Minister said.

‘Probe will be held into IUML MLA’s claim of being offered money after Assembly poll’

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Minister for Public Works Aadhav Arjuna on Monday said a probe will be conducted into alleged horse trading by the DMK “by illegally confining Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) MLAs in a hotel” before the formation of the TVK-led government.

The Minister made the remarks against the backdrop of the controversy triggered by IUML MLA Syed Farooq Basha, who had alleged that a few persons had approached him and another IUML MLA after the Assembly election and offered them crores of rupees to join their camp.

However, speaking in the Assembly on Monday, Mr. Basha claimed that his comments were being distorted by the DMK.

Minister for Minorities Welfare A.M. Shahjahan of the IUML intervened and said, “After this government came to power, there



Who kept the two IUML MLAs at the Accord Hotel? Who owns the Accord Hotel? It is owned by DMK MP Jagathrakshakan
AADHAV ARJUNA
Minister for Public Works

were high expectations among the people that it would be free of corruption, and it has been functioning well under that principle. If allegations that money was taken, or that horse-trading took place, are made despite this, it would create a situation where it would become impossible to continue engaging in politics for generations.”

“Since some statements made by IUML members are being selectively quoted, I have a duty to offer certain clarifications. After the election results were announced, on May 4, the IUML, which had contest-

ed and won as part of the [DMK-led] Secular Progressive Alliance, announced that it would support them and take a decision accordingly. However, on May 9, we extended our support [to the TVK] for one specific reason – to prevent Governor’s rule, acting as a proxy for the Union government, from being imposed,” he said.

According to him, Mr. Basha’s allegation was about those who contacted the IUML on May 7 over who should be the Chief Minister. From the Opposition’s side, an attempt was made on May 7 to prevent the formation of a govern-

ment led by Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay. The DMK leadership took such a decision and conveyed it to the IUML. On May 8, it took another decision and put forward a different proposal. “As the IUML refused to accept it, I do not wish to disclose certain details, considering that the party was protected and nurtured by the respected Quaid-e-Millat,” he said.

“But a situation may arise where we will have to reveal everything – who took the two IUML MLAs (including him) to the Accord Hotel after 10 p.m. on May 8 and kept them there, who threatened them, and who kept them under watch. Several incidents took place in this regard,” Mr. Shahjahan claimed.

Mr. Arjuna said, “Who kept them at the Accord Hotel? Who owns the Accord Hotel? It is owned by DMK MP Jagathrakshakan. An inquiry will be conducted shortly.”

DVAC books K.N. Nehru, associates over alleged ₹1,020-cr. tender irregularities

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) has registered a case against former Municipal Administration Minister K.N. Nehru, his brothers, former MLAs S. Sudarshanam and J.J. Ebenezer, and other associates, contractors, and government officials for the alleged manipulation of government tenders and collection of illegal gratification in contracts awarded by the Municipal Adminis-

tration, Urban and Water Supply Departments between 2021 and 2025.

The FIR, registered as DVAC Headquarters Crime No.7 of 2026 on September 4, names 13 accused, including Mr. Nehru, his brothers K.N. Manivannan and N. Ravichandran, close associate Kavi Prasad, two representatives of TVH Group, three former municipal administration officials, staff of C.T. Constructions, and contractor K. Sathish Kumar. Unidentified officials, contractors, and private individuals



In legal trouble: Senior DMK leader and former Minister K.N. Nehru and his brothers are among the 13 persons named in the FIR.

have also been named.

The case followed a 258-page report submitted by the Enforcement Directo-

rate (ED) to the DVAC in December 2025, alleging manipulation of government contracts and a

wrongful gain of about ₹1,020 crore. The State government subsequently permitted a detailed inquiry, which was registered in December 2025.

According to the FIR, the DVAC inquiry *prima facie* found a nexus between public servants, private individuals, and contractors in the award of contracts. It alleged that contractors were identified even before tenders were opened, and illegal gratification was collected on the pretext of “party fund” at 7.5% to 10% of the contract value.

The FIR cites WhatsApp chats and materials recovered from the mobile phones of the accused as evidence.

The FIR also refers to the alleged payments of ₹1 crore, ₹2.77 crore, and ₹5 crore in connection with contracts involving a private infrastructure company, besides other alleged payments running into crores.

Based on the detailed inquiry, the DVAC said the material *prima facie* disclosed offences of criminal conspiracy, criminal

breach of trust, cheating, and criminal misconduct. The case was registered under the provisions of the Indian Penal Code, the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, and the Prevention of Corruption Act.

The FIR was registered after permission was obtained under Section 17A of the Prevention of Corruption Act. The DVAC has taken up the investigation and submitted the FIR, along with the ED report, to the Principal Judge, City Civil and Sessions Court, Chennai.

Congress in no hurry to fill vacant posts in Karnataka Cabinet

Satheesan-Rahul meet fuels talk over next KPCC chief

Revanth seeks KCR apology over BRS MLC's remarks; BJP stages walkout

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Natural partners

India and Belgium are building ties across sectors despite differences

In terms of size and engagement, Belgium is not one of India's most important partners. However, the visit of the Belgian Prime Minister to Delhi is part of a larger puzzle of India's ties with European countries. These have now gained salience with focus areas for India: in economic relations, defence relations and strategic ties. At the top of the agenda in talks between Prime Ministers Bart De Wever and Narendra Modi was bilateral trade opportunities once the India-European Union Free Trade Agreement (FTA) is signed – which is expected in December. India-Belgium trade is about \$13 billion, a third of which is from over a century of collaboration in the diamond industry. Antwerp is a global hub for diamond trading, while Mumbai and Surat provide the biggest cutting and polishing services. However, once the EU FTA is signed, they hope to benefit from collaboration in other areas including renewable energy and food processing; the Prime Ministers agreed to set a target of doubling bilateral trade in the next five years. Despite being surrounded by friendly European allies, Belgium has a robust high-tech defence industry – small arms, drone and counter-drone technology, ammunition and naval defence – and is keen to make inroads in the Indian market, with India seeking to diversify its procurement beyond global powers. The two sides agreed on an MoU for co-development of military hardware, and signed a letter of intent on defence cooperation. India will appoint a resident defence attaché to Brussels, complementing Belgium's move.

Statements by the two leaders, however, indicated that the visit went beyond the bilateral to a more geopolitical framing of strategic ties, both bilateral as well as between India and Europe. At a business event, Mr. De Wever said that Europe is now realising the truth of India's "warnings" on strategic autonomy from global powers and over dependence in trade and industrial production, in particular referring to China. After the talks, Mr. Modi said that democratic values, a market economy, and people-to-people ties make India and Belgium "natural partners", a theme he has promoted this past year, as he has stepped up visits to Europe and received a number of European leaders in Delhi, in the run-up to his Brussels visit later this year for the FTA. It is also significant that Mr. De Wever's visit comes in the same week that New Delhi is preparing to welcome Russian President Vladimir Putin for the BRICS summit in Delhi. The engagement with Belgium demonstrates a new maturity for both European countries and India. This shows sensitivity to their respective positions on the Russia-Ukraine conflict, indicating that ties outweigh Europe's enmity and India's deep friendship with Moscow.

Ground control

ISRO must focus on space technology as a tool for development

The irony was evident: on the day the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) had its greatest success of the year – the launch of its first geosynchronous imaging satellite (EOS-05) on a temperamental GSLV – its employee organisations demanded clarity on its long-term plans. But this grievance was long in the making. Since the Indian Space Policy of April 2023, the message has been clear that ISRO would, one day in the unspecified future, stop making commercial satellites and launch rockets. Clearly inspired by NASA, it expects to focus on ambitious exploratory missions and, literally, moonshots. Why would a space agency ramping up space missions upset a section of employees? This is not the paradox it presents. The letter, co-signed by nine employee associations, and addressed to the chairman, seeks clarity on staff-strength, recruitment and the outsourcing of core functions. ISRO says that it will "not be privatised or reduced"; IN-SPaCE, set up to facilitate private participation, says the agency will "not be diminished", only that the industry's role must grow. Both are silent on the core concern – potential job losses. This brings up an underlying tension that ISRO must deal with: does its vision of India's space sector align with its founding principles, of not being enamoured of space races and being laser-focused on space technology as a tool for social development? Or is the image of power, where India is one of a handful of space-faring countries with a mushrooming of 'space startups', now the bedrock of that vision?

With a budget 16 times the Department of Space's – \$24.4 billion against ₹13,705 crore – NASA too has scaled back since the 1960s: from 0.7% of American GDP in 1966 to 0.1% now, and from 36,000 civil servants at Apollo's peak to about 14,000 today. Unlike NASA, which in its early years designed and made every nut and bolt, ISRO has always had a manufacturing relationship with the private sector (Walchandnagar, L&T). What is different is that the buzz is not about established companies building on experience but new entrants with fleeting foreign capital, most interested in satellite data as a service. No sector can hope to be static; survival can mean significant changes to how it operates. There is yet no serious reckoning with the might of China's space programme. If India's space sector in 2035 is to be known as a source of export earnings, a nucleus of value-added services that brings in jobs and absorbs skilled labour, then hard choices taken today may be worth it. But jumping onto a bandwagon of space – as fuel for the science fiction fantasy of billionaires and colonial notions of conquest, to align with some misplaced notion of an 'exclusive' club – is foolhardy. ISRO must have a transparent policy that spells this out.

BRICS has strayed quite far from where it started. To be held this weekend (September 12-13, 2026) the 18th BRICS Summit, in New Delhi, gives India a huge opportunity to bring coherence back to the expanded group and give it direction if it is to be an effective body in shaping global events.

BRICS was formed to give a greater voice to Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa, the emerging economies, in global governance and institutions, particularly financial and economic institutions, and to aim for a more equitable multilateral order. India was initially an enthusiastic participant, seeing the group as a vehicle for genuine reform of multilateral institutions. The first summit hosted by India (the fourth BRICS summit), in 2012, focused on the theme "Global Stability, Security and Prosperity," tacitly reflecting a much broader geopolitical canvas. The Indian presidency helped lead to the establishment of the BRICS Bank, the New Development Bank. Other Indian initiatives followed, including the integration of a counter-terrorism architecture into BRICS' work.

The emergence of the China challenge

However, China had other plans. At the time, even if it was not anti-West, China saw BRICS as a counterpoise to western domination – a view that India also initially shared in the context of reform. More importantly, China needed a group such as BRICS, consisting of emerging economies, to amplify its global ambitions, given that BRICS countries accounted for nearly 20% of world GDP in 2010. Further, China wanted to use BRICS mechanisms such as BRICS-Plus and BRICS Outreach to reach out to the Global South and consolidate their profile as a second pole in a future bipolar world.

Suddenly, India not only had a reform agenda on its hands but also had to act as a counterweight to China's larger designs on BRICS. India, Brazil and South Africa soon realised that Chinese support for the reform of multilateral institutions was selective. For example, China resisted supporting the three countries' bid for permanent seats on the United Nations Security Council. Consequently, India started focusing more on BRICS consolidation and intra-BRICS matters to resist Chinese grandstanding. In fact, this year's theme for India's chairship has four pillars – Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability – and draws on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of "Humanity First" and a "people-centric" approach to BRICS cooperation.

In addition, there was a real danger that the principle of consensus, which had kept BRICS a cohesive group, would be bypassed and that BRICS would go the way of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO), where the majority can bulldoze their views through. India and Brazil resisted these efforts. The 2019 BRICS Summit in Brasilia was held without any other invited guest countries – just the five original members. But in 2020, under the Russian presidency, probably the first non-consensus chair's statement on COVID-19 was issued,



T.S. Tirumurti

Chair, Steering Committee, Deccan Centre for International Relations, former Permanent Representative of India to the United Nations, New York, and former Sherpa of BRICS

The Delhi summit offers India an opportunity to restore BRICS's original purpose

bypassing the sacred principle of consensus. If non-consensus documents are increasingly resorted to, as we saw at the BRICS Foreign Ministers' meeting in May 2026 in New Delhi due to the inability of the new members to agree, then BRICS will cease to be effective.

Membership expansion tests BRICS cohesion

But then, it was difficult to resist the Chinese juggernaut. China pushed for the expansion of the New Development Bank and then for the expansion of BRICS itself. India resisted, as did Brazil. But that was not to be, and BRICS now has 11 members, following the addition of Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates and Indonesia, as well as 10 partner countries.

India's sagacity has now been vindicated, as the new members of BRICS have started fighting among themselves. While the original five have their differences, some of them serious, they know how to address them with maturity for the greater good of the group. The new members do not have any such compunctions and are subverting BRICS through their bilateral conflicts. BRICS should not go the way of the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC), with bilateral disputes paralysing the group.

In addition, the tussle over the direction BRICS should take has begun. India has tried to keep BRICS as a "non-West" group, as opposed to the increasing pressure from some members to turn BRICS into an anti-West group. An anti-West slant is becoming increasingly difficult to avoid, with China competing with the United States for global leadership, Russia at war with Ukraine with the full backing of Europe, and Iran being bombarded by the U.S. and Israel. It becomes even harder to maintain the "non-West" line when Brazil and India have been subjected to punitive tariffs by U.S. President Donald Trump, and the U.S. Congress is considering legislation that would give the President the power to levy punitive tariffs on countries importing Russian oil. The question being asked is: how can India stop BRICS from becoming anti-West at a time when the Quad (Australia, India, Japan, the U.S.) is being emasculated by the U.S., India-U.S. relations are under great pressure, Pakistan is being courted by the U.S. at India's expense, and global institutions are being made dysfunctional by the West? The more erratic the U.S. is *vis-à-vis* BRICS, the greater the chances of BRICS going in the wrong direction. Fortunately, India's effort to prevent an anti-western drift is shared by many other BRICS members, since they too have much to gain by engaging with multiple actors from different camps in their national interest. They want change, but not geopolitical realignment with China and Russia. This is the direction of BRICS's future.

But there is a much larger question. Both the U.S. and China are enunciating parallel visions of the world and playing by their own rules, rather than internationally negotiated ones. Both are, in effect, challenging existing international norms and global institutions and setting up parallel

structures and standards in emerging areas such as Artificial Intelligence, digital and Internet governance, data ownership, state control, 5G/6G and telecom, satellite navigation, and electric vehicles. Neither is looking for reform of existing institutions. China has just set up a new World AI Cooperation Organisation in Shanghai, in addition to other parallel initiatives such as the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, the Belt and Road Initiative and the Digital Silk Road, which challenge the Bretton Woods institutions and their governance and financing models. They see BRICS as one of the vehicles through which to pursue their broader goals. For example, the push for de-dollarisation through the establishment of a parallel BRICS currency is receiving a lukewarm response, since many members are uncomfortable with a renminbi-dominated currency and would prefer merely interlinking payment systems, central bank digital currencies and national-currency transactions. Nevertheless, after the success of its pilot project, China is formally launching its ambitious mBridge, an alternative financial payment system. The last thing India wants is an alternative Bretton Woods system dominated by China.s

India can course correct BRICS

The 2026 Summit in Delhi provides an opportunity for course correction, and India has worked hard to persuade the new members to overcome their political differences. In a world in flux, India has to revive the original *raison d'être* of BRICS and shape the expanded grouping into a vehicle for reform and stability, while stopping others from hijacking it.

At the 2018 BRICS Summit in South Africa, Mr. Modi first articulated his vision of "reformed multilateralism" at the leaders' retreat. By 2019, this vision had found its way into the BRICS Summit document in Brasilia, with India, Brazil and South Africa pushing for it. The time has come to revive this agenda and make BRICS a strong voice for the "non-West" middle powers – and, by extension, for the Global South.

In Davos, the Canadian Prime Minister spoke about broadly West-centric middle powers coming together. A Global South middle power is very different. And if there is a credible organisation of Global South middle powers, it is BRICS. It has its problems. To begin with, China is hardly a middle power and has disproportionate influence within BRICS. India and China need to find greater synergy on emerging global issues, even as their bilateral differences are being contained. Further, some middle powers that ought to be there are not represented in BRICS. However imperfect its composition may be, it is clear that BRICS has great geopolitical and geo-economic potential.

At a time when the profile of BRICS is only increasing, with many countries wanting to join it, India should proactively embrace the BRICS reform agenda to serve its larger interest of multi-alignment. If India does not, others will take BRICS in a different direction.

U.S. tariffs are not what is holding back Indian research

Tariff wars with the United States have ebbed and flowed for years. After months of escalation, Washington and New Delhi stepped back a few months ago. The penalty tied to India's purchases of Russian oil went, the reciprocal tariff was cut, and medicines and most electronics stayed exempt. Exporters treated it as relief. But an old worry in policy circles is worth testing: that high American tariffs will choke research in the industries that they touch, and set back India's move into higher-value production.

The reality

That worry rests on a mistaken assumption that the sectors exposed to American tariffs are the sectors where India does its research.

Consider the impact of the 2019 loss of duty-free access and the 2025 tariff hit on sectors such as organic chemicals, plastics, base metals, machinery, auto components, and leather. Now consider how much these industries do in research. Indian metals firms spend about 0.4% of sales on R&D, compared with a global average of nearly 1.6%. Auto and parts makers spend a little over 2%, versus a global average of 5%, while electrical equipment firms spend less than 2%, against the same 5% global benchmark. These industries were research-thin long before any tariff arrived. The sectors most exposed to trade shocks and the sectors that invest in research barely overlap. India's research effort is concentrated in pharmaceuticals and automobiles, and almost everything else does little. A tariff on chemicals or steel cannot cut research spending that was never there.

This also takes the air out of the claim that tariffs are holding back Indian innovation. Patenting and research spending in the exposed sectors show no clear break during the tariff years that can be attributed to the duties. These sectors had been on a low-research path well



Arindam Goswami

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The sectors most exposed to trade shocks barely overlap with those that invest in research

before 2018 and stayed on it. The tariffs are a symptom of a trading relationship under strain.

Research is a fixed and risky investment that pays off only when a product sells at scale. A firm facing a smaller export market can retreat to cheaper, undifferentiated goods, or invest in products that a tariff cannot easily replace. Indian industry has chosen the first path for decades, and a tariff does not change that habit.

Where tariffs do matter is narrow. Of the two sectors that account for most of India's research, pharmaceuticals secured an exemption in the February deal, while automobiles did not. The 25% U.S. duty on auto parts remains, and metal tariffs raise input costs for downstream engineering and component firms. So, the live risk to India's research base runs through autos – not the broad manufacturing economy that fills the headlines.

The real problem

The problem to worry about predates this trade fight and will outlast it. India spends a very small percentage of its output on research, a figure that remains well below that of the countries it wants to compete with. The private industry share is also well below the global leaders. What industry does spend tends to go toward routine development and testing rather than research that creates new products. By one comparison, Nvidia alone spends nearly as much on research as all of Indian industry combined.

This is the backdrop for the government's ₹1 lakh crore Research, Development and Innovation scheme, launched late last year. It offers long-tenure, low-cost capital to firms in sunrise and strategic areas such as artificial intelligence, semiconductors, quantum technology and biotechnology. The ambition is overdue. But the money is pointed at the frontier, while the industries most exposed to trade shocks

and most in need of moving up the value chain are older sectors that the scheme is not designed for. A chemicals or auto-parts maker that has never run a research programme will not start now because of a loan aimed at deep tech.

That is the opportunity the tariff episode offers. A trade shock tells an exposed industry that its products are vulnerable. The useful response is to move those firms into differentiated products that a tariff cannot easily undercut, which means investing in research. Incentives can be weighted towards core research rather than routine testing and aimed at exposed sectors instead of being spread thin. The higher costs that metal tariffs cause on downstream engineering firms can be offset for those that keep up research spending. Pharmaceuticals and autos also deserve protection in any further negotiations, because tariffs in these sectors can affect innovation. Sheltering an exposed industry without asking anything in return preserves low-value production. Support should be tied to research effort, so that relief rebuilds capability rather than freezing the status quo.

Time to measure research better

None of this works without better measurement. India's official research figures arrive years late and undercount private spending. A country that cannot see where its research is going cannot steer it. A faster, firm-level record linking research spending to exports would let policymakers act before the damage shows.

The tariff truce gives India time. The tariffs were never the main thing holding back Indian research. The task is to fix what is: an economy whose exposed industries do too little research, while its research strength is in a few sectors that could be vulnerable to the next trade shock.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A dam, the concerns

China's proposed colossal dam on the Yarlung Tsangpo has precipitated profound geopolitical and ecological apprehensions. The region's pronounced seismicity renders such an enormous hydraulic structure particularly

disquieting. The absence of an enforceable transboundary water-sharing mechanism further exacerbates India's predicament. China must institutionalise hydrological transparency. **Nagarajamani M.V.,** Hyderabad

Assembly proceedings

Of late, the Tamil Nadu Assembly appears to have become more of a shooting spot than a place for serious debate. Members shout at the top of their voices, while 'cheerleaders' from the respective political parties

enthusiastically thump the tables — often without even understanding what is actually being discussed. There was much hype surrounding the Chief Minister's response to the points raised by the Leader of the Opposition. But in the end, it turned out to be

nothing more than a damp squib. Allegations were made without producing evidence, while the much-talked-about 'files' are still waiting to be opened. Only a handful of members appear to be focusing on people's welfare and the real issues affecting

them. Meanwhile, the larger concern remains the deterioration of law and order in Tamil Nadu.

R. Shankar, Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address and the full name.

Teen agency beyond Meta’s reckoning

Meryl is 13. She describes YouTube Shorts as “so addicting”; holding her attention “just long enough” that she loses track of everything else. She is one of dozens of teens who have participated in the research at the Teens, Family, and Technology Lab at Rutgers University. While the 13-year-old’s language is not unusual, teen voices are still largely missing from broader debates about social media use.

Meta’s \$17.1 billion settlement with U.S. States is making headlines as a reckoning over addictive platform design. However, not much has been said about how teen agency emerges in a media environment built to predict the most tempting feed. Debates about youth and technology have historically focused on media effects: either what teens do with media, or what media does to teens. Nearly 100 years ago, the Payne Fund Studies marked the first systematic exploration of this dynamic, examining the impact of movies on children. With every new wave of technology, the storyline persists. Youth audiences are typically spoken for – cast as passive, trapped or targeted by new tech.

This framing misses the point. It ignores how the experience of adolescence itself shapes media use, and why certain types of media design captivate teens. Teens’ media use resonates with a powerful framework from developmental psychology: a race car that can go very fast, but whose brakes are still being built. That speed creates both opportunities and risks. Teens are primed to learn



Nikhila Natarajan

Co-founder of the Teens, Family, and Technology Lab at Rutgers University

more rapidly than at any other stage of development. Yet that power makes teens more vulnerable to negative stimuli. This heightened sensitivity exists alongside a crucial asymmetry: their ability to plan and prioritise (what to do first, what next) develops gradually, even as teens exhibit heightened sensitivity to “rewards” (easily persuaded by things that are pleasing). In today’s media, these rewards arrive via personalised recommendations. When short-form video loops shrink the gap between media experiences to 15 or 30 seconds, the onus of decision-making becomes the young person’s problem at a time when the braking system is still getting built.

Whistleblowers, Silicon Valley defectors, and documentaries such as *The Social Dilemma* have laid bare how platform design choices erode human agency. What remains absent from public commentary is what teens’ vocabularies reveal about their developmental needs. Across the 13-to-16 age group, teens say that short-form videos are shrinking their attention spans. But their reflections point to a persistent entry point: boredom.

Boredom, peer dynamics
Boredom is a developmental driver. As adolescents shift their orientation toward peers and crave greater independence, they continue to live under adult restrictions. They then open an app seeking a quick distraction, only to find themselves stuck for hours on platforms such as YouTube Shorts or TikTok.

Peer dynamics drive how teens move across different apps, with platform design acting as an amplifier. On platforms such as Instagram and Snapchat, where popularity is quantified

through public likes and follower counts, every interaction gets a scoreboard. For an adolescent hyper-sensitive to social inclusion and exclusion, this design is incredibly stressful. Early evidence from Australia’s social media ban bears this out. Two systematic surveys by Bursztyn and colleagues found that Australian teens report needing roughly 70% of their peers to quit social media before they’re willing to quit themselves.

Research at the Teens, Family, and Technology Lab shows that adolescents navigate an average of 7 to 12 different platforms daily. Instagram and Facebook exist within a competitive teen media inventory alongside Snapchat, YouTube, Pinterest, Discord, Spotify, and more. Here, teens’ recalibration of media practices, and parents’ concerns for their children’s wellbeing act as powerful competitive forces.

While Meta and other platforms chase topline revenues, some teens are crafting micro-frictions to push back. Pinterest is a big hit with girls who want to escape performative sociality; music streaming competes with short-form video apps; and some teens are deleting apps intermittently. These are behavioural signatures of adolescent metacognition – literally, thinking about thinking. Yet AI-fuelled media design continues to operate at the limits of adolescent development, exacerbating tensions between the intentional and accidental. Understanding the contradictions of adolescent development invites us to reconsider teen media use in a new light – as a striving for agency.

The incongruity of caste and science

All humans must be treated equally. That is a moral and constitutional position. It is not a scientific position because science does not carry moral or constitutional authority.

The normative system laid out in the ‘Manusmriti’ expresses the ‘principle’ that the birth of a person says something essential about who that person is supposed to be, with persons born into specific social categories to be assigned a place in the division of labour and a set of permitted relationships and social rights. Modern constitutional thinking is radically different. Per the Magna Carta, the English Bill of Rights and the constitutional democracies of today, individuals possess rights that depend on more than their place in a social hierarchy. After all, the fundamental rights of the Indian Constitution are attached to persons and citizens, not to inherited social functions.

Yet a poster that turned up at IIT-Mandi on September 4 said the role of “Brahmanas” is to “spread god’s message”, that of “kshatriyas” to “protect society and spirituality”, of “vaishyas” to “drive economy, support others”, and of “shudras” to “serve higher classes”.

Science, which underlies the technologies the IITs are primarily concerned with, offers another conception paralleling the constitutional view, rooted in a different kind of authority.

The authority of science
While some defenders of the caste system have claimed that it is based on inherited biological differences, the system is really the cause of the differences, rather than their inheritor. The human



Vasudevan Mukunth

organism develops as its genes interact with its environment, and caste-based discrimination affects these environments. Studies on the social determinants of health have revealed caste-related inequities in healthcare and access to healthcare while social epigenetics has found that social circumstances can induce biological changes via mechanisms that affect the way genes are regulated.

People of Black African heritage and Indigenous peoples in Asia, say, have non-identical genomes for this reason. By applying science’s methods, we know the differences between these peoples do not excuse a caste-like system. Instead, the differences in these people’s social circumstances through history – including societies of which they were part practising a hereditary, hierarchical system at any point – affected the way they developed.

In a landmark 2009 study, geneticists reported that most present-day Indians descended from two differentiated ancient populations, which mixed extensively before endogamy took root, and present Indian groups contain mixes of these ancestries. The team also said there are substantial genetic differences between various communities today thanks to a long history of endogamy. Other studies of Indian populations have also reported strong founder effects (when a new population emerges from a small group of individuals and inherits the lack of genetic diversity) due to endogamy. The genome does not announce that these people were ordained

to marry one another but records the fact that they elected to do so for reasons beyond scientific wisdom.

The human nervous system is also very plastic: it constantly rewires itself in response to every experience in a life-long process. Not everyone is good at everything, but plasticity means the neurological system develops together with each human’s environment, interests, temperament, and individual choice, giving rise to a variety of abilities among people.

No matter how well-equipped, the practice of science could never say whether all humans are equal. That is a political and ethical proposition it cannot test or prove. However, it does say that all humans are members of one species, that their development is shaped by their experiences, and that social environments can become embodied.

Just as caste constrains the plasticity of the human brain, it also constrains the human capacity for culture. *Homo sapiens* can accumulate knowledge and pass it on so that other *H. sapiens* do not have to learn from scratch. Caste-based discrimination, however, restricts the spread of knowledge and narrows the social range over which one of the defining capacities of our species can operate – as if a student’s ability to solve a differential equation has anything to do with the status of their ancestors.

This clash of possibilities is what makes the appearance of a message reinforcing the caste system at a centre of scientific learning particularly tragic.

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Nearly 8,000 people died due to collapse of structures in 5 years

While the incident in Satya Niketan in Delhi has sparked outrage, hundreds of people have been dying due to laxities in enforcing building safety norms.

DATA POINT

Pon Vasanth B.A

The collapse of a five-storey building in Satya Niketan in Delhi on September 6, in which six people have been confirmed dead as of Monday morning, has turned out to be yet another grim reminder of the laxity in cracking down on buildings violating safety norms.

While collapses like the one in Satya Niketan have caught the public’s attention, because of the high death toll and the fact that it was a PG for students, many such isolated incidents which happen across the country go largely unnoticed.

An analysis of the annual Accidental Deaths and Suicides in India (ADSI) reports showed that a total of 7,874 people were killed in building collapses across the country between 2020 and 2024. Delhi recorded 169 deaths in the same period.

The ADSI 2024 report – the latest available from the National Crime Records Bureau – stated that while such deaths showed a marginal decline in the country in 2024, the deaths in the National Capital Territory (NCT) have increased since 2020 (**Chart 1**).

The ADSI includes five sub-categories under deaths due to collapse of structures – Collapse of Dwelling House/Residential Building, Collapse of Official/Commercial Building, Collapse of Dam, Collapse of Bridge, and Others. The data discussed in this article excludes the numbers reported under the categories of ‘Collapse of Dam’ and ‘Collapse of Bridge’.

Uttar Pradesh, the most populous State in the country, recorded 223 deaths due to building collapses in 2024, the highest in the country. It was followed by the second most populous State, Maharashtra (as per Census 2011) with 220 deaths. **Chart 2** shows the 15 States and UTs that reported the

highest number of deaths due to building collapses.

Delhi reported the 12th highest number of deaths (42) in the country in 2024. Despite being geographically smaller, the densely-populated NCT has been among the top 15 States every year since 2020. Moreover, the deaths recurring every year in the capital are more worrying when seen in relation to its population. Deaths from building collapses per million population, calculated using mid-year population estimates from the ADSI reports every year, show that Delhi recorded the second- or third-highest deaths per million population in 2022, 2023, and 2024 (**Chart 3**).

Recent numbers

While the ADSI report for 2025 is yet to be released, a compilation of incidents reported in the media showed that at least 70 people have died in 20 incidents since January 2025, which means that at least three people have died every month in such incidents.

Map 1 shows the incidents reported in the media since 2024, including the one in Satya Niketan on Sunday. There have been at least 34 incidents, killing more than 90 people since 2024.

Acting in predictable haste, as most government agencies do after such incidents, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, has said that it will seal all illegal five-storey and taller buildings “immediately”.

However, data discussed in this article indicates that the underlying systemic problem demands well-thought-out long-term strategies that keep in mind the growing need for affordable housing to end such avoidable deaths.

Note on map: The incidents and death toll were compiled from news reports. Though each incident has been verified from at least three news reports, there may be some inaccuracies in the numbers. Incident locations are geocoded to locality level, and not the precise spot of the incident.

Accountability collapse

The data for the charts were sourced from annual Accidental Deaths and Suicides in India reports. DataMeet’s Delhi municipal spatial data was used to plot the map. Incidents plotted in the map were sourced from media reports. With inputs from Gauri Singavarapu and Gandla Sneha, who are interning with The Hindu’s Data team



CHART 1: Deaths due to building collapses have increased in Delhi. Y-axis scales are different for All India and Delhi

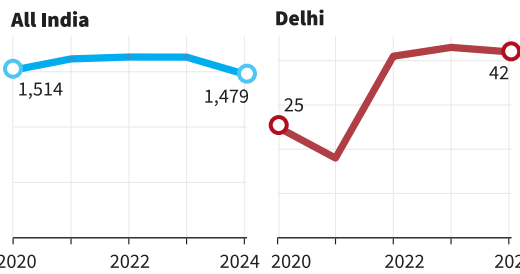
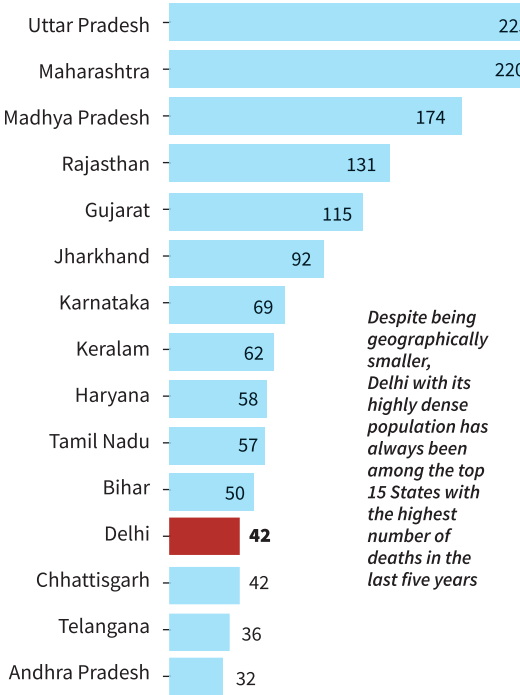
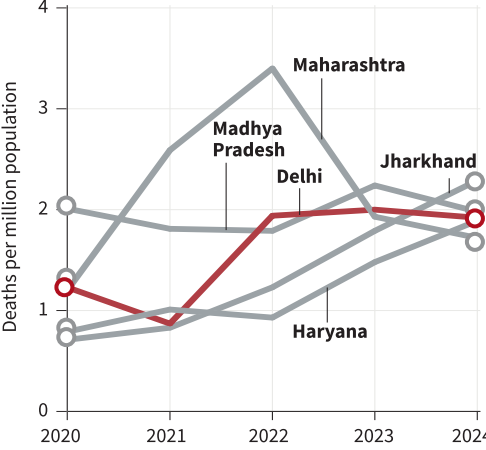


CHART 2: The 15 States (or UTs) with the highest number of deaths due to building collapses in 2024

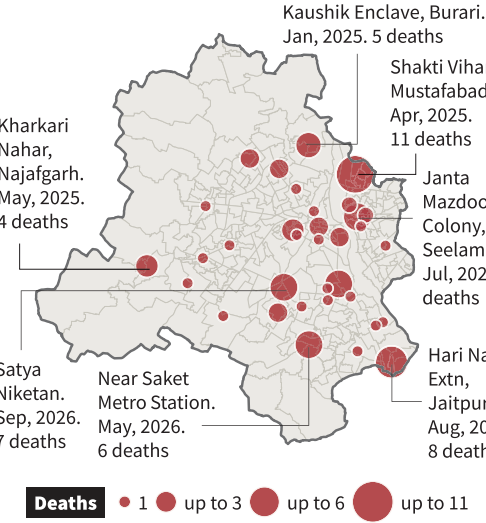


Despite being geographically smaller, Delhi with its highly dense population has always been among the top 15 States with the highest number of deaths in the last five years

CHART 3: Delhi recorded the second or third highest deaths per million due to building collapses since 2022



MAP 1: In at least 34 incidents of building collapses since 2024 in various parts of Delhi, over 90 people were killed



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 8, 1976

Bhutto lays claim to Kohinoor diamond

London, September 7: Pakistan has asked Britain to return the fabulous Kohinoor diamond which is the central stone in the Queen Consort’s crown and has been in British possession since 1849.

A Government spokesman said to-day the request was made in a personal letter to the Prime Minister, Mr. James Callaghan by the Pakistani Premier, Z. A. Bhutto. It was “being considered”.

The 100 carat gem now stored in the Tower of London is acknowledged as the finest diamond in the world and became part of the crown jewels of Queen Victoria after the British annexed Punjab. The 1,000-year-old diamond was last worn by the Queen Mother at the Coronation of King George VI in 1937.

A spokesman for Queen Elizabeth to-day would not comment on the monarch’s authority to accede to President Bhutto’s request.

The palace spokesman said Prime Minister Callaghan was likely to discuss the request with the Queen.

Informed sources said the Pakistani Premier wrote in his letter that the return of the stone would be a demonstration of the spirit that moved Britain to shed its imperial emburances.

The request for the coveted Kohinoor – ‘Mountain of Light’ – might become another chapter in the turbulent history of the stone.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 8, 1926

South Africa’s status

Capetown, September 7: General Hertzog’s speech at a meeting in the City Hall on the eve of his departure to attend the Imperial Conference dealing with the Flag Bill has foreshadowed a compromise and he declared that if the Committee on the flag should recommend the inclusion of a crown in it he was confident that the Government would approve it.

Gen. Hertzog denied that he intended at the conference to demand a written constitution and said he intended to urge that steps should be taken so that South Africa’s national status which was equal to that of Britain and other dominions be entitled to an international recognition and should be so published and declared to the world.

From Page One

Collapse toll hits 7; HC calls for hostel audits

The rescue work was declared complete at 5 p.m. on Monday, with agencies saying the debris had been removed entirely from the site. The mortal remains of those deceased were handed over to the family members, the police said.

In the High Court, a Bench of Chief Justice D.K. Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia said the deaths raised serious concerns about the safety of students living in PG accommodations and the acute shortage of hostel facilities for outstation students in Delhi. The deceased students hailed from several States, including Uttar Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, and Madhya Pradesh.

The court directed the MCD to ascertain whether PG buildings in its jurisdiction had been constructed with valid permissions, whether they complied with building bye-laws, and whether any violations had taken place.

The High Court said the responsibility for the incident could not, *prima facie*, be confined to the property owner, as the role of university authorities and the MCD also required examination. It directed the civic body to conduct its inspection at the highest executive level and fix responsibility public servants if the collapsed building was found to have been constructed without authorisation.

A Delhi Court remanded Mr. Gupta and his wife to judicial custody, while their son has been sent to police custody for two days.

LPG booking interval at 25 days for rural users

At the peak of the conflict in West Asia in March 2026, the government had expanded the booking interval for domestic LPG cylinders from 21 days to 25 days for urban consumers and 45 days for rural consumers.

Prior to the conflict, India met 60% of its overall LPG requirements through imports. Of these imports, 90% were routed via the Strait of Hormuz, which faced a blockade as a result of the conflict.

Indian oil marketing companies then began increasingly importing LPG from the United States, which now forms nearly two-thirds of India's LPG import basket.

The government's subsequent push for piped natural gas (PNG), among other factors, led to India's consumption of LPG declining by 17.4% in June compared to the same month last year, and 16.2% in August compared to the same period last year.

Distributors hail move

Speaking to *The Hindu*, LPG distributors' associations welcomed the move.

Chandra Prakash, president of the All-India LPG Distributors Federation, said certain distributors categorised as rural were actually located in areas that had later developed into full-fledged urban centres, such as Noida in Uttar Pradesh and Navi Mumbai in Maharashtra. The Petroleum Ministry's move will benefit such distributors, he said.

Mr. Prakash assured that distributors would be able to meet the demand arising from the revision in the booking interval. "There will not be a massive surge in demand with the move. India's oil marketing companies have diversified their procurement, and we have augmented our domestic production as well. We do not foresee any shortage even in the upcoming festival season," Mr. Prakash said.

Pawan Soni, general secretary of the Federation of LPG Distributors of India, also said the Ministry's move would benefit distributors that come under the rural categorisation.

14 arrested as M.P. spurious liquor tragedy toll reaches 13

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

The official death toll in the hooch tragedy in Madhya Pradesh's Sagar district reached 13 after two more people succumbed during treatment on Monday. State Congress president Jitu Patwari, however, alleged that the count was more than 50 after visiting affected villages.

The police, meanwhile, continued its crackdown and arrested 14 people linked to the network of spurious liquor, allegedly supplied from Uttar Pradesh's Lalitpur, officials said. A magisterial inquiry led by a sub-divisional magistrate has been ordered into the matter. The government has also announced a compensation of ₹4 lakh to the families of each of the deceased.

ED searches 7 places linked to Trinamool MP Nadimul Haque

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

The Enforcement Directorate on Monday morning began search operations across seven premises in Kolkata, Delhi and Ranchi as part of a money laundering investigation against Trinamool Congress Rajya Sabha MP Nadimul Haque, who is the proprietor of an Urdu daily.

Since 2004, the 56-year-old Mr. Haque, a journalist and businessman, has been serving as director of Akhbar-E-Mashriq Pvt Ltd, which publishes the daily *Akhbar-E-Mashriq*. Founded in 1980, the daily circulates its editions across six cities: Delhi, Kolkata, Ranchi, Lucknow, Bhopal, and Srinagar.

The MP has served as the head of the West Bengal Urdu Akademi.

Arunachal and Aksai Chin shown between claim lines

World map endorsed at UN depicts the two places as distinct regions between claims by India and China; in the case of the LoC, there is a note stating that it is agreed upon by India and Pakistan

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

A new world map that was endorsed at the UN during the India-backed "Correct the map" resolution of September 4 in the UN General Assembly has projected India's Arunachal Pradesh and Aksai Chin, which India has maintained is a part of Ladakh, as distinct regions caught between Indian and Chinese "claim lines".

The map, which came up on July 1 during the months-long discussion for the UNGA resolution, shows Arunachal's southern State border with Assam, indicating the "Chinese line" while eliminating the State's border with Nagaland. It shows the State's northern border, indicating the "Indian line". Similarly, the map shows Aksai Chin's eastern borders, indicating the "Indian line" while presenting the western borders of Aksai Chin in what appears to be the "Chinese line". These "claim lines" appear to be a continuation of previous similar maps of the UN. But unlike



Fine lines: A section of the world map published by the United Nations in July 2026. UN.ORG

in the 2011 map of the UN, these lines are not specified as "claim lines" in the July 1 map.

The map depicts Jammu and Kashmir with a dotted line indicating the Line of Control (LoC) between India and Pakistan. However, the issue of the LoC is clearly mentioned in a brief note on the map, explaining the "dotted line represents approximately the Line of Control in Jammu and Kashmir agreed upon by India and Pakistan. The final status of J&K has not yet been agreed upon by the parties."

But, there is no note on why the "Map of the World" issued by the UN

during the consultation process and endorsed by the "Correct the Map" resolution sponsored by Togo and supported by the African Union depicted Arunachal and Aksai Chin as territories caught between Indian and Chinese claim lines. The map is non-binding, but it will be used by multilateral institutions worldwide.

Discussions on the map began in March 2026 when the African Union supported the "Equal Earth cartographic projection to more accurately represent Africa". African Union called this approach "cognitive justice". Subsequently, Togo prompted UNGA con-

Defence acquisition proposals worth ₹1.10 lakh crore cleared

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

The Defence Acquisition Council (DAC), chaired by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, on Monday accorded Acceptance of Necessity (AoN) for a range of acquisition proposals for the armed forces estimated at ₹1.10 lakh crore, with approximately 98% of the procurements planned to be from Indian industry.

According to the Defence Ministry, for the Army, the DAC approved the procurement of chemical, biological, radiological and nuclear (CBRN) reconnaissance vehicles, high mobility vehicles (HMTVs), self-propelled mechanical mine layers (MMLs), advanced light helicopters (ALHs), trawl tanks and the Sarvatra Bridge System.

The trawl tanks and the Sarvatra Bridge System will



Rajnath Singh

provide composite crossing capability to fighting formations during operations in varied terrains.

Domestic boost

For the Navy, the DAC granted AoN for the procurement of Arudhra radars and the design, development and subsequent procurement of marine gas turbines (MGTs).

The Arudhra radars will replace existing air route surveillance radars at va-

rious naval air stations. Indigenous development of MGTs, which are crucial for warship propulsion, is expected to reduce dependence on foreign vendors.

For the Air Force, the Council approved several proposals aimed at enhancing the war-fighting capabilities of its fighters, transport aircraft and helicopters.

The DAC also cleared the procurement of ground-based multi-purpose jammers (GBMPJ), which will provide effective jamming capability against radars. Approval was also accorded for the installation of the Defence Forces Secure Access Card (DEFSAC) system, which will replace existing paper-based identity cards, passes and permits with interoperable radio frequency identification (RFI)-based smart cards.

Devesh K. Pandey
NEW DELHI

A centuries-old underground banking system is now transforming into a tech-enabled network, with virtual assets adding new layers to "digital hawala". The shift is being exploited for purposes ranging from routine money laundering to, in some cases, financing terrorist organisations, the latest Financial Action Task Force (FATF) report said.

The global money laundering and terror financing watchdog's report, titled "Investigating Professional Money Laundering, Underground Banking, and the Use of Hawala and Other Similar Service Providers", identifies the fusion of virtual assets with the traditional "hawala" system as one of the most significant developments. According

Manipur govt. to update NRC with 1951 as base year

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI



Konthoujam Govindas

Manipur Home Minister Konthoujam Govindas on Monday informed the 60-member Assembly that the National Register of Citizens (NRC) in the State would be updated using 1951 as the base year.

Manipur is divided on the NRC issue, for which the Centre recently deferred the Census exercise in the State. While Meitei and Naga organisations want the NRC before the Census and delimitation, Kuki organisations have called it "premature and unjustified".

Mr. Govindas said that the State government would pursue the implementation of the NRC with the Centre in line with the resolutions adopted by the House. He cited certain figures to justify the resolutions (2022, 2024, and on September 2).

He told the House that 14,992 out of 24,475 "illegal immigrants" detected in the State so far have been pushed back into Myanmar. The immigrants entered the country through three border districts — Chandel, Kamjong, and Tengnoupal. Manipur has been grappling with the in-

flux of undocumented Myanmar nationals since the military coup in the neighbouring country in February 2021. Insisting that the pushback process was being carried out through diplomatic channels, Mr. Govindas said the government instructed the Deputy Commissioners concerned to segregate the "illegal immigrants" from local Indian communities.

The Kuki-Zo Council on Monday urged the Centre to conduct the Census operation in the State, insisting that "politically motivated demands" should not obstruct it.

In a memorandum to Union Home Minister Amit Shah, the KZC said any decision concerning the NRC remained within the Centre's constitutional and legal authority and was not driven by "unsubstantiated" allegations of demographic changes.

Watchdog report warns of rise in tech-driven hawala network

to the report, nearly 70% of surveyed jurisdictions have reported the integration of new technologies into such networks.

Forms of digital hawala

The study has flagged six forms of "digital hawala" — a term covering a spectrum of technologies that facilitate the coordination, execution, settlement, or concealment of transactions.

One configuration involves digital coordination but traditional settlement, with operators using encrypted messaging applications, shared ledgers and online platforms to communicate instructions, recruit clients and couriers, and maintain records. The second is "digital customer interface", such as mobile wallets or fintech apps, although settlement between operators happens

Manipur musician killed in Delhi; 7 held, minor detained for lynching

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A musician from Manipur, Chongtham Vikram Singh, living in Delhi's Ashram area, died on Monday of injuries suffered in an alleged assault by a group on Sunday night.

The Delhi Police, which registered an FIR under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) for mob lynching, arrested seven men and detained a 15-year-old boy in connection with the case.

The accused were engaged in packaging and delivering food from nearby dhabas and were aged between 15 and 36, the police said.

Prior threats

In his complaint to the police, Yaiphaba, the victim's son, said his father had told him on the way to the



Chongtham Vikram Singh

hospital that people from a nearby dhaba had attacked him. Some of them had previously threatened Singh after he complained of excessive noise, the complaint said.

Singh, a guitarist and musician from Imphal, has been part of rock bands but has not been working for the past few years. He was also a music teacher.

Former Manipur Chief Minister and BJP leader N.

Biren Singh said he was "deeply saddened" and "deeply concerned by the incident". "With evidence now emerging in connection with the incident, I urge the Delhi Police to take swift and appropriate action, thoroughly investigate the matter, and ensure that justice is delivered at the earliest," he said.

FIR registered

The Delhi Police registered an FIR against unknown persons under Sections 103(2) (involves murder on the grounds of race, caste or community by a group of five or more persons) and 3(5) (crimes committed by a group with common intent) of BNS.

The police said that "the circumstances leading to his assault and death are being ascertained and necessary legal action is being taken as per law". The

police have identified the arrested as Bharat Kumar, Pramod, Ramzan Khan, Deepanshu, Mohan Vishwakarma, Vijay, and Mannu.

Around 11.30 p.m. on Sunday, Yaiphaba and his mother were at home when they heard loud noises and Singh screaming. Yaiphaba said that when he opened the door, he found four to five people assaulting his father, "kicking and punching him". When he raised an alarm and tried to stop them, the attackers fled. Yaiphaba said he had seen the faces of some attackers.

Yaiphaba and his mother took Singh to a private hospital where he died on Monday morning. His family members said the body was taken to the All Institute of Medical Sciences for a post-mortem examination.

'Hindutva influencer' sent to judicial custody

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A Delhi court on Monday remanded Hindutva influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj to 14 days in judicial custody in connection with the alleged assault of the father of a student during a protest at Jantar Mantar in July organised by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP).

Additional Sessions Judge Saurabh Pratap Singh Laler of the Patiala House Courts passed the order after Mr. Bhardwaj was produced before the court following the completion of his one-day police custody. The court had remanded him to police custody for a day on Saturday. He will be produced before the court again on September 21. Mr. Bhardwaj was detained in Uttar Pradesh on Friday.

EC announces byelections to six seats on October 6

Two Assembly constituencies in T.N., two in Bengal, one in Puducherry, and a Lok Sabha seat in Assam are going to the polls; focus on Rejinagar and high-profile Nandigram, vacated by Suvendu

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission on Monday announced that byelections in five Assembly constituencies in West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, and Puducherry, and one Lok Sabha constituency in Assam would be held on October 6.

The nomination process will remain open until September 16, and counting will be held on October 9. The election process would be completed by October 11.

The byelections were necessitated following the resignations of elected legislators across the three States and the Union Territory for various reasons.

In Tamil Nadu, vacancies arose in Madurantakam (SC) and Dharapuram (SC) following the resignations of Maragatham Kumaravel and P. Sathyabama, respectively. Ms. Kumara-



A file photo shows people waiting to exercise their franchise in the Tamil Nadu Assembly polls in Chennai in April. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

vel and Ms. Sathyabama both had been elected on AIADMK ticket in the 2026 Assembly polls and resigned to join Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam.

In Puducherry, the Thattanchavady constituency opened up after the resignation of N. Rangasamy. The Chief Minister had won from both Thattanchavady and Mangalam seats and decided to give up the former.

In West Bengal, Rejinagar and the high-profile Nandigram are up for election following the resignations of Humayun Kabir and Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari, respectively. Mr. Adhikari decided to retain the Bhabanipur seat, where he had defeated then incumbent Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee.

Offered to Mamata
Mr. Kabir, a former Trinamool Congress leader who

floated the AJUP after his expulsion from the party, won from both Nowda and Rejinagar and decided to retain the former. He has offered the Rejinagar seat to Ms. Banerjee to contest. It remains to be seen whether Ms. Banerjee will choose either Nandigram or Rejinagar to make a return to the Assembly.

In Assam, the Nagaon Lok Sabha constituency is going to the polls following the resignation of Pradyut Bordoloi. He had won on Congress ticket in 2024. He subsequently joined the BJP and won from Dispur in the Assembly polls.

Two other Lok Sabha seats—Shillong in Meghalaya and Basirhat in West Bengal – remain vacant, and polls have not been scheduled there yet.

The Model Code of Conduct will come into effect immediately in the districts encompassing the poll-bound constituencies, the EC said in a statement.

Rahul seeks accountability for Delhi building collapse

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Accusing the BJP government of evading accountability for the Satya Niketan building collapse in Delhi, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Monday targeted Prime Minister Narendra Modi, saying Mr. Modi puts labels such as “dimagi Naxal” (intellectual Naxal) and “naraaz phooph” (angry uncle) on anyone who asks questions.

“There is no accountability,” Mr. Gandhi said in a post on X, asking what explained the “helplessness” of a “triple engine” government in Delhi.

The lack of action stemmed from a “lack of intent”, Mr. Gandhi alleged, adding that the government followed a “shameful pattern” of taking no preventive action before accidents, followed by grandstanding and attempts to fix responsibility on lower-level officials after tragedies.

“The collapse of the building packed with students at Satya Niketan is no



Rahul Gandhi

isolated tragedy,” he said, referring to six deaths in a building collapse in Saidulajab and 22 deaths in a fire in Hauz Rani in the last four months. Those demanding accountability were instead being “shamed, defamed and silenced”.

‘Four-engine govt.’

At a press conference, Congress leader Kanhaiya Kumar, accompanied by National Students’ Union of India (NSUI) president Vinod Jhakhar, stepped up the attack, calling the BJP’s “four-engine government” in Delhi a “killing machine”.

Mr. Kumar pointed out that apart from the Union

and Delhi governments, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi was also controlled by the BJP and the Lieutenant-Governor with executive powers was appointed by the Centre. He also questioned the Prime Minister’s absence from the site, pointing out that Mr. Modi had addressed students at Delhi University’s Shri Ram College of Commerce on Saturday. “Narendra Modi went to SRCC for his PR, so why didn’t he go to Satya Niketan?” Mr. Kumar asked.

The Congress demanded inspection of all paying guest accommodations, construction of hostels within Delhi University, a rent control law for hostels and paying guest accommodations, and compensation of at least ₹1 crore to each bereaved family.

Party leader Abhishek Dutt alleged that the scrapping of Section 466(A) of the Delhi Municipal Corporation Act through the Jan Vishwas Act had weakened criminal action against builders undertaking illegal or dangerous construction.

Inflation puts festive cheer under strain, says Congress

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Monday said rising prices of essential commodities had put a strain on household budgets ahead of the festive season, and accused the Union government of resorting to “statistical jugglery” instead of containing inflation.

Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh said inflation’s “high-voltage shock” was weighing on the joys of festivals, with prices of several food items rising sharply. “Wholesale prices of onions have doubled in just three weeks. Sugar has risen by 25%,” Mr. Ramesh said in a post on X. Prices of arhar, urad, mustard and refined oil had also increased, while almonds, cashews, pistachios, raisins and walnuts had become costlier ahead of Deepavali, he said.

“Statistical jugglery cannot hide the impact of inflation. The public is watching everything,” he said.

13 lakh voters deleted from Delhi’s electoral rolls in pre-SIR phase

Suruchi Kumari
Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

Pooja Devi, 38, has been living at the same address in Kalkaji for the past two decades, employed in domestic work. When the special intensive revision of electoral rolls began in the national capital in June, however, she did not get any enumeration form. Once the draft roll was published, she hoped to find her name in the list of those removed because they were absent, shifted, dead, or with duplicate names, but her name was missing there too.

“My husband and children received their forms but I did not. I had also voted in the 2025 polls with them. My name is nowhere,” she said, flummoxed by the booth-level officer’s claim that no form was generated in her name.

Ms. Devi seems to be among the 13.39 lakh voters whose names were deleted from the electoral roll in Delhi this year, even before the SIR process started in June, according to *The Hindu’s* analysis of data available on the website of Delhi’s Chief Electoral Officer (CEO).

At the time of Assembly elections in February 2025, Delhi’s electorate stood at 1.56 crore. By June 16 this

year, when the electoral roll was frozen before the SIR started, this had dropped to 1.45 crore, a decrease of 11.01 lakh names.

After the SIR started, a further 47.56 lakh names have been deleted in the draft roll published on August 31, meaning that so far, 37.6% or well over a third of the voters in the roll during the 2025 Assembly polls are no longer part of Delhi’s electorate.

Delhi CEO Ashok Kumar and his office did not respond to *The Hindu’s* queries, including whether notices were served on those whose names were deleted during the pre-SIR mapping exercise.

According to the Election Commission’s rules, continuous updation of the electoral roll happens through individual applications for new enrolments or objections, with BLO field verification required in cases of unregistered deaths and shifting of voters, only after receiving Form-7. In all such cases, a notice must be issued. The Electoral Registration Officer can also take up deletions, corrections, or shifting of names *suo motu*, based on the BLO’s field report. There is no draft roll or claims and objections period for such routine updating exercises, unlike for special revisions.

Rahul Gandhi interviews candidates for AICC posts

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Monday interviewed several party workers as the party’s high command looks to appoint new All India Congress Committee (AICC) secretaries.

Though the exact number of candidates is not known, sources said that 30 to 40 people were interviewed in separate batches.

The move is part of the high command’s attempt to bring in new faces and give representation to Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and Other Backward Classes.

AICC secretaries are attached to general secretaries handling different States and departments.

India’s carbon credit scheme receives U.K. recognition: official

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

In a major breakthrough, the U.K. has recognised India’s Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS) as a qualifying criterion for pricing relief under its carbon border adjustment mechanism (CBAM), a move that would reduce the tax burden on domestic exporters, an official said on Monday.

In a communication addressed to the Bureau of Energy Efficiency, Ministry of Power, the U.K.’s His Majesty’s Treasury confirmed that the CCTS has been included in the U.K.’s published indicative list of overseas carbon pricing schemes assessed as qualifying criteria under a provision of the Carbon Bor-



The recognition is expected to reduce tax burden on Indian exporters. GETTY IMAGES

der Adjustment Mechanism (Calculation of CBAM Rate and Determination of Carbon Price Relief) Regulations 2026, the official said.

“This will reduce the effective CBAM liability on Indian goods, directly benefiting Indian exporters,” the official said.

Gujarat to host National Film Awards for first time

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The National Film Awards ceremony will take place in Gujarat for the first time on September 22, with the 72nd edition scheduled in Ekta Nagar. President Droupadi Murmu will present the awards, government officials said on Monday.

The move to Ekta Nagar marks a departure from the awards’ traditional venue in Delhi. The first National Film Awards ceremony was organised here in 1954, and Delhi has hosted most of the subsequent ceremonies. The Awards have been presented outside Delhi before – the 17th and 18th editions were held in Madras (now Chennai) in 1970 and 1971, as per reports.

The winners of the 72nd National Film Awards, announced in July, include *Article 370* as the best feature film. Yami Gautam has been named as the best actress for the same film. Mammootty and Kartik Aaryan will share the best actor award for their performances in *Bramayugam* (Malayalam) and *Chandu Champion* (Hindi) respectively.

Randeep Hooda has won the best debut director award for *Swatantrya Veer Savarkar*.

Quota will put more women in political leadership: Om Birla

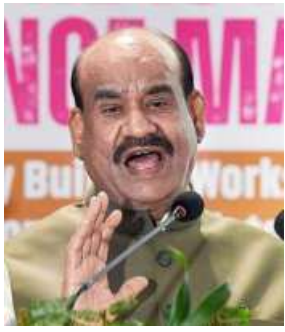
The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Monday said the proposed 33% reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and Legislative Assemblies would open new avenues for women’s political leadership, stressing that the role of women must move beyond receiving support, to shaping policies and laws.

Inaugurating a two-day all-India capacity building workshop on gender-responsive governance”, organised by the National Commission for Women (NCW), in Faridabad, Mr. Birla said the day was not far when women would account for more than 50% of those in public services.

The focus should shift from merely providing women with support and opportunities to enabling them to actively determine policies, programmes, and legislation addressing their concerns and aspirations, he said.

Women legislators in Parliament, Assemblies, panchayats and municipalities could play a decisive



Lok Sabha Speaker addresses participants at a workshop in Faridabad on Monday. ANI

role in ensuring that laws reflected ground-level realities. Institutions such as the NCW also had an important role in identifying emerging challenges and facilitating solutions.

India could not achieve the goal of becoming a developed nation without the economic and social empowerment of women, who constitute nearly half the population, he said.

He also urged women legislators to share successful initiatives and strengthen awareness among women, especially those in vulnerable sections, about laws and institutional mechanisms available to address their concerns.

Congress SC, ST MPs to petition President over ‘purification’ row

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Thirty-two Congress MPs belonging to the Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe communities on Monday decided to petition President Droupadi Murmu over the alleged “purification yajna” held in Uttarakhand’s Haldwani following a rally addressed by party president Mallikarjun Kharge.

In a meeting at the Congress headquarters, the MPs described the incident as a grave assault on the dignity and self-respect of SCs and STs and a direct af-

front to the constitutional values of equality and abolition of untouchability.

“We discussed the shocking purification incident in Haldwani following Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge’s rally. We have decided to form a parliamentary forum to fight this at all levels. We will be submitting a representation to the President of India on Tuesday,” Lok Sabha member Mallu Ravi said.

The MPs finalised a memorandum seeking the President’s intervention and appropriate action. They also decided to con-

stitute a parliamentary forum to take up issues concerning SC and ST communities.

Congress leaders K. Raju and Rajendra Pal Gautam also attended the meeting. Mr. Raju said the proposed forum would discuss a strategy for raising issues concerning SCs and STs in Parliament.

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi had condemned the incident that happened on August 11 and demanded an FIR be registered under the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act against those responsible.

**MAHATRANSCO**
Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.

NOTICE INVITING TENDER CPD/41-2026-27

Tenders are invited through e-Tendering in SRM Two Bid system from the registered vendors for Supply of following:

Tender No. & Description of Material	Estimated Amount (in Rs. Lakhs)	Due Date & Time (Hrs.) for Submission & Opening of Tender
	Tender Fee (in Rs.)	
SP/T-0509/0926 RFx 5000001604 (3rd Call) for Procurement of 420kV, 2x80MVA Switchable Line Reactor along with New Uninhibited Naphthenic Based High Grade Mineral Insulating Oil required for 400kV Kumbhargaoon Sub-Station	3378.39	15.09.2026 17:00 Hrs.
	25,000.00	15.09.2026 17:15 Hrs.
Pre-Bid Meeting:	Date: 08.09.2026 Time: 16:30 Hrs.	Venue: 8th Floor, MSETCL, "Prakashganga", BKC, Bandra (E), Mumbai

Contact Person: Office of the Executive Engineer (Gr-V) CPA, C.O. MSETCL, 1st Floor, Prakashgad Building, Bandra (E), Mumbai
Tel. No.: 022-69852717/69852720
Email id: cecpa@mahatransco.in, secpa@mahatransco.in, eegrp5@mahatransco.in
For further details visit our website <https://srmetender.mahatransco.in/>
Any further amendments/clarifications will be published on the MSETCL website www.mahatransco.in & <https://srmetender.mahatransco.in/>.
Bidders are therefore requested to check these websites for further updates.
Sd/- Executive Engineer (P&C)

**TIRUMALA TIRUPATI DEVASTHANAMS - TIRUPATI**
Office of the Chief Engineer
TENDER NOTICE
ADV No.30/D3/CE/TTD/2026-27, NIT No.426 /SE-II/TTD/ 2026 -27 dt:06-09-2026
Name of work:1) Laying of additional MS Pipe Line from Gogarbhram Dam to Filter plants at main Filter House, Tirumala. **Amount Rs.600 Lakhs,Time for Completion:12 months.**
NOTE: For full details, log on to the Website <https://www.tirumala.org>.
TTD-40021(31)/1/2026-PRO SEC(Adv.No.175) Date:07-09-2026 **EXECUTIVE OFFICER**

**AI Living Labs AI LIVING LABS FOUNDATION**
Government of Andhra Pradesh Initiative
Notification for Recruitment | 12 Contract Posts | Amaravati
Applications invited for 01-year Contract positions: Chief Executive Officer (01), Chief Technology Officer (01), Chief Operations Officer (01), Manager-Finance & Admin (01), Project Manager (01), Platform Engineer (01), Office Manager (01), Partnership Manager (02), Capability Development Specialist (01), AI Ecosystem Coordinator (01), Capability Development Manager (01).
Apply Online: <https://aillivinglabs.ap.gov.in/careers>. **Last Date: 20-09-2026.**
DIPR 5403PPICL, Dt.07-09-2026 **Sd/- Chairman, AI Living Labs Foundation**

PUNJAB STATE WAREHOUSING CORPORATION
SCO 74-75, BANK SQUARE, SECTOR-17B CHANDIGARH
PBX: 0172-5197847, 5197846
NOTICE INVITING TENDER
PSWC invites online tenders through GeM Portal for creation of 1.45 LMT godown capacities at 04 locations in the State of Punjab for guaranteed lease of 10 years on Build, Own and Operate/Lease basis for storage requirements of FCI under two bid system "Technical Bid" and "Financial Bid".
NIT (alongwith GeM Bid IDs) is available on Department's website i.e. <https://pswc.in>
PSWC reserves the right to scrap the tender at any stage without assigning any reason and PSWC will not be held liable for any costs and consequences incurred by the intending bidders.
Note: Any corrigendum(s)/Notification(s) to this Notice Inviting E-Tender shall be published Department's website & GeM Portal.
1004/12/2026-27/14913 Managing Director, PSWC

INBRIEF



SC questions U.P. police over journalist's digital data

The Supreme Court on Monday asked the Uttar Pradesh Police why they needed the digital footprint of Abhishek Upadhyay, an independent journalist who flagged the alleged misappropriation of donations to the Ayodhya Ram temple, in order to investigate a road-rage case registered against him. The Bench, headed by CJI Surya Kant, and comprising Justices V. Mohana and Joymalya Bagchi, directed the Ghaziabad Police Commissioner to file an affidavit detailing the information sought from social media platform X for investigating the FIR registered against Mr. Upadhyay.

Assam woman's severed head found in fridge; husband held

The Assam police recovered a partially decomposed and headless body of a woman in Guwahati on Sunday night. The severed head was found, wrapped in a polythene bag, in the refrigerator at the apartment she had been living in since her marriage in September 2025. Her fingers were allegedly cut off. The police identified the woman as 25-year-old Riya Talukdar, who worked in a boutique. Her cab driver husband, Ramanujan Goswami, was arrested after he surrendered to the police. The murder came to light after neighbours complained of a foul smell emanating from the flat and informed the police.

States told to furnish details of facilities for senior citizens

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday directed all States and Union Territories to file fresh status reports detailing the number of old-age homes and the facilities available to senior citizens across the country. A three-judge Bench headed by CJI Surya Kant asked Attorney General R. Venkataramani to communicate the direction to the Advocates General and standing counsel of all States and Union Territories, requiring them to furnish the latest information within four weeks. The Bench was hearing a public interest litigation petition filed in 2016 by former Union Minister and senior advocate Ashwini Kumar concerning the welfare of senior citizens, particularly those living without adequate shelter, food or medical care.

Civil Service candidates await Centre's word on foundation course amid case in top court

Abhinav Lakshman
NEW DELHI

The 958 candidates recommended by the Union Public Service Commission in the 2025 Civil Services Examination (CSE) are now in limbo over their service allocation and the starting date of their foundation course. While the course was expected to begin in August, several candidates told *The Hindu* they have received no communication regarding the way forward. The delay follows the Centre's application to the Supreme Court asking permission for the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) to allocate services without implementing the court's March 11 *Rohith Nathan* judgment. That ruling found the DoPT was incorrectly excluding certain Other Backward Classes (OBC)

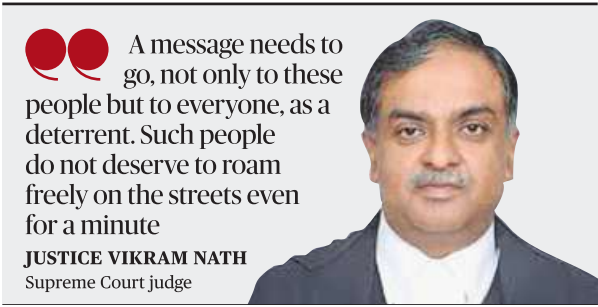
The delay follows the Centre's application to the Supreme Court regarding the Rohith Nathan judgment

candidates from reservation by concluding they belonged to the creamy layer based only on their parents' salary income. The court directed corrective measures within six months. The CSE 2025 results were declared on March 6, days before the judgment. Now, while the Supreme Court is set to hear the Centre on September 17, candidates recommended for the Civil Services told *The Hindu* they have "no idea" what their future pathway looks like. "The foundation course has not started. I have received no communication from the DoPT or the academy

about when the foundation course will start. There was a schedule that said it was to start on August 24 tentatively, but since the Supreme Court became seized of the matter, we have not heard anything," one candidate said. Another candidate said that they have not been able to see any updates regarding the next steps on the website of the DoPT or the website of the Lal Bahadur Shastri National Academy of Administration, where they will be trained. A third candidate said that they are now waiting to see how the next hearing in the Supreme Court goes. "I believe the government is also waiting for the Supreme Court," the candidate said, adding that since the court is going to look at the issue of service allocation, no news of the foundation course can be expected until then.

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday said those who assault doctors and hospital staff "do not deserve to roam on the streets even for a minute", prompting a Maharashtra corporator accused of attacking three municipal doctors in Thane to withdraw his plea after the Bench indicated that it could examine the cancellation of his bail. A Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta was hearing a plea filed by Shiv Sena corporator Ramesh Sukrya Mhatre challenging the Bombay High Court's July 18 order staying the bail granted to him by the trial court, as well as its August 7 order imposing stringent conditions on his release, including that he remain outside Maharashtra until the commencement of the trial. The court also referred to a recent incident in Palghar, where 17 Shiv Sena workers were booked for allegedly assaulting staff at a hospital on September 5 following a dis-



pute over the treatment of a 19-year-old man injured during a Dahi Handi celebration. "We are going to issue notice on the State's appeal. Yesterday, again the same group of people have assaulted doctors and hospital staff in Palghar," the Bench said, adding that there appeared to be a "propensity to do these things". Senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi, appearing for Mr. Mhatre, clarified that those booked in the Palghar incident were not the same persons accused in the Thane case. He then sought permission to withdraw Mr. Mhatre's plea, saying he wanted to "put a quietus to this here". Justice Nath, however,

said the court needed to send a larger message against attacks on medical professionals. "A message needs to go, not only to these people but to everyone, as a deterrent. Such people do not deserve to roam freely on the streets even for a minute," he said. Accordingly, the Bench issued notice on the Maharashtra government's appeal challenging the bail granted to Mr. Mhatre and three other accused and directed that it be listed on September 28. It also allowed Mr. Mhatre to withdraw his petition. The case stems from an alleged assault on three doctors at the Kalyan Dombivli Municipal Corporation-run Shastri Nagar Hospital in Dombivli, Thane district, on July 6. Mr. Mhatre and others allegedly attacked the doctors after they advised that a pregnant woman be shifted to another hospital as all beds in the neonatal intensive care unit (NICU) were occupied. The Bombay High Court subsequently initiated *suo motu* proceedings and, on July 18, stayed the bail granted to Mr. Mhatre and the other accused by the trial court. They surrendered the following day and were lodged at Aadharwadi Jail in Kalyan. On August 7, however, the High Court granted bail to Mr. Mhatre and some of the other accused, subject to stringent conditions. It directed them to remain outside Maharashtra until the commencement of the trial, while allowing them to enter the State for the framing of charges. They were also directed to stay away from the complainant doctors. The High Court had further directed the Maharashtra government to provide adequate protection to the three doctors who were allegedly assaulted.

SC refuses extension for Aravalli panel to submit final report

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI



The committee has been tasked with evolving a uniform definition of the Aravalli hills.

While rejecting a six-month extension sought by a Supreme Court-appointed high-powered committee tasked with defining the Aravalli hills and range, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Monday questioned whether it was "waiting for his retirement". The court directed the panel to submit its final report by November 30. "They should have clearly asked for a date after my retirement... It appears they are waiting for my retirement. We are not going to allow this," the CJI told Additional Solicitor-General Aishwarya Bhati, appearing for the Centre. CJI Kant is due to demit office on February 9, 2027. The Bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V. Mohana, made it clear that no further extension would be granted, and directed the five-member panel, headed by Indian Council of Forestry Research and Education Director General Kanchan Devi, to "work day and night" to finalise its recommendations. The committee has been tasked

with evolving a uniform definition of the ecologically fragile Aravalli hills and range, and recommending measures to regulate future mining. The court asked the committee to submit interim reports on specific issues requiring immediate consideration, without waiting for the entire exercise to be completed. It also directed the panel to hear all stakeholders, including tribal communities in Rajasthan and Gujarat, before finalising its recommendations. The matter will be heard next on December 2, by which time the committee is expected to have submitted its final report.

New script unfolds as Kashmir hosts its inaugural international film festival

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Kashmir, where all 15 cinema halls had closed down in the wake of militancy over three decades, on Monday hosted its first-ever four-day international film festival with the screening of the Lebanese film *Dead Dog*, a drama on the reunion of an estranged couple. Under a multi-layer security cover, director Sarah Francis' movie, the first among 135 films to be screened from 41 countries, was shown at the Inox theatre in Srinagar's Shiv Pora area. The multiplex is the first functional cinema hall to reopen in the valley after 23 years in 2022. Jammu & Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah addressed a gathering at Sher-i-Kashmir International Convention Centre (SKICC) in Srinagar and called the festival "a new



Chief Minister Omar Abdullah at the inauguration of the International Film Festival Jammu and Kashmir in Srinagar. IMRAN NISSAR

chapter in the long-standing relationship between J&K and cinema". "To stand here today under the majestic shade of the chinar trees, surrounded by the sentinel peaks of the Himalayas, is to be reminded that some places on earth do not merely boast stories. They are born of them," said Mr. Abdullah. He said the festival's clear message is about "Kashmir's potential as a

celebration of cinema, it is a declaration of intent," he added. 'Landmark initiative' Inaugurated by Jammu & Kashmir Chief Secretary Atal Dulloo and Directorate of Information and Public Relations director Shreya Singhal, the festival will screen movies at venues in Srinagar's SKICC and Inox, Gulmarg, and Jammu city. It is tipped to be a major "landmark cultural initiative that celebrates the universal language of cinema". "We received around 1,100 entries for the festival. After screening, 135 entries were shortlisted, including more than 60 foreign films. This is an opportunity to reconnect J&K with the world of cinema and invite the film industry not only from the country but also from abroad, and make Kashmir once again a prominent film destination," said Mr. Dulloo.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14893

(set by Vidwan)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY

14 Carry around good German drifter (6)

15 Entire bravest fighting class of spineless ones! (13)

18 Abused the French during invasion (6)

19 Ideal society ignored copulation by faceless, crusading Knight (8)

22 Amorous communication is part of his extroversion (4)

23 I reportedly deceive with diplomacy and direct visual communication (3,7)

26 Escaping from trap, purchase smack or cocaine and crow somehow! (2,4,2,2,5)

Down

1 Try small bill (4)

2 Love working after girl returns to pool (6)

3 Rodent with a painful inflammation on island (6)

4 Case in perpetuity (4)

5 Second person on train, runs to become content developer (8)

6 Desire mostly set in difficult zone between darkness and luminosity (8)

7 Area covering a windy basin where monsoon winds originate (7,3)

12 A peg in secret with English sleuth (7,3)

13 Some young rebellious flyer (5)

16 Will very old and bright one go on regularly? (8)

17 Communist pets for Caucasian countrymen (8)

20 Derived name from money power, perhaps (6)

21 Head Egyptian god, Greek circular dish (6)

24 Rameez Raja hosting a famous rabbi (4)

25 Old fool runs away naked (4)

28

SUDOKU

	7					9		6
	4		5					
1			7					
	3		1		4	2	6	
4			6		7			8
	6	7	8		9		3	
					5			3
					6		5	
2		8					4	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle

METEOR	IGNORES
UACHIN	ELANGU
MAITCE	GLCP
INFERNO	IDEATES
EUFANC	ORON
SALON	KRAIT
RUN	
SET	ROOMY
FEAR	NITIC
MAXIMAL	UMBRAGE
IF	EMRANS
PEROXIDE	BLONDES
REGE	EILSON
OVERDUE	RANCOUR

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

1	3	2	7	5	9	8	6	4
5	4	7	8	2	6	3	9	1
8	6	9	1	4	3	2	7	5
7	1	5	3	9	8	6	4	2
3	2	8	6	1	4	9	5	7
4	9	6	2	7	5	1	8	3
6	8	1	5	3	7	4	2	9
2	5	4	9	8	1	7	3	6
9	7	3	4	6	2	5	1	8

FAITH

Attaining liberation

If a person does not use his birth as a human being to attain liberation, then he may be said to have wasted his life. Being a human being has many advantages, which aid liberation, said R. Narayanan in a discourse. We can use our hands to offer flowers to God. We should see our legs as the means to walk to temples, and to circumambulate the sanctum. Our eyes are intended for looking at the images of God in temples. Our mouths are for singing His praises. The head is given to us to bow prayerfully before the Lord. Appar says to his head, *Thalaiye nee thalai vanangai* (Oh head, bow before Lord Siva). But if we do not use our faculties as they should be used, then of what use is this life? If we pursue pleasures and have no time for God, how can we attain moksha?

Something negative can be countered only by something positive. Birth leads to problems and unhappiness. Repeated births take place because of our ignorance. This ignorance is the negative aspect of our lives, and can be banished only if we worship God. Tirukkural verse 358 talks about getting rid of ignorance. Thiruvachagam says there are 84,000 possible births an atma can have. Manickavachagar says in Thiruvachagam that he has taken birth as a blade of grass, a worm, many kinds of animals and birds, snakes, stones, human beings, ghosts, sages and devas and has suffered in consequence. Avvaiyar says it is rare good fortune to take birth as a human being. She advises that we spend our time in the company of virtuous people. It is imperative that we pay attention to the words of principled people. We must talk about their good qualities and emulate them.

INBRIEF



RBL Bank to raise up to \$1 bn from overseas investors

Private lender RBL Bank on Monday said its board approved the mobilisation of up to \$1 billion from overseas investors through bond issuance. The board approved the establishment of a Euro Medium Term Note Programme (EMTN Programme) in accordance with Regulation S of the US Securities Act, 1933, subject to regulatory, statutory and other approvals, RBL Bank said in a stock exchange filing.

Govt. spurs coal rake loading by 20% to strengthen stock

Loading of coal rakes for supply to the power sector has grown about 20% between September 3 and 6, the Union Coal Ministry said on Monday, adding that it was also closely monitoring thermal plants with stocks below 25% of their normal requirements with measures being taken to ease their supply position. According to data from the Central Electricity Authority, 53 domestic coal-fired plants were operating at the critical normative level as on September 5.

Copper prices head to record high; tight supplies outside U.S.

Copper prices headed toward a record high on Monday, as the prospect of shortages outside the U.S. spurred buying, while the softer dollar reinforced positive sentiment. Traders said that a U.S. holiday meant volumes were likely to be muted, but added that focus was firmly on copper and zinc. Benchmark copper on the London Metal Exchange was up 0.1% at \$14,430 a metric tonne at 0931 GMT, the highest since the all-time peak of \$14,527.50 hit in January.

In a first, alternative fuel vehicles outsell petrol cars in India

CNG, hybrid and electric together overtook petrol in the PV market at 41.95% against the latter's 40.85% in August 2026, FADA data showed

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

The Indian automobile industry retailed 24,23,201 units in August 2026, registering a 17.51% growth year on year (YoY).

However, compared with July 2026, retail sales fell by 6.48% due to the lull in seasonal monsoon and a festival calendar that shifted Ganesh Chaturthi and the spillover of Onam-led buying into September.

Growth was led by Wheeled Construction Equipment at 31.45%, Two-wheelers 19.69%, Passenger Vehicles 16.14%, and Commercial Vehicles 14.45%, while Three-wheelers grew 8.64% and Tractors sales were effectively flat at 0.84%, as per data released by the Federation of Automobile Dealers Association (FADA), Monday.

For the first time in India, alternative fuels – CNG, hybrid and electric combined – overtook petrol in the passenger vehicle (PV) market, at 41.95% against petrol's 40.85%.

“Two-wheelers, passenger vehicles, commercial vehicles, tractors and three-wheelers each set fresh August records, and overall registrations were the highest ever for the month,” said Sai Giridhar, president, FADA.

Two-wheeler retail sales

Ethanol effect

An analysis of automobile retail sales data shows beyond the volume record, fuel mix has reached an inflection point

CNG vehicle sales stood at 25.28%, Hybrids 9.04%, and EVs 7.63%

Electric CV share rose to an all-time high of 5.18% from 2.06% a year ago



Dealers attribute shift to running-cost economics, consumer hesitation around E20 transition

stood at 17,14,610 units, up 19.69% YoY – the best August since 2018 – but down 5.70% MoM.

Share of e-TWs crossed the 10% mark (10.68%) in a non-festival month for the first time, against 7.66% a year earlier.

Commercial vehicle retails came in at 90,769 units, up 14.45% YoY – the best-ever August – though 8.93% lower MoM.

LCVs grew 15.32% YoY, HCVs 13.98% and MCVs 10.38%, with dealers citing infrastructure execution, mining and e-commerce-linked logistics alongside steady financing.

Electric CV share rose to an all-time high of 5.18% from 2.06% a year ago, with e-CV volumes setting a fresh monthly record.

Passenger vehicles retailed at 4,02,398 units, up 16.14% YoY. For the first time, the PV segment has crossed the four-lakh mark in an August though MoM

sales was lower at 3.40%.

Beyond the volume record, the fuel mix reached an inflection point – alternative fuel vehicles (CNG 25.28%, Hybrid 9.04%, EV 7.63%) together touched 41.95%, surpassing petrol vehicles (40.85%) for the first time, though petrol remains the single largest individual fuel.

Dealers attribute the shift to running-cost economics and continuing consumer hesitation around the E20 transition, nudging petrol buyers towards CNG, hybrids and EVs,” Mr. Giridhar said.

PV inventory rose by a further five days over July-end to about 38-40 days, well above FADA's recommended 21-day benchmark, with 56% of PV dealers reporting higher stock MoM, he added.

With three-wheeler EV penetration at 65.30% – the segment is now structurally electric.

JLR to slash 4,000 jobs worldwide in 2 years to save £1.7 bn

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Jaguar Land Rover (JLR), a wholly owned subsidiary of Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles Limited (TMPV), has announced reduction of its global workforce by about 4,000 roles over the next two years as part of a “strategic transformation programme.”

“The reduction, which is not expected to impact direct manufacturing jobs, will be achieved through voluntary means wherever possible,” TMPV said in an exchange filing. “JLR is today beginning consultation on the first round of reductions and will provide support to all colleagues affected by the changes and engage with Trade Unions and employee representatives throughout the transition,” it added in the statement.

“We recognise this will be difficult news for colleagues affected, and are committed to supporting everyone with care, fairness and respect,” JLR CEO P.B. Balaji said in a statement.

JLR said that the “strategic transformation programme” was designed to “simplify the organisation, improve operational performance and support long-term sustainable growth.”

As per JLR's “Growth Reimagined” strategy announced at its Investor Day on 19 June 2026, JLR is targeting approximately £1.7 billion of savings over the next two years to reduce its break-

The reduction is not expected to impact direct manufacturing jobs, according to the company

evens towards 3,00,000 units,” the company said.

The savings, it said, were designed to enhance JLR's ability to deliver sustainable profitable growth, against the backdrop of an increasingly competitive and rapidly changing market and continuing geopolitical uncertainty.

“The programme will reduce organisational complexity, and underpin the commitment to invest between £15-18 billion in electrification, digital technologies, advanced manufacturing and enhanced customer experiences over the next five years,” Mr. Balaji said.

“The automotive industry faces significant challenges, with technological change amidst intense competition and ongoing geo-political uncertainty. Through our Growth Reimagined strategy, JLR is moving decisively to strengthen our competitiveness and position the business for long-term success,” he said.

Over the next 12 months, the company will launch five new products, continue to leverage the strength of its brands, and renew its focus on North America, amongst other markets, to help it deliver double digit revenue growth, he stated.

RBI mops up ₹6 lakh crore in 2 auctions with mixed response

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Monday mopped up over ₹6 lakh crore of excess funds from the banking system in two auctions, which saw an underwhelming response from banks despite surplus liquidity.

The 30-day variable rate reverse repo (VRRR) auction announced last week received a tepid response from banks, and the central bank announced another auction in the first half of the day.

As against ₹7 lakh crore of notified amount, the first auction received a tepid response, with bids of just over ₹2.59 lakh crore being received for the 30-day VRRR, according to an official statement.

The bids for the 30-day VRRR were accepted at the cut-off and weighted average rate of 5.24%, according to the RBI. Soon afterwards, the RBI announced an overnight VRRR auction with a notified amount of ₹5 lakh crore, which was completed at 11:30 hrs.

Market response to the second auction was a tad better, with bids of ₹3,53,390 crore received, which amounts to over 70% of the notified amount, indicating that lenders are comfortable parking funds for a shorter tenure. For the overnight, the RBI accepted the full amount at a cut-off rate and weighted average rate of 5.24%.

There are large inconsistencies between GDP and other economic indicators: says Garg

Kunal Shankar
Santosh V. Perumal

Former Finance Secretary Subhash Chandra Garg has questioned the credibility of India's latest GDP estimates. In an email response to *The Hindu*, he argued the sharp downward revisions to the size of the economy need a far more transparent explanation than the government's invocation of a new methodology, wider coverage and improved data.

At the centre of his concern is the absence of a transparent bridge between the 2011-12 base series and 2022-23 series. Mr. Garg said MoSPI must publish a back-series from 2011-12 to 2021-22 and set a timetable for doing so. “Perfectly valid demand,” he said, arguing absence of such a programme suggested that the government was “not very serious” about resolving the issue.

He was particularly concerned about the reduction in the estimated nomi-



Subhash Chandra Garg

nal size of the economy. The revision in Q1 FY26, he said, was part of a much larger change with GDP for 2024-25 reduced by ₹12.70 lakh crore. The Centre did not adequately explain why the revisions resulted in a smaller economy.

The standard explanation – new series incorporates wider coverage, new data sources and indices – was, in his view, insufficient. “Any better coverage leads to nominal GDP getting increased, not decreased,” he reasoned.

Mr. Garg offered two

possibilities for the revisions: the earlier system overstated GDP on errors such as double counting or the GDP was deliberately overstated to produce stronger growth numbers, and later, written down under the cover of the new series. He gave no evidence of deliberate manipulation but said the scale of the revision made essential a detailed explanation.

He also questioned the price architecture underpinning the latest real-growth estimate. With consumer inflation over 4% and producer-price inflation about 9%, he said, the about 2.5% GDP deflator implied by the latest numbers appeared difficult to reconcile. “There is definitely a serious internal inconsistency,” he said, calling for the underlying price data to be disclosed and explained.

Mr. Garg was equally sceptical of the application of double deflation to manufacturing, arguing international best practices can-

not simply be transplanted without sufficiently granular Indian data. Until the new methodology stabilises, he suggested the older system be run in parallel.

His concerns extend beyond methodology to the independence of the statistical system. India's data infrastructure needs “massive modernisation,” he said, but the statistical system could still produce reliable numbers if there was no “political interest to produce results in a certain direction.” Statisticians needed greater freedom from political control.

No statistical noise

The broader problem, Mr. Garg argued, was the divergence between GDP and other indicators of economic well-being. Weakness in household incomes, employment, consumption and sentiment cannot always be dismissed as statistical noise, he said, particularly when particular data outcomes turn politically sensitive.

GDP itself, he stressed, was not a measure of welfare. India does not adequately publish the “income leg” of national accounts showing how value added is divided between labour, corporations and government. With per-capita GDP still low, he argued India must target 9-10% growth while redistributing income more effectively and reducing unproductive government expenditure.

For Mr. Garg, the government's technical responses have therefore failed to close the credibility gap. Its explanation for the reduction in GDP, he said, remained “officialese, obfuscatory” and “sheds no light.”

He was unequivocal about the central issue: the downward revision in GDP was real and, in his assessment, must ultimately be explained either by an earlier overstatement or by acknowledging earlier growth was artificially inflated. “Nothing can falsify my argument,” he said.

‘50% of Indian firms say macro growth isn’t fully translating’

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Half of Indian businesses reported the country's strong macroeconomic performance either has not translated into improved business performance or has done so partially, as per the latest Confederation of Indian Industry's (CII) Business Outlook Survey.

This finding comes at a time when questions have been raised about whether the Centre's GDP growth numbers are reflective of the ground situation.

However, the composite business confidence score in the CII Business Outlook Survey for July-September 2026, looking at the current situation as well as future expectations, rose to 66 in Q2 from 60.8 in the first quarter of FY27. The score in Q2 of this year was the same as in Q2 last year.

“The sharp improvement reflects strengthening in business sentiments, primarily supported by the easing of disruptions stem-



A sizeable number of firms saw higher demand.

ming from the West Asia conflict,” the survey stated.

The survey covered 238 public sector and private firms from “all industry sectors”, including micro, small, medium and large enterprises, from different regions, the CII said.

The data shows 13.4% of the respondents said “on ground conditions were subdued despite strong macro data” while 36.6% said they saw some improvement in business conditions “but weaker than indicators suggest”.

However, 11.3% of the respondents said business growth “matches or ex-

ceeds macro momentum”.

Another 29.4% said they saw “clear benefits, though somewhat below headline growth”. The survey does not mention how the balance 9.3% voted.

The demand aspect of the survey showed 29.4% of the respondents expect no change in local demand in Q2 vis a vis Q1. Also, another 3.5% expect demand to be more than 20% lower than in Q1 while 6.1% expect demand to be 5-20% lower than in Q1.

The other side of this data is a sizeable number of firms saw higher demand.

“For Q2FY27, 61% of respondents expect demand to rise, while only 9.6% foresee a moderation, a widening of the positive margin over Q1 that signals sustained confidence in end-market conditions,” the survey showed.

“The share expecting demand growth above 20% rises from 12.9% in Q1FY27 to 16% in Q2FY27, indicating that optimism is not just holding but intensifying at the upper end.”

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA - DEPARTMENT OF WATER RESOURCES
OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER,
MURAN DAM DIVISION, KHATIGUDA
AT/PO-KHATIGUDA, DIST-NABARANGPUR, PIN-764085
E-mail I.D.: emurandamddivision@gmail.com

PAPER PUBLICATION NOTICE
e-Tender Call Notice No.: EEMDD-04(04)/2026-27, Dated:-29.08.2026

Bid Documents consisting of work, Estimated Cost of bid document, time of completion, Class of Contractors and the set of terms and conditions of contract and other necessary documents can be seen in Govt. Website i.e. www.tendersodisha.gov.in.

2. Name of the Work	Civil Works
3. No. of Works	01 (One) Number
4. Estimated Cost	Rs.-1.80 Crore (e-TCN SL.No.4)
5. Eligibility of the bidders	'A' & 'B' Class contractors (Odisha P.W.D or equivalent class of other licensing authority) as per Detail Tender Call Notice.
6. Period of completion	04 (Four) Calendar Months
7. Date of Clarification	09.09.2026 to 11.09.2026 Only During Office Hour
8. Time for receipt of bid in the Portal	From 09.09.2026 (11.00 AM) to 24.09.2026 (up to 5:00 P.M.)
9. Date & place of opening of the bids on-line	25.09.2026 (11:00 A.M) O/o The Executive Engineer, Muran Dam Division, At/PO: Khatiguda, District: Nabarangpur, Pin-764085, Odisha
10. Name and address of the Tender Inviting Authority (TIA)	Executive Engineer Muran Dam Division, At/PO: Khatiguda, District: Nabarangpur, Pin-764085, Odisha

Further details can be seen from the e-Procurement portal "<http://tendersodisha.gov.in>"

Executive Engineer, Muran Dam Division, Khatiguda
32001/815/2627 OIPR-32001/32230/1/26-27/0003

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
DEPARTMENT OF WATER RESOURCES
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER & BASIN MANAGER,
SUBARNAREKHA & BUDHABALANGA BASIN,
AT/PO:- LAXMIPOSI, DIST:-MAYURBHANJ. Mail Id : cebmsbb2019@gmail.com
Government of Odisha "e" PROCUREMENT NOTICE
Bid Identification No.- 10/26-27 of CEBM, SBB, Laxmiposi

1. Name of Work	Irrigation Work
2. Total No. of Project	2 Nos.
3. Estimated Cost	Varies from Rs.504.21 Lakhs to Rs.504.28 Lakhs
4. Bid Security / E.M.D.	Details can be seen in the DTCN of bid documents of the respected works
5. Period of Completion	Details can be seen in the DTCN of bid documents of the respected works
6. Class of Contractor	"A" Class
7. Date & Time of availability of bid document in the portal	27.09.2026 at 10.00 AM
8. Last date / time for receipt of bid in the portal	24.09.2026 up to 5.00 PM
9. Date of opening of bid	25.09.2026 at 11:00 A.M.
10. Name & Address of the O.I.T.	Chief Engineer & Basin Manager, O/o the CE&BM, Subarnarekha & Budhabalanga Basin, Laxmiposi, Mayurbhanj.

Further details can be seen from the e-Procurement Portal "<https://tendersodisha.gov.in>"

Chief Engineer & Basin Manager,
Subarnarekha & Budhabalanga Basin, Laxmiposi, Mayurbhanj
32001/820/2627 OIPR-32001/32074/1/26-27/0004

SRM E-Tender Notice (3rd Call)

Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.

Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Company Ltd, EHV PC O&M Zone Vashi invites bids through SRM E-Tender in two bid system (Techno-commercial Bid & Price Bid) from the eligible registered bidders for following works;

RFx No./ Tender No.	Particulars	Estimated Cost
7000041425 T-10/2026-27 (3rd Call)	Work of enhancement of existing corridor of 220kV Kalwa-Mulund-Bhandup-Borivali Line by addition of LILO cable at 220kV Bhandup GIS Substation for Mumbai strengthening under EHV O&M Division Kalwa	Rs. 2060.30 Lakhs excluding GST Rs. 2431.15 Lakhs including GST

E.M.D. in Rs. 20,60,302/-, **Tender Fees:** Rs. 29,500/- including GST, **Sale period:** 07.09.2026 to 17.09.2026, **Last Date of Submission:** 17.09.2026 up to 15:00 Hrs, **Date of opening (Tech. bid):** 17.09.2026 at 15:30 Hrs. (if possible).

Contact person: Executive Engineer, EHV PC O&M Zone, Vashi, Phone No. (022) 27666010 (P)/27665994.

For further details please visit to <https://srmnetender.mahatransco.in>

Sd/-
Chief Engineer
EHV PC (O&M), Zone, MSETCL, Vashi

NUUK

EU announces funding boost for Greenland as Trump seeks control



European Union chief Ursula von der Leyen unveiled plans on Monday for \$232 million of EU investments in Greenland, which President Donald Trump has insisted should belong to the U.S. “The EU stands in full solidarity with the Kingdom of Denmark and the people of Greenland,” Ms. von der Leyen said. REUTERS

JERUSALEM

Israel threatens ‘full-scale war’ on PA in case of October 7-style attack



Israeli Defence Minister Israel Katz has threatened a “full-scale war” against the Palestinian Authority (PA) if it prepared an attack against Israeli forces or settlements similar to the one launched by Hamas from Gaza on October 7, 2023. The remarks came after a stabbing attack in the northern occupied West Bank. AFP

KATHMANDU

Nepal holds a day of mourning as rescuers focus on trapped workers



Nepal held a national day of mourning with candlelight vigils on Monday for victims of devastating glacial floods, as families of missing hydropower workers feared trapped in tunnels prayed rescuers might yet find them alive. The August 26 floods killed at least 1,399 people, with more than 5,500 missing. AFP

BELGRADE

Thousands turn out in Serbia for funeral of convicted war criminal



Bosnian Serb war criminal Ratko Mladic was buried in Belgrade on Monday, in a service attended by thousands, sparking accusations from European Union of the “glorification” of a man who died while serving a life sentence for genocide. Despite his conviction, Serb nationalists continue to paint Mladic as a hero and protector. AFP

U.S. energy facilities in Gulf remain exposed to retaliation, warns Iran

Tehran issues threat after latest clashes with the U.S.; new Hormuz passage maps to be approved soon, ships entering new restricted zone will be added to sanctions list, says Iran’s security head; oil prices near six-week highs after attacks on ships

Reuters
DUBAI

Iran threatened on Monday to retaliate against any new U.S. attacks on its assets, warning that the energy production chain in the region was “sprawling, accessible and exposed” and that U.S. oil and gas companies there shared that exposure.

“Strike our assets and you get struck,” Iranian Parliament Speaker Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf said after U.S. and Iranian strikes on shipping at the weekend that pushed oil prices up to six-week highs at one point on Monday.

On Sunday, senior Ira-



Persian tides: People ride in a boat near vessels in the Gulf waters off the coast of Iran’s port city of Bandar Abbas on Monday. AFP

nian security official Mohsen Rezaei said Iran would announce plans for a new restricted zone in the Gulf in the coming days, and that it would soon approve maps of a new shipping

corridor through the Strait of Hormuz.

Mr. Rezaei said the new restricted zone would begin from where a U.S. naval blockade of Iran starts and extend into areas of the

Gulf. Any ship entering the new zone would be added to an Iranian sanctions list, he said. “We will only commit to the Strait of Hormuz being open when they (the Americans) stop the sabotage, threats and attacks on Iran,” Mr. Rezaei said.

Underlining Iran’s defiance, Mr. Qalibaf issued a new threat to respond to any U.S. strikes, in what appeared to be a response to a warning by U.S. Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth that Iran’s oil tanker fleet was “defenceless”.

“It’s simple: the oil and gas production chain here is sprawling, accessible, and exposed. American oil and gas companies across these waters and facilities

share that exposure,” Mr. Qalibaf, who is Iran’s top negotiator, wrote on X.

Meanwhile, Iran’s Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baqaei on Monday warned South Korea against military deployment or involvement in U.S. operations in the Strait of Hormuz, saying such a move would have “serious consequences”.

On Friday, Seoul said it was considering “contributions” to U.S. security efforts in the Strait of Hormuz. South Korea said it would consider the move provided that its own military readiness was not compromised, but added that no decision had been made.

German far-right AfD wins big in State poll, falls short of majority

Reuters
BERLIN

The Alternative for Germany (AfD) appealed on Monday to lawmakers from Chancellor Friedrich Merz’s conservatives to support its bid to rule Saxony-Anhalt after the far-right party surged into first place in the eastern German State’s election.

The AfD won 43.8% of the vote, official results showed. However, the party fell a little short of winning a majority in its quest to form the country’s first far-right State government since the Second World War. The party has won 39 of the 83 seats in the State legislature, and hopes to win over individual conservative lawmakers.

The election result rais-

es serious questions about the longstanding refusal of Germany’s mainstream parties, including Mr. Merz’s Christian Democrats (CDU), to work with the AfD, a policy known as the “firewall”.

“Politics always means compromise,” AfD leader Tino Chrupalla said, appealing to CDU lawmakers to make a “centre-right conservative majority” in Saxony-Anhalt possible.

German Chancellor Friedrich Merz said on Monday he was “deeply shocked” by his party’s State election defeat at the hands of the far-right AfD.

“This is the heaviest electoral defeat the (CDU party) has suffered in years, in decades,” Mr. Merz said. His party scored just 17.2% of the vote.



An eight-year-old Lebanese boy receives treatment in Nabatieh, after he was injured in the strike.

12 killed in Israeli strikes in southern Lebanon

Agence France-Presse
BEIRUT

Israel conducted a wave of airstrikes in south Lebanon killing 12 people including women and children, the Lebanese Health Ministry said on Monday, in an intensification of violence after a weeks-long lull.

One of the overnight strikes hit a building in the town of Kfar Rumman, killing 11 people, including two children and four women. Another attack in the same town killed a rescuer and wounded another, according to the Ministry.

The Israeli military in a statement said it had struck Hezbollah “infrastructure sites” across southern Lebanon after the launch of two explosive drones towards its troops.

The Army said it “will continue to operate to remove threats while remaining committed to the ceasefire agreement”.

Hezbollah has not claimed any attack since June 20.

Israeli airstrikes and a ground invasion of Lebanon have killed more than 4,300 people since March, according to Beirut.

U.K. govt. slams anti-migrant protests

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON

The U.K. government condemned protests by hundreds of people in Portsmouth, who had gathered until the early hours of Monday morning to protest the arrival of illegal migrants on a dinghy from France. Protesters faced off with police, as they sought to block buses carrying migrants for processing in Kent.

“We condemn the intimidating and thuggish behaviour we saw in Portsmouth last night,” a Home Office spokesperson said in a statement emailed to *The Hindu* and other news organisations.



A migrant tries to board a dinghy from France in an attempt to cross the English Channel.

The words were echoed by government Ministers. The way the protesters behaved “crosses a line”, Treasury Secretary Emma Reynolds said. Police and Crime Com-

missioner for Hampshire and the Isle of White, Donna Jones, who is affiliated to the Conservative Party, said 140 migrants arrived in one boat early on Sunday morning from France.

The Home Office declined to comment on whether any of the migrants who had arrived were Indian nationals.

A day earlier, some 200 protesters took to the streets in the coastal port town of Dover, with visuals of masked men boarding trains and marching along the road chanting, “Whose streets? Our streets.”

Business Secretary Jonathan Reynolds said: “I condemn it. I mean, peaceful protest – essential part

of British life, but that’s not dressing up in costumes like this and disrupting people’s lives.”

Commissioner Jones said the U.K. government had “lost control” of the 100s of miles of British coastline in an interview with Sky News.

The number of protesters had grown to 400-500 by midnight on Sunday, and they stayed on till about 3 a.m. in Eastney, in Portsmouth, Ms. Jones said “when a legal position was agreed” and protesters agreed they had made their point. She said the incidents were a “real wake up call” for the U.K. government over the lack of border control.

King in the rubble



Palestinian children watch a screening of *The Lion King* at camps sheltering displaced people in Sheikh Radwan neighbourhood, north of Gaza City. X/PALESTINE_UN/OMAR ASHTAWY

Sport

Suruchi brimming with excitement ahead of maiden Asiad appearance

SHOOTING

Uthra Ganesan
BHOPAL

Suruchi Phogat first held a pistol in 2019, at the age of 13. She did so because there were no rifles at the Guru Dronacharya Shooting Academy in Bhiwani; and because her father was determined to make her a sports person.

The 20-year-old will be one of the favourites to medal for India in 10m air pistol at the Asian Games later this month, as much because of her performance streak over the past 18 months as her ability to keep things simple.

“Excitement. No ner-



Suruchi. R.V. MOORTHY

vousness, no challenge, nothing. There is only excitement inside me because it is my first Asian Games,” she said, a permanent wide smile on her

face exuding an openness that only accentuates her clarity of thought.

The ‘baby’ of the Indian shooting contingent, Suruchi insisted that everyone was equal in the squad but admitted that certain members of the coaching and sports science staff are slightly more protective, telling her what to do and expect while travelling.

It is a throwback to the time she took the local trains for a 100-km journey from Sasroli village in Jhajjar district of Haryana to the academy.

“My father and brother accompanied me. At that time, of course no one knew but once the results and medals started coming, the regulars on the

train would recognise me.

“They would say they had seen my face in the local newspapers and be curious. I would tell them that I am a shooter.

“It’s not like I suddenly became famous or anything but yes, it was the beginning of a realisation that I am doing something,” she laughed.

Eventful journey

Making the cut for Aichi-Nagoya has been an eventful journey that has seen her win four consecutive World Cups and the World Cup Final, set a National record in 10m air pistol and a World junior record in the process and rise to World No. 3. It is only the beginning.

Priyanka upbeat despite the challenge

ATHLETICS

Ashwin Achal
BENGALURU

Tempted by the prospect of winning a prize, Priyanka Goswami ventured into race walking.

As a young gymnast at the K.D. Singh Babu Stadium Sports Hostel in Lucknow, Priyanka found that she had a flair for track and field.

After taking the big leap of faith, her first test came at a district athletics meet.

“We used to get a bag as a prize at the meet. I tried a few running events, but I could not do well. I did not get even a single bag,” Priyanka said at a media interaction facilitated by the Sports Authority of India here.

Priyanka then noticed



Aiming high: Race walker Priyanka wants to finish on the podium at the Asian Games. K. MURALI KUMAR

that her chances of winning a bag were substantially higher in another event. “There were only three girls in the race walking event. I figured that I could defeat at least one of them,” she said with a laugh.

Priyanka finished third, won her bag and, in the

process, embarked on a new career path.

“As a gymnast, my body was flexible and my technique was good. From there, God took me all the way to the Olympics,” she said, referring to her appearances at the 2020 Tokyo and 2024 Paris Games. In 2022, Priyanka made

history, winning silver, to become the first Indian woman to clinch a race walking medal at the Asian Games.

Priyanka fell just short of another medal at the recent 2026 Commonwealth Games, where a time penalty saw her finish fourth.

The 30-year-old is confident about her chances at the upcoming Asian Games, where the competition from Japan and China pose a mighty challenge.

“It is true that race walking is dominated by Japan and China. If I can get a medal, it will be a big achievement in my life,” Priyanka said.

LEARNING CURVE

The captaincy process leads to immense personal growth: Kishan



R. RAGU

When you are the captain, the first thing is situational awareness, you have to stay alert the entire day on the field to understand what is happening and what isn't. Going through this whole process leads to immense personal growth, and while you might not realise it immediately, your mindset shifts completely — Ishan Kishan.

TEAM FIRST

‘When you are the skipper, it becomes a duty to help players’



R. RAGU

There are many small things we often overlook in our daily routines. You don't look at your players or try to help them figure out how they can get better. But when you are the skipper, it becomes your duty to help them, because if your teammates are improving, ultimately you will achieve the team's goals — Ishan Kishan.

SMOOTH START

Maaya storms into second round of junior singles at New York



FILE PHOTO

Maaya Rajeshwaran outclassed Emery Combs of USA 6-2, 6-2 in the first round of the girls singles at the US Open. The 15th-seeded Indian will take on Arina Malygina in the second round. In the doubles event, Maaya and Antonina Sushkova will meet the American duo of Combs and Olivia De Los Reyes in the first round.

‘SPECIAL MENTOR’

Pietersen joins England coaching team ahead of World Cup



FILE PHOTO

Kevin Pietersen has joined England's white-ball coaching team as a “specialist mentor” in the build-up to next year's World Cup in southern Africa. The former England captain will be part of Brendon McCullum's coaching group for the upcoming T20 and ODI series at home to Sri Lanka later this month, as well as subsequent series.



A thorn in the flesh: Kishan made the South bowlers toil for a second successive day. R. RAGU

Kishan puts South under the pump

The southpaw's blistering double century takes East past the 700-run mark; Kushagra joins the party with a hundred against a hapless attack

DULEEP TROPHY FINAL

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

Ishan Kishan has been on a rollercoaster ride over the last few years. From being part of all three formats in 2023, he hit rock bottom by early 2024 when he was dropped from the BCCI central contract list, partly for his refusal to turn up for the Ranji Trophy.

Since then, the Jharkhand wicketkeeper-batter has been making amends, putting in the hard yards in domestic cricket to forge his way back into India's T20 and ODI squads.

Now, the 28-year-old is showing that he is ready to do the same in the longest format as well. He hammered 270 (334b, 30x4, 7x6) for East Zone against South Zone on day two of the Duleep Trophy final at the MAC Stadium on Monday.

Resuming at 385 for four, East posted a gargantuan total of 708 with Kumar Kushagra (101, 132b,

8x4, 5x6) completing his century. Kishan and Kushagra added 230 for the fifth wicket, pummelling a hapless South attack into submission.

Kishan set the tone with a brace of boundaries off Mohammed Siraj and M.D. Nidheesh. Kushagra soon joined in the act, lofting C.V. Milind and driving Nidheesh down the ground. He raced through his 90s by taking on Shreyas Gopal and brought up his hundred.

South's only hope of staging a comeback was with the second new ball, but Siraj, who bowled just three overs in his first spell, was off-colour yet again.

Post lunch, Kishan tore into Shreyas, smashing the leggie for three boundaries in an over. What stood out in the captain's knock was the way he shunned risks even when he used his feet, often drilling the ball past the bowler all along the ground. He raised his second First Class double century with a searing cover drive off Devdutt Padikkal. After the milestone,

Kishan switched to T20 mode and unleashed a barrage of sixes, lofting spinners Shreyas and T. Vijay with disdain. He needed just 30 more deliveries to raise his bat again – for a 250 – despite battling cramps.

Barring a miracle over the last three days, Kishan has ensured East has one hand on its third Duleep Trophy title.

The scores: East Zone — 1st innings: Abhimanyu Easwaran run out 72, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi c sub (Tanay) b Milind 44, Shikhar Mohan b Milind 85, Sudip Kumar Gharani c Milind b Vijay 6, Ishan Kishan c Smaran b Vijay 270, Kumar Kushagra c Milind b Vijay 101, Anukul Roy lbw b Rasheed 45, Md. Kounain Quraishi c Siraj b Shreyas 40, Mohammed Shami b Shreyas 28, Abhijit Sarkar (not out) 0, Mukesh Kumar c & b Vijay 0; Extras (b-8, lb-2, nb-6, w-1): 17; Total (in 163 overs): 708.

Fall of wickets: 1-100, 2-133, 3-147, 4-241, 5-471, 6-626, 7-680, 8-698, 9-708.

South Zone bowling: Siraj 25-3-140-0, Nidheesh 15-2-58-0, Vijay 42-4-180-4, Milind 21-2-88-2, Shreyas 42-7-165-2, Rasheed 13-0-46-1, Padikkal 4-0-18-0, Bhui 1-0-3-0.

‘Captaincy has helped me become a better batter’

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

One of the hardest tasks for an international cricketer is how they respond to being dropped from the national squad and fight their way back.

And over the last year, Ishan Kishan has shown the way to do it.

“Sometimes, when we play regularly for the Indian team, you just keep playing in a flow. You may be a very good player, which is why you're playing for India, but your growth stagnates at a certain point.

“When you take one step back and go back to



Kishan... in full flow. R. RAGU

domestic cricket, you start from zero again,” said Kishan after smashing 270 for East Zone against South in the Duleep Trophy final

here on Monday.

“You start thinking, ‘I need to get even better,’ because today, there are so many players scoring runs. To get back into the team, your only option is to perform much better than them.

“You get time to reflect on what you missed earlier, why you couldn't convert your starts into big scores. I mean, the batting doesn't change that much; it's just the mindset that changes over time.”

Last year, Kishan led Jharkhand to a convincing Syed Mushtaq Ali title triumph and felt that captaincy had helped him become a better batter.

Alcaraz crushes Paul, runs into Shelton in quarterfinal

US OPEN

Agence France-Presse
NEW YORK

Defending champion Carlos Alcaraz posted his most convincing win in his injury return at the US Open, downing Tommy Paul in straight sets on Sunday to line up a quarterfinal clash with Ben Shelton.

Second-seeded Alcaraz looked closer to his brilliant best in a 6-4, 6-3, 6-4 victory over Paul, the 20th seed. Alcaraz will face red-hot Shelton, a 6-2, 6-3, 6-4 winner over Stefanos Tsitsipas, for a place in the semifinals.

In the women's section, Linda Noskova reached the quarterfinals, edging Ukraine's Marta Kostyuk in three sets. The Czech, who has largely flown under the radar in New York despite winning Wimbledon, beat

THE RESULTS

Men: Fourth round: 2-Alcaraz (Esp) bt 20-Paul (USA) 6-4, 6-3, 6-4; Michelsen (USA) bt 27-Etcheverry (Arg) 7-6(6), 6-4, 6-4; 11-Tiafoe (USA) bt 7-Medvedev 7-6(1), 6-4, 7-6(6); 8-Shelton (USA) bt Tsitsipas (Gre) 6-2, 6-3, 6-4.

Women: Fourth round: 5-Andreeva bt 24-Potapova (Aut) 5-7, 6-4, 6-3; Zheng (Chn) bt 8-Swiatek (Pol) 7-5, 6-3; 6-Noskova (Cze) bt 11-Kostyuk (Ukr) 7-5, 5-7, 6-4; 3-Pegula (USA) bt 16-Cirstea (Rou) 6-3, 6-4; 26-Navarro (USA) bt 21-Kalinskaya 6-4, 6-2.

Kostyuk 7-5, 5-7, 6-4, finally sealing the win on her sixth match point when Kostyuk netted a backhand return.

“I am more than relieved,” Noskova said after booking a last-eight showdown with defending champion Aryna Sabalenka.

American Frances Tiafoe, the 11th seed, booked

his quarterfinal berth with a 7-6(1), 6-4, 7-6(6) victory over former champion Daniil Medvedev. Tiafoe will face compatriot Alex Michelsen, who defeated Argentina's Tomas Martin Etcheverry 7-6(6), 6-4, 6-4, for a place in the semifinals.

Women's third seed Jessica Pegula, one of the players with a chance to supplant Sabalenka atop the rankings in New York, reached the last eight with a 6-3, 6-4 victory over Romanian Sorana Cirstea.

On Monday, Paris Olympics gold medallist Zheng Qinwen, who had to come through qualifying, stunned six-time Grand Slam champion Iga Swiatek 7-5, 6-3 to reach the quarterfinals.

Fifth-seeded French Open champion Mirra Andreeva beat Anastasia Potapova 5-7, 6-4, 6-3 to seal a last-eight berth.



Stroll in the park: Shelton proved too good for Tsitsipas. AP

Knights beat Pipers despite Anand's loss

GLOBAL CHESS LEAGUE

P.K. Ajith Kumar
BENGALURU

Viswanathan Anand rarely plays these days: he is more of a mentor and now the interim president of FIDE. Magnus Carlsen, who dethroned Anand as the World champion in 2013, has relinquished his crown.

Still, when the two all-time greats come across a chessboard, there is a buzz. That was quite palpable at the Lalit Ashok on Monday. They played some interesting chess too, on the third day of the Tech Mahindra Global Chess League, but Anand was unlucky, as he lost on time from an equal position. The five-time World champion, however, could afford to forget his defeat, as his team, PBG Alaskan Knights, won the match against Alpine APL Pipers 9-7. That, in fact, was the first loss in the tournament for Carlsen's team after winning both their matches.

A little later, however, the defending champion bounced back, scoring a crushing 15-3 win against Fyers American Gambits. Carlsen was held to a draw by Javokhir Sindarov, but K. Humpy, Vidit Gujrathi and Volodar Murzin won their

games, with black pieces, to ensure that their team would score heavily.

The Pipers top the table after four rounds. It has nine match points, and 43 game points. As many as four teams are on six points – Mumbai Masters (36 game points), American Gambits (34), Alaskan Knights (30) and Ganges Grandmasters (28). Two-time champion Triveni Continental Kings, which finally managed a victory, has three points.

The results: PBG Alaskan Knights bt Alpine APL Pipers 9-7 (Anand lost to Carlsen; Arjun drew with Anish; Yagiz Kaan bt Vidit; Lagno drew with Divya; Batsiashvili bt Humpy; Abhimanyu drew with Murzin).

Cheq Mumbai Masters bt Ganges Grandmasters 12-3 (Vachier-Lagrave drew with Nepomniachtch; Pranesh bt Aronian; Mamedyarov drew with Dominguez Perez; Harika drew with Shuvalova; Yip bt Tsolakidou; Abhimanyu bt Daneshvar).

Fyers American Gambits lost to Alpine Pipers 3-15 (Sindarov drew with Carlsen; Nihal drew with Anish; Dubov lost to Vidit; Bibisara drew with Divya; Sarasadat lost to Humpy; Maurizzi lost to Murzin).

Triveni Continental Kings bt Alaskan Knights 11-6 (Firouzja drew with Anand; Yi bt Arjun; Aravindh bt Yagiz Kaan; Jiner lost to Lagno; Kosteniuk bt Batsiashvili; Pranav drew with Abhimanyu).



Clash of titans: Anand was involved in an interesting game with Carlsen before losing on time. SUDHAKARA JAIN



Carlsen. FILE PHOTO: ALLEN EGENUSE J.

Chess in India is massive, says Carlsen

P.K. Ajith Kumar
BENGALURU

Ahead of the Global Chess League, Magnus Carlsen had joked about how his team, Alpine APL Pipers, had done during his absence last year and hoped that it would not do worse this time. He should be pleased now.

Pipers have gone top of the table despite Carlsen not being at his best so far.

He has won only one of his four games – against his old rival Viswanathan Anand, and that too on time – but his teammates K. Humpy and Vidit Gujrathi have been doing rather well.

The two Indians are, in fact, the best performing players in the league at the moment, both winning three of their games.

“The team is doing fantastic,” Carlsen said. “Three wins out of four is great. My performance has been a bit underwhelming, but since the team is doing well. I am happy. It is nice to see good crowds here. Chess in India is massive.”

SNAPSHOTS

From Duleep to Thimmappiah... the Karun story

BENGALURU: Karun Nair scored a century for KSCA Secretary's XI against Chhattisgarh State Cricket Sangh on the first day of their Dr. (Capt.) K. Thimmappiah memorial tournament match here on Monday.

Karun was part of the South Zone squad for the Duleep Trophy, but could not find a place in the XI for the semifinal here and the ongoing final against East Zone in Chennai.

South Zone coach Vikram Verma told reporters in Chennai on Monday that Karun left the squad due to "personal reasons."

"He went (home) for personal reasons. He mailed and took permission," said Vikram.

Vikram stated that Karun was left out in order to accommodate a left-hand batter. "We went with a good combination because every team has two left-arm spinners. So we thought a left-hand batter in the middle-order would give him a chance to dominate them. We thought what is best for the team," Vikram said.

Super-sub Gatti helps Juventus hold Milan

MILAN: Federico Gatti came off the bench and scored an injury-time equaliser as Juventus snatched a 1-1 draw with AC Milan in Serie A.

The result: Serie A: Juventus 1 (Gatti 90+2) drew with Milan 1 (Cisse 68).

Abhinandh wins title

CHENNAI: Top seed P.B. Abhinandh clinched the boys' u-19 title, defeating Damian Floro of Slovakia



Abhinandh, left, and Rithvik (Heartfulness IS, 5/16).

11-5, 11-8, 11-9 in the final of the WTT Youth Contender Tunis II on Sunday.

Rithvik returns a five-for

Rithvik Shyam's five for 16 set up Heartfulness IS-A's seven-wicket win over PSBB-A (K.K. Nagar) in the TNCA City Schools under-14 tournament for the B. Somasundaram Trophy on Monday.

The scores: PSBB-A (K.K.Nagar) 106 in 27.5 overs (Atreya Hariharan 37, Rithvik Shyam 5/16, H. Sai Sabarrees 3/19) lost to Heartfulness IS-A 107/3 in 24.2 overs (H. Sai Sabarrees 45, M. Yuthistra 39 n.o.).

Vidya Mandir 156/5 in 29 overs (P. Ashwath Narayanan 92) bt KRM PS 89/7 in 29 overs (Vrishn 3/10). Don Bosco-A 159/6 in 30 overs (Saif Ali 37, G. Sarvesh 41) bt Sir Mutha-A 75 in 25.4 overs.

Govt. HSS (West Mambalam) 152/6 in 30 overs (R. Sharwincochelvan 34, M. Sudhan 32) bt Sunshine SSS 41 in 19.3 overs (A. Prithinsh 3/12).

SBOA S&JC 68 in 23.4 overs (C. Sharath Kumar 31, Srejith Arunkumar 3/10) lost to Ramachandraa PS-A 72/1 in 5.1 overs (Y.P. Kavin Nandan 42 n.o.).

Vaels IS 187/5 in 30 overs (S. Shlokshan 54, Delrick Sachin 71) bt MCC MHSS 77 in 21.1 overs.

Shradha Children's Academy 126/9 in 30 overs (Ayan Krithik 43, K. Yadhuraj 37, Yuvan Mardia 3/12) lost to Bhavan's Rajaji Vidhyashram 127/3 in 17.3 overs (Yuvan Sehul Shah 34, Abhilash Gopu 50).

Chettinad Vidyashram-A 46/6 in 14 overs lost to Heartfulness IS NIOS 47/2 in 12.2 overs.

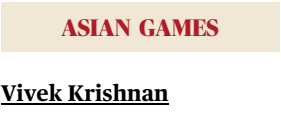
Nellai Nadar MHSS 83 in 28.4 overs lost to PSBB Millennium-B 84/2 in 15.4 overs (V. Thanish 41 n.o.).



Encore beckons? This will be the Indian cricket team's second appearance at the Asian Games, having pocketed gold in 2023. FILE PHOTO

For cricket to grow, it has to be played everywhere: Gavaskar

The continental competition provides a unique opportunity for India's stars to mingle with athletes from other sports; the 77-year-old hopes that the Men in Blue savour the experience



Vivek Krishnan

In an unrelenting cricket calendar where monotony can set in over run-of-the-mill bilateral assignments, a multi-disciplinary event like the Asian Games holds the promise of a novel offering.

The competition provides a unique opportunity for India's high-profile cricketers to mingle with athletes from other sports whilst attempting to win gold for the nation.

Shreyas Iyer & Co. will be looking to do just that when they travel to Japan for the continental spectacle's T20 tournament from September 24 to October 3.



Gavaskar. FILE PHOTO

This will be the Indian cricket team's second appearance at the Asian Games, having pocketed gold in Hangzhou, China, in 2023.

Sunil Gavaskar hopes the Men in Blue savour the experience of a multi-sport carnival. "You get to know

and talk to athletes from other sports, and get to know what makes them tick. It will be a wonderful experience," he said during a virtual media interaction.

Though reports have emerged of the arrangements in Japan for the cricketers not being up to scratch, Gavaskar emphasised that such obstacles shouldn't dissuade the game's stakeholders from exploring newer markets.

"If cricket has to become a global sport, it has to be played in different parts of the world. At the Olympics, for example, you could play in a city where cricket isn't generally played. You might not always get the best facilities," the 77-year-old opined.

"For the game to grow, I

would encourage them to play wherever possible."

If cricket is to pique the curiosity of spectators at the Asian Games, the boy wonder that is Vaibhav Sooryavanshi will have to show up. The spunky 15-year-old, who cracked two half-centuries against Zimbabwe after a baptism by fire against England, will hope to continue his upward flight.

"Look in T20 cricket, you can't expect consistency. Vaibhav is the kind of batter who can win you three or four out of 10 games. But he's somebody with whom we need to have patience," assessed Gavaskar.

(Watch cricket at Asian Games 2026 on Sony Sports and Sony LIV from September 17).

Arshi, Zidaan, Hridaan, Akshat drive to glory

Sports Bureau

Nine-year-old Arshi Gupta secured maximum points in the Mini Max class in the fifth round, to win the ME-CO-FMSCI Indian National karting championship RMC India 2026 in Bengaluru on Sunday. Zidaan Arshaan Anees and Akshat Misra, both of Peregrine Racing, topped the Micro Max and Senior Max categories respectively. Hridaan Sanadhya of Crest Motorsports emerged winner in the Junior Max class.

Provisional results: Senior Max: Finals (17 laps): 1. Akshat Misra (Peregrine Racing) 15mins, 51.277secs, 2. Eshanth Vengatesan (MSPORT) 15:56.416, 3. Aahil Mecklai (Rayo Racing) 15:57.954.

Pre-Finals (14 laps): 1. Akshat 13:11.439, 2. Rohaan Madesh (Peregrine) 13:12.760, 3. Eshanth (13:13.459). **Best Rookie:**

Eshanth. **Junior Max: Finals (16 laps):** 1. Hridaan Sanadhya (Crest Motorsports) 14:58.444, 2. Rivaan Dev Preetham (MSPORT) 15:02.265, 3. Hamza Balasinorwala (Crest) 15:04.813. **Pre-Finals (14 laps):** 1. Hridaan 13:12.488, 2. Swarnav Das (Crest) 13:15.148, 3. Rishik Rohit Reddy (MSPORT) 13:15.975. **Best Rookie:** Rivaan.

Mini Max: Finals (14 laps): 1. Arshi Gupta (Leapfrog Racing) 13:31.660, 2. Ridhaan Anil Kumarr (Red Rabbit Racing) 13:39.733, 3. Shivneel Karthikeyan (MSPORT) 13:39.854. **Pre-Finals (12 laps):** 1. Arshi 11:34.763, 2. Ridhaan 11:41.565, 3. Shiv Tummala (Peregrine) 11:42.876. **Best Rookie:** Arshi. **Micro Max: Finals (12 laps):** 1. Zidaan Arshaan Anees (Peregrine) 12:09.957, 2. Rudrapratap Singh Shekhawat (Leapfrog) 12:10.710, 3. Ayansh Patil (MSPORT) 12:14.196. **Pre-Finals (12 laps):** 1. Zidaan 12:08.459, 2. Ayansh 12:08.797, 3. Rudrapratap 12:16.055. **Best Rookie:** Shriyan Rao Thakkallapelly (Peregrine).



Happy bunch: Young champs Hridaan, Arshi, Zidaan and Akshat.

LIVE TELECAST	ENGAGEMENTS
▼ Duleep Trophy (final): Day 3, JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m. Women's T20 Asia Cup: Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 8 p.m. US Open: SS Select 1, 2 & JioHotstar, 8.30 p.m. & 4.30 a.m. (Wednesday) Champions League: Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 10.15 p.m. & 12.30 a.m. (Wednesday).	Cricket: Duleep Trophy final (day three), South Zone vs. East Zone, 9.30 a.m., MAC Stadium; TNCA-B. Somasundaram Trophy u-14 City schools tournament, Ebenezer MHSS vs. PSBB-A, Nungambakkam (OCF); Bhavan's Rajaji Vidyashram vs. Heartfulness IS NIOS (Gojan), 8 a.m.; Vaels IS vs. The PSBB Millennium-B, Gerugambakkam, Gojan (mat.), 1 p.m.

AROUND THE CITY



One for the album: The winners of the TNTTA State-ranking table tennis tournament. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Tharun and Ananya clinch titles

S. Tharun (RTTHPC) defeated S. Preyesh (S. Rly.) 11-9, 11-8, 6-11, 11-9, 13-11 in the men's final of the fifth TNTTA State-ranking table tennis tournament on Monday.

M. Ananya (Chennai Achievers) overcame Selena Deepthi (RTTHPC) 11-3, 11-13, 11-9, 11-8, 5-11, 11-8 in the women's title decider.

Dr. Muthiah Ramaswamy, Chairman, Chettinad Group, gave away the prizes.

Other results (finals):

Boys: U-19: Akshay Bhushan (Chennai) bt S. Mehan (Chennai Achievers) 11-6, 11-6, 5-11, 11-6, 11-6; **U-17:** K. Akshay Bhushan bt Vishruth Ramakrishnan (MST) 11-9, 12-10, 11-8; **U-15:** Sanjay Arwindh (SK Academy) bt M.

Ashvajith (SK Academy) 11-8, 11-5, 6-11, 11-7; **U-13:** R. Sujeth (Bestshot TTA) bt Siddharth Adhithyan (SSHI) 3-11, 8-11, 11-6, 11-7, 11-8; **U-11:** T.K. Akshath (Dronacharya TTA) bt M. Nibhish (SKJ-Salem) 9-11, 11-4, 6-11, 11-5, 11-4; **U-9:** S. Adhvik (MAK Chandra TTA) bt Divit Jain (SK Academy) 9-11, 11-6, 11-6, 11-4.

Girls: U-19: M. Hansini (Chennai) bt R. Mercy (ACE TTA) 4-11, 6-11, 14-12, 11-5, 11-4, 11-4; **U-17:** R. Mercy bt B. Varnica (SSA-ERD) 12-10, 11-6, 11-7; **U-15:** B. Varnica bt Samyra Rajesh (ITTC) 11-7, 11-6, 12-10; **U-13:** N. Sahana (Beshtshot TTA) bt Ujjayini Niyogi (RTTHPC) 11-7, 12-10, 5-11, 8-11, 12-10; **U-11:** H. Dhiya (Bestshot TTA) bt D. Lathikasree (BTTA) 11-5, 11-7, 11-8; **U-9:** Sharadha Ramakrishnan (MST) bt Yanthi (Coimbatore) 5-11, 15-13, 5-11, 11-4, 11-6. **Veteran:** G. Vinodh (SRSA) bt L. Vigneshwaran (SSHI) 11-8, 6-11, 11-9, 11-4. **Corporate:** J. Arunkumar (Chennai) bt J. Sriram (Towers Club TTA) 11-4, 11-9, 11-6.



The best: Besant Nagar Club, which clinched the RWD Open Chennai City club league-cum-knockout tennis championship.

Besant Nagar triumphs

Besant Nagar Club beat Gandhi Nagar Club-A 48-23 in the final of the RWD Open Chennai City club league-cum-knockout tennis championship.

Chennai Open golf from today

The Chennai Open 2026, a DP World Professional Golf Tour of India (PGTI) event, will be held at the TNGF Cosmo Golf Course from September 8 to 11. The fifth edition of the tournament, carrying a prize purse of ₹1 crore, will feature leading professionals, including Saptak Talwar, defending champion N. Thangaraja of Sri Lanka, Veer Ahlawat, Om Prakash Chouhan, Manu Gandas, Khalin Joshi, Rashid Khan,

Honey Baisoya, and Akshay Sharma. Chennai-based S. Prasanth, S. John Royan, C. Ilayaraja, and C. Arul will lead the local challenge.

TFA sub-junior trials from Sept. 8 to 10

Tamil Nadu Football Association (TFA) will conduct selection trials for the State sub-junior boys' team, for the AIFF National championship 2026-27, from September 8 to 10 at Migros Kids MHSS (Kaniyampoondi), Tiruppur.

Those born between January 1, 2013, and December 31, 2014, are eligible to take part in the trials.

Contact Sakthi (96296 75533) or Ganesh (98946 39189).

Nonpareil lives up to the billing in Khammam Plate

HYDERABAD: Trainer D. Netto's ward Nonpareil, ridden by Akshay Kumar, won the Khammam Plate, the chief event of Monday's (Sept. 7) races.

The winner is owned by Mr. Rajendran rep. Rapar's Galloping Stars LLP, M/s. Tripuraniven-kata Aditya Chowdary & P. Ranga Raju. Akshay Kumar rode two more winners on the day.

1. CHAITANYA CHAKRAM PLATE (1,400M): CLASSY TOUCH (Neeraj Rawal) 1, French Lieutenant (Antony Raj) 2, Ashwa Jaffna (Gaurav) 3 and Evansville (P. Sai K) 4. 1-1/2, 4 3/4 and 1-1/2. Im, 25.78s. ₹15 (w), 11, 12 and 19 (p). SHP: 41, THP: 35, FP: 49, Q: 34, Tanala: 110. Favourite: Classy Touch. Owners: M/s. Narendra V. Shah, N. Shyam Sunder, Anil V. Poduval, Meher K. Sunderji & Suyash U. Dalvi.

Trainer: Neellesh Rawal.

2. KHAMMAM PLATE (1,800M): NONPAREIL (Akshay Kumar) 1, Winfield (Antony Raj) 2, N R I Suppower (D.S. Deora) and Get Lucky (Md. Ekram) 4. 1-1/4, 3 and 2-3/4. Im, 51.20s. ₹13 (w), 10, 10 and 21 (p). SHP: 18, THP: 37, FP: 19, Q: 16, Tanala: 67. Favourite: Nonpareil. Owners: Mr. Rajendran rep. Rapar's Galloping Stars LLP, M/s. Tripuraniven-kata Aditya Chowdary & P. Ranga Raju. Trainer: D. Netto.

3. MAHABUBNAGAR PLATE (DIV. I) (1,200M): ANNHILATOR (Akshay Kumar) 1, Knight Crusader (B.R. Kumar) 2, Glorious Power (M.S. Deora) 3 and Decoy (Shivam) 4. 2, 1/2 and 2. Im, 13.79s. ₹17 (w), 11, 19 and 33 (p). SHP: 27, THP: 81, FP: 38, Q: 27, Tanala: 664. Favourite: Annihilator. Owners: M/s. Srikanth

Badruka, Rama Seshu Eyunni & Prabhakar Chowdary Tripuraneni. Trainer: D. Netto.

4. MANCHERIAL PLATE (1,600M): HOPING HIGH (Mohit Singh) 1, Only My Way (Afroz K) 2, Sunny Day (P. Ajeeth K) 3 and Secret Option (Akshay K) 4. 2, Neck and 2. Im, 42.87s. ₹39 (w), 14, 12 and 10 (p). SHP: 103, THP: 52, FP: 666, Q: 477, Tanala: 1,451. Favourite: Sunny Day. Owner: Mr. Vipin Kalra. Trainer: Jasbir Singh.

5. BHADRACHALAM TROPHY (1,200M): POLE STAR (Akshay Kumar) 1, Sharanga (Abhay Singh) 2, Flying Fury (G. Nares) 3 and Dubai Touch (M.S. Deora) 4. Not run: Colt Pistol. Neck, Neck and 2. Im, 13.74s. ₹20 (w), 15, 49 and 19 (p). SHP: 88, THP: 57, FP: 325, Q: 189, Tanala: 1,266. Favourite: Pole Star. Owners: Mr. Rajendran rep.

Rapar's Galloping Stars LLP., Mr. & Mrs. Shapoor P. Mistry rep. Manjiri Horse Breeders Farm Pvt. Ltd., & M/s. Ram H. Shroff & Raj H. Shroff rep. Stride Livestock Pvt. Ltd. Trainer: A. Imran Khan.

6. MAHABUBNAGAR PLATE (DIV. II) (1,200M): HIGH SPEED DIVE (Rafique Sk.) 1, Ragnarök (Shivam) 2, Gloria (Antony Raj) 3 and Exclusive Black (Akshay K) 4. 4, Head and 1-1/2. Im, 12. 99s. ₹34 (w), 24, 13 and 10 (p). SHP: 38 THP: 44, FP: 84, Q: 49, Tanala: 341. Favourite: Ragnarök. Owner: Mr. Kothapally Phani Krishna. Trainer: B. Mukesh Kumar.

Jackpot: 70%: ₹6, 295 (77 tkts.) & 30%: 252 (823 tkts.).

Mini Jackpot: 3,145 (21 tkts.).

Treble: (i) 70 (483 tkts.), (ii) 656 (56 tkts.).

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A CH-CE

R. Kaushik

The Cambridge Dictionary defines *introspection* as the *examination of and attention to your own ideas, thoughts, and feelings*.

Introspection must be a ruthlessly honest endeavour. It's not an exercise to impress others but to look inwards, reflect on what one is and what needs to be done to become the best version of oneself. It calls for taking ownership of one's actions, of accepting mistakes and errors, if any, and of zealously working towards eradicating those mistakes and making amends, if so required.

There is no better example in Indian cricket of the use of introspection as a self-betterment tool than Ishan Kishan, the pocket-sized dynamite who has embarked on a sensational journey of reinvention that has made him one of the hottest properties, if only in the white-ball ecosystem for the time being.

To say that, at the beginning of 2026, his international career was at a crossroads will be a mild understatement. The destructive left-hander had worked himself out of favour as he allowed frustration, if not petulance, to get the better of him.

Overlooked from all three international playing XIs in the interest of team requirements and balance despite having done little wrong, Kishan took a leave of absence midway through the tour of South Africa in 2023-24, citing the need for a mental reset.

In choppy waters

But when he refused to obey the diktats of the Board of Control for Cricket in India and made himself unavailable to play domestic cricket for Jharkhand despite practising for IPL 2024, which was imminent, he found himself in choppy waters. In an unequivocal warning, the BCCI stripped him of his central contract - as it did with current T20I captain Shreyas Iyer. The unsaid message was clear - don't take anything for granted.

Kishan had one of two paths to choose - wallow in self-pity, rail at the injustice of it all and allow himself to go to seed, or smell the coffee, accept that he had done himself no favours and wake up to the reality that if he aspired to represent the country again, he would have to not just produce the runs expected of him but to reiterate without any scope for doubt that he had learned his lesson.

The Jharkhandi did all that and more. He was outstanding in domestic cricket

across formats, not just batting with flair and keeping with assurance but also slipping effortlessly into the role of a leader. His tactical acumen revealed itself time and again, manifesting in a maiden domestic title - the 20-over Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy - last season with the captain himself starring in the final with a brazen century.

As India grappled with opening woes ahead of the home T20 World Cup, where they would be defending the title won in Bridgetown under Rohit Sharma in June 2024,

Kishan suddenly emerged as a very obvious and viable option. That the mandarins occupying the corridors of power had forgiven him became obvious when Suryakumar Yadav, the skipper, called up the younger man and asked him if he would win the team the World Cup.

Clearly, it wasn't a call Suryakumar made on his own. He would have consulted his bosses before approaching Kishan during a brief but very pithy chat. "*Chhotu, World Cup jitayega?*" the captain asked the wicketkeeper-batter, who responded with, "*Bharosa karogey?*" (Will you trust me?). Suryakumar's reply was instantaneous - "*Chal, kiya*" (Done). And just like that, Kishan was back in favour, back in business, back doing what he loves the most.

Celebrating the reintegration

Needless to say, Kishan kept up his end of the bargain. He celebrated his reintegration with international cricket with scores of 76, 28 and 103 in his second, third and fourth outings back, against New Zealand in India's final engagement before the World Cup. All these knocks came at No. 3, but with Sanju Samson suddenly blowing cold, he was thrust into the role of the opener-wicketkeeper at the World Cup, where he reeled off 20, 61, 77, 18 and 0 in the first five fixtures.

However, India were unable to get off to meaningful starts as opponents started to exploit the all-left opening salvo with off-spinners of varying quality.

Abhishek Sharma was in the middle of a horror run and therefore to break up the monotony of two left-handers, the think-tank took a punt on Samson, brought him back as opener and stumper and pushed Kishan down to No. 3 from the Super Eight fixture against Zimbabwe onwards. Samson came to the party with breathtaking knocks in the last three matches, including in the semis against England and the final against New Zealand, but Kishan didn't seem the drop

Listening to Kishan speak over the past few months is an eye-opening experience. One can see the deep impact of losing the central contract and finding himself in the dumps, but one can also easily make out that he has now become a more mature, grounded and realistic human being

Kishan 2.0 – a sensational reinvention

Having made giant strides, the southpaw, who struck a double-hundred in the Duleep final, could not have asked for a better start to the First Class season



R.V. MOORTHY

to one-down with 38 (24b), 10 (6), 39 (18) and a whirlwind 25-ball 54 in the title clash.

Chhotu did help Suryakumar lift the World Cup, but while his fortunes have continued to be on the upswing, the man who created history by becoming the first to oversee a successful title-retention campaign was immediately dumped without so much as a thank you.

His T20I heroics have brought Kishan back into the ODI mix as well. In June, he marked his comeback with a frenetic 125, off a mere 79 deliveries, against Afghanistan in Lucknow, in what was just his second 50-over international in 32 months. By this time, he had led Sunrisers Hyderabad for the first half of IPL 2026, with regular skipper Pat Cummins travelling with the squad but not cleared to enter the fray by Cricket Australia.

Even though he knew that he was only keeping the seat warm for the Australian Test and ODI skipper, Kishan wasn't a stand-in captain in the strictest sense. He brought his tactical acumen and man-management skills into play, led from the front and left the team in a good space - and handily placed to make a charge for the playoffs - when the Aussie reassumed charge.

Cummins was quick at every opportunity to laud Kishan's leadership skills in his absence, their mutual respect apparent from the repeated discussions the nominated captain had with the man who had led in his absence when the two were reunited on the field of play for the second half of the season.

Distinct and stated desire

Kishan isn't merely content with white-ball laurels, though. At least among Indian batters, there is a distinct and stated desire to represent the country in

Test cricket. Tilak Varma, the gifted 23-year-old, said as much on the eve of the ongoing Duleep Trophy final, where he is leading South Zone against Kishan's East.

Tilak has made a name for himself as an exuberant, new-age T20 player, a reputation that has landed him the vice-captaincy of the national side, and it won't be long before he becomes a 50-over certainty too. But he is consumed by the ambition to play for the country in the five-day format.

Since debuting in the Ranji Trophy for Hyderabad when he was only 16 years old, the rangy left-hander has stacked up an average of 55.77 from 24 First Class matches. He has often been unable to represent his state in the red-ball game because invariably, India's players are involved in some T20 outing or the other during the Ranji Trophy, but it's only a matter of time before Tilak gatecrashes the Test side as well.

In that race, he has Kishan for company and competition. Obviously, the shorter man is considerably older than Tilak and has greater experience of first-class cricket - 66 matches before the Duleep final, an average of just under 40 and nine hundreds with a best of 273. Kishan's red-ball quest is anything but straightforward.

The effervescent Rishabh Pant is the designated wicketkeeper-batter who is relishing his second coming at the international level after a long break following his terrible car accident in December 2022, while Dhruv Jurel has stolen a significant march as the gloveman-in-waiting.

Jurel's Test debut came when Pant was recuperating from a series of surgeries, and he immediately caught the eye with his agility and compactness behind the sticks and his composure and technique

in front of it. In only his second Test, he steered the team to a tense victory in Ranchi in the company of current skipper Shubman Gill and has stacked up two centuries in his last seven Tests.

How highly he is rated by the leadership group is evidenced by the fact that he is in the Test XI as a specialist batter, occupying the No. 6 position so that he can split left-handers Pant and Ravindra Jadeja.

His last Test knock was a flowing unbeaten 115 in Colombo a fortnight back and even though he is widely regarded as a terrific player of spin, it is hard to see him being dislodged when India play their next Test, in seam-friendly Wellington in November.

Work cut out

Kishan knows therefore that he has his work cut out, but no one also knows better than him that hard work can take you places you had never imagined were accessible. His statement-making double-hundred in the Duleep final in Chepauk is exactly the kind of start to the domestic First Class season he would have envisaged, and one can rest assured that when he is not on India white-ball duty, he will torment bowlers whilst masterminding Jharkhand's fortunes in a leadership capacity.

Listening to Kishan speak over the last few months is a refreshing, eye-opening experience. One can see the deep impact of losing the central contract and finding himself in the dumps, but one can also easily make out that he has now become a more mature, grounded and realistic human being who has still retained his innate impishness and the slant towards mischief. Clarity of thought is evident every time he opens his mouth, a clarity that is a spillover from his awareness in the middle.

In Ishan Kishan's fall from grace and his willingness to not just climb back on the horse but become a champion jockey again is a shining example of the wonders self-belief and commitment to the cause can catalyse. The intelligent young man is no longer chasing shadows or slaying inner demons. More power to him.

THE GIST

Kishan's T20I heroics have brought him back into the ODI mix. In June, he marked his comeback with a frenetic 125 against Afghanistan in Lucknow, in what was just his second 50-over international in 32 months

The southpaw isn't merely content with white-ball laurels, though. He knows that he has his work cut out, but no one knows better than him that hard work can take you places you had never imagined

In recent times, one can see the deep impact of the batter losing the central contract and finding himself in the dumps, but one can also easily make out that he has now become a more mature, grounded and realistic human being



R. RAGU



EMMANUAL YOGINI

Neelima Vallangi

CM

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Amount unveiled by EU chief for Greenland package

232 in \$ million. European Commission president Ursula von der Leyen unveiled on Monday a 200-million-euro (\$232 million) investment package for Greenland, as the EU seeks to boost its relations with the island. “Greenland can count on the EU,” she said. AP

Teachers who launched a sit-in over recruitment

1,000 Over 1,000 teachers who lost their jobs following court rulings launched a sit-in outside the West Bengal Education Department headquarters, ‘Bikash Bhavan’, on Monday, demanding that the State government expedite their recruitment. PTI

Number of names deleted from Mizoram electoral rolls after SIR

78,442 Mizoram’s electoral rolls underwent a significant change during the SIR exercise, with 78,442 names deleted and 39,243 new electors added, taking the state’s final voter count to 8.35 lakh, a senior official said on Monday. PTI

Decline in road accidents in U.P. under ZFD scheme

6.97 in per cent. Uttar Pradesh recorded a 6.97% decline in road accidents, an 8.03% fall in fatalities, and a 6.11% reduction in injuries at locations covered under the Zero Fatality District scheme between January and August this year, police said on Monday. PTI

Persons booked for drunk driving in Keralam

2,799 The police in Keralam registered cases against 2,799 people for allegedly driving under the influence of alcohol during a week-long special drive across the State, a police spokesman said on Monday. PTI
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Are nicotine pouches beyond the law?

Does COTPA cover nicotine pouches? Why are they not covered by the law banning vapes? Could nicotine pouches be treated as food under Indian law? Can they be legally imported into India? Can nicotine pouches be sold at duty-free shops?

EXPLAINER

Murali Neelakantan

The story so far:

A new study led by the ICMR-National Institute of Cancer Prevention and Research has found that nicotine pouches are reaching Indian cities through online platforms, hookah shops and gig delivery services. The study comes after a warning from the World Health Organization in May 2026 about the dangers these products pose. Yet it is far from settled which Indian law, if any, governs them.

What are nicotine pouches?

A nicotine pouch is a small, tobacco-free, tea-bag-like sack containing nicotine, flavourings and plant-based fibres. Users place the pouch between the lip and gum for up to an hour, allowing nicotine to be absorbed directly into the bloodstream without smoke, vapour or spitting.

Does COTPA cover nicotine pouches?

The Cigarettes and Other Tobacco Products Act, 2003 (COTPA) governs the marketing, advertising and sale of cigarettes and other tobacco products. But its definition of tobacco products does not extend to all products containing nicotine. Had the legislature intended to cover every extract of the tobacco plant, it could have said so. Restrictions on the freedom of trade and commerce must be strictly construed and since nicotine pouches are not among the products listed in the Cigarettes Act, they fall outside it.

Are they regulated by the Drugs Act?

Nicotine is not listed as a drug in any schedule of the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940. Nicotine patches and gums have, however, been approved as drugs by the Drug Controller General of India for therapeutic use in treating nicotine addiction. Schedule K under the Drugs and Cosmetics Rules, 1945 lists gums and lozenges and exempts them from licensing and prescription requirements if they contain less than 2 mg of nicotine.

If nicotine were not considered a drug



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at all, there would be no reason to exempt certain nicotine products in Schedule K. The very fact that only some nicotine products are exempted suggests that all others are meant to be regulated by the Drugs Act.

Against this, pouches are arguably unlike patches and gums. They make no therapeutic claim and do not purport to treat addiction; they are a substitute for cigarettes. On this reading, they do not qualify as drugs under the Drugs Act.

Why are they not covered by the law banning vapes?

The import and sale of vapes is banned by the Prohibition of Electronic Cigarettes Act, 2019 (“PECA”). If vapes were drugs, no separate legislation would have been needed: the government could have regulated them, or refused licences, under the Drugs Act. The enactment of PECA therefore suggests that the Drugs Act did not give it adequate power to ban them. Nicotine pouches are different from vapes: they contain no electronic device and produce neither smoke nor vapour. They are consequently not covered by PECA.

Could pouches be treated as food?

The Prevention of Food Adulteration Act and the Food Safety and Standards Act define food broadly: any processed, partially processed or unprocessed substance intended for human consumption. Court rulings on supari and chewing tobacco establish that the

definition has a very wide amplitude, encompassing items that are chewed rather than swallowed. It is arguable, then, that nicotine pouches could fall within the broad definition of food.

Can pouches be imported into India?

Import restrictions flow from two statutes: the Foreign Trade (Development and Regulation) Act, 1992 and the Customs Act, 1962. The Foreign Trade Act empowers the Central government to prohibit, restrict or regulate imports; the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) administers this and publishes the ITC-HS classification listing which goods are free, restricted or banned. Section 11 of the Customs Act allows the government to prohibit goods wholly or partly by notification, on grounds that include the protection of human, animal or plant life.

After the World Customs Organization updated the Harmonized System, a sub-category was introduced for oral nicotine products that do not involve combustion: 2404 91 30 covers tobacco-free single-use pouches of the Zyn or Lyft type, and 2404 91 90 covers other oral nicotine products not meant for therapeutic uses. These replaced a residual category for other manufactured tobacco substitutes; the codes for medicaments apply only where a product is strictly a cessation aid. Under the DGFT schedule and the rules of the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs, goods under 2404 91 30 are “restricted”.

Unlike “free” items, they cannot be cleared merely on payment of duty, and unlike “prohibited” e-cigarettes, they are not banned outright – but they require a specific licence or permission. In deciding, the DGFT cross-references the health and other ministries.

What about duty-free shops?

Nicotine pouches are currently available at a few duty-free stores at Indian airports. Such stores are licensed under Section 58 of the Customs Act and cannot claim to be entirely outside Indian law.

It is sometimes said that a duty-free shop lies outside the territory of India, and that it is the passenger who imports the goods on crossing customs control. In *Flemingo Duty Free Shop Pvt. Ltd. v. Shri Kaushik Bhattacharya* (2024), the Calcutta High Court held that a duty-free store did not “import” goods into India, being deemed to be located outside it for the purposes of the Customs Act, and that legal metrology labelling requirements therefore did not apply. This should not be read to mean no Indian law applies to duty-free shops. If no Indian law applied to stores, could they stock arms and ammunition? If a crime was committed in a duty free store, which court would have jurisdiction to try the case? Which police station would have jurisdiction to register a case? That would be just too absurd.

Cigarettes, alcohol, jewellery, watches, food and small electronic items are some of the goods permitted at duty-free shops. Nicotine pouches are not – unless one can argue they are food. Given their customs classification as restricted, it is unlikely that any import licence has been granted.

What is the legal position?

The legal position is intricate, but the remedy is not. A notification under the Customs Act and the Foreign Trade Act banning the import and sale of nicotine pouches on health grounds would take minutes to issue. If the government moves as slowly as it did with vapes, pouches will become fashionable, and demand will settle in. A ban notified after that point will only produce smuggling on the scale we now see with vapes and cause damage to health that will be hard to mitigate. *(Murali Neelakantan is a lawyer)*

THE GIST

▼ Nicotine pouches are not covered by COTPA or PECA, while their status under the Drugs Act is debatable. They could also arguably fall within the broad definition of food

▼ Tobacco-free, single-use nicotine pouches require a specific licence or permission under the DGFT’s ITC-HS classification; they are not prohibited outright like e-cigarettes

▼ The government can prohibit their import and sale on health grounds. Delaying action could lead to established demand and smuggling, as seen with vapes

What could have prompted the latest hike in LPG prices?

How are under-recoveries shaping LPG pricing, and what could be its wider impact?

Saptaparno Ghosh

The story so far:

After two successive months of decline in LPG prices, oil-marketing companies hiked prices of the commercial variant of the bottled hydrocarbon gas by approximately ₹10 per cylinder across the country on September 1. The 19-kg cylinder in Delhi now costs ₹2,747.5 per cylinder whilst the price of the 14.2-kg cylinder remains unchanged.

What is the latest price hike about?

Industry observers state the latest hike in the commercial segment primarily caters to offset the under-recoveries (that is, the losses OMCs incur because of the difference in prices at which they sell to consumers against the price they should receive for meeting the cost of

production and distribution) for the domestic segment.

The latest government data reported that India’s State-owned oil-marketing companies were incurring under-recoveries of ₹188 per domestic cylinder in early August, down from ₹500 per cylinder in July and more than ₹700 per cylinder in June. According to data, the packaged domestic segment accounted for 90.4% of all LPG consumption in the country during April and June this year. Further, about 10.6 crore Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala scheme beneficiaries – approximately 33% of the domestic segment – receive an additional subsidy of ₹300 per cylinder.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Prashant Vashist, senior vice president and co-group head, corporate sector ratings, at ratings agency ICRA, said, “At present,

the under-recovery on domestic LPG cylinders is hovering at about ₹200 per cylinder. Thus, the latest hike potentially tries to somewhat compensate for that amount, although the proportionate sales of commercial LPG are much smaller [compared to the domestic variant]. I would not read much into it”.

What does the supply situation look like?

On the supply side, imports of petroleum, oil and lubricants (POL) products registered a decline of 45.1% between April and July this year, according to data from the government’s Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC). It attributed this to “reduction in imports of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), pet coke and fuel oil (FO) etc.”

However, essential to note that India’s oil-marketing companies ramped up their

daily production of bottled hydrocarbon gas from 34,000 metric tonnes to 55,000 metric tonnes to offset the impact of lower imports. Further, following an August 13 directive, India’s upstream companies, along with private and public oil-marketing companies have been set a daily production target of 63,810 metric tonnes.

Are we looking at a potential impact?

Speaking to *The Hindu* earlier, Manpreet Singh, treasurer at the National Restaurants Association of India, said the impact of the latest hike, standalone, would be “negligible” although it may prompt concerns about price increases in the future.

Although it is essential to note the impact from the industrial segment, which requires bottled hydrocarbon gas to run their furnaces, such as in the glass-making industry and elevated demand is expected to seep in because of the festive season. However, the segment too is increasingly transitioning to piped natural gas, seeking secure and consistent supplies. According to data from the Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB), industrial sales of piped gas increased by 30% between April and June this year compared to the same period last year.

THE GIST

▼ Commercial LPG prices rose by about ₹10 per cylinder as OMCs seek to offset domestic LPG under-recoveries

▼ Lower imports are being offset by higher domestic production, while the impact on businesses is expected to be limited for now

